Wolf`s Guide to

Dharma Retreats & Teachings

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If you have a favorite place, guesthouse, or especially retreat center, please tell me about it! If you benefited from this guide and have visited meditation centers listed (or not listed) below, and can add some thoughts, please write.

Email me at aware.wolf.ko@gmail.com

As a fletcher makes straight their arrow,
a wise person directs
their unsteady thought,
which is difficult to guard,
difficult to hold back.
- Buddha, *The Dhammapada*

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Here's an extensive listing and often a review of dharma centers, retreat places, Ashrams, and monasteries. The Guide was started in 2017 and continues to be added to in 2025, although the pace has slowed down.

Post-Covid things seem to have returned to normal. Remember to do your own due diligence. Google prospective teachers, centers, and ashrams. Check current travel conditions.

If I went to Spahn Ranch on a weekend when the Manson family was staying there in the 1960s – I'd probably have a great time; Nondual teachings, Hippie chicks, music, and free drugs. What do I know.

UPDATE 2023: Retreats are back on the menu, boys!

India (and Asia) seems to have weathered Covid well enough. Centers, cafes, and guesthouses survived. Western Tourism may not be up to 2019 levels, but backpackers are returning.

Thailand eliminated requirements for covid documents, testing, and trip insurance.

Myanmar (Burma) had a military coup. The US State department recommends not traveling to Burma because of armed conflict and unlawful detentions. I'm not sure if Burmese meditation visas are being issued. Some monasteries and centers are not accepting foreign meditators or yogis.

Sri Lanka was also under a travel warning because of civil unrest but I've known some people who visited and now it seems fine.

Everything changes.
-- Suzuki Roshi

I've written a lot here, but my experience may not be your experience. Anything I feel about a center doesn't have to be what you feel and experience. Everything does change, as Suzuki Roshi says, and with time, these centers will change: teachers come and go; policies change; cooks are replaced. A center that was friendly, with top-notch instruction, and good food can become blase, with a new teacher who dislikes students, and a new cook whose speciality is bland faux pork ball soup with a side of Saltine crackers.

Remember YMMV : *Your Mileage May Vary*

This guide focuses a lot on India, but also covers some other countries in southeast Asia. If you're looking for places to do a retreat in South Asia, you've come to the right place

A book on meditation I recommend to people is Ashin Tejaniya's, *Don't Look Down on the Defilements: They Will Laugh At You*.

Available free here at his website:
https://ashintejaniya.org/books-dont-look-down-on-the-defilements

A good app I enjoy is Sam Harris's *Waking Up.*

Free thirty day link:

30-day guest pass
https://dynamic.wakingup.com/guestpass/SC311002E

If it's too expensive, *Waking Up* is generous on scholarships.

Here is a condensed list of many retreat centers. This list includes many centers I'm not really personally familiar with or added late and so may not be pointed out or mentioned in my narrative review later. Also in places like India the country is chock full of Ashrams. This list is hardly comprehensive. Once you're in country you'll naturally probably will find out through word of mouth other suitable places.

My top recommendations might be:

In Thailand:
Doi Suthep for a cooler retreat
Wat Pa Tam Wa

In Nepal:
Panditarama Lumbini

In Himachal Pradesh, India:
Tushita

Thosamling
Deer Park Bir

In Tamil Nadu, South India:
Bodhi Zendo
Auroville
Tiruvannamalai & Ramana Ashram

See below for a full review of these places.

My blacklist or Red Flagged (Places or Teachers I cannot recommend):
Any TWIM (Tranquil Wisdom Insight Meditation) teachings or teachers e.g., Delson Armstrong claims to be an Arahant, a perfected one. I like and recommend Deer Park in Bir India. Unfortunately Deer Park has hosted TWIM visiting teachers. Anyone claiming a high attainment, using a fancy-schmancy special title – should be looked at very skeptically (most likely they are a chucklefuck).

The Bhagavan's Arunachala Ashram, Wayanad Kerala, India.

Tiruvannamalai, Tamil Nadu has a circus of satangs. Some of whom don't seem sane, some have just overestimated their attainment, others are grifting.

Caveat Emptor
(Buyer Beware)

*

Those who awaken
Never rest in one place.
Like swans, they rise
And leave the lake.

On the air they rise
And fly an invisible course,
Gathering nothing, storing nothing.
Their food is knowledge.
They live upon emptiness.
They have seen how to break free.
– Dhammapapada

Listing of Dharma Retreat Centers and Teachings

India

Christopher Titmuss Vipassana Retreats. Sarnath. Yearly seven day retreats in January-February (Now India retreats canceled)

Radha Nicholson however also has a 7 day retreat in Bodhgaya India.

UPDATE: Christopher has stopped coming to India for yearly retreats. However Radha Nicholson is doing a yearly retreat in Bodhgaya. See her website here:

https://radhanicholson.com/

Recommended. Also people watch and meditate by the Bodhi Tree and enjoy a nice meal at Muhammad's.

Tushita. Dharamsala. Well regarded Introduction to Buddhism courses and Intermediate Buddhism courses. Popular place. Recommended.
http://tushita.info/

Tushita links to Dharma teachings around Dharamsala
http://tushita.info/links/buddhism-in-dharamsala/

Root Institute. Bodhgaya. Buddhism events and courses in season.
https://www.rootinstitute.ngo/

Iyengar Yoga Himalayan Center. Dharamkot.
https://www.hiyogacentre.com/en/the-centre/dharamkot-dharamsala.html

Universal Yoga. Dharamkot, Dharamsala.
http://vijaypoweryoga.site/

Deer Park. Bir. Buddhism Courses with visiting teachers.

http://deerpark.in/

Buddha Pala. Sister institute for Deer Park Bir. Kalimpong, West Bengal. New.
https://buddhapada.in/

Dharmalaya. Bir. Courses and Eco-type retreats.
http://dharmalaya.in/

Sherab Ling Monastery. Close to Bir. Independent retreat and occasional teachings and events.
https://www.palpung.org/english/news/default.asp

Thosamling Nunnery. Near Dharamsala. Shamatha Meditation weekends, guest teachers, and residential private retreats. Recommended.
http://thosamling.com/

Dongyu Gatsal Ling. Tenzin Palmo's nunnery. Independent women's retreat.
http://tenzinpalmo.com/

Sattal Christian Ashram.
http://sattalchristianashram.org/index.php

Haidakhan Babaji Ashram. Chhakhata Range, Uttarakhand. Near Haldwani. Excellent reviews.

Praguna Shala YogaSchool. Formerly Inteyoga. Hatha yoga ashram close to Mysore.
https://pysmysore.com

Prana Vashya Yoga. Mysore. Five star reviews.
http://www.pranavashya.com/

Bodhi zendo. Perumalmalai, outside of Kodaikanal, Tamil Nadu. Highly reviewed Zen retreat center. Highly Recommended.
http://www.bodhisangha.net/index.php/en/home/

Kanzeon Zendo, formerly Little Flower Zendo. Perumalmalai. Father Ama's Zen center for his students or those with a serious interest in Zen.
https://kanzeonzendo.in/

Bodhi Vanam. A new center. Near Bodhizendo & Kanzeon, Palani Rd. Tamil Nadu. Run by Ananda, an Osho, Zen, and Yoga etc teacher who teaches workshops here and in Auroville.
https://veda.bodhivanam.org

Shantivanam Christian Ashram. Trichy.

http://www.bedegriffiths.com/category/shantivanam/

Auroville. Near Pondicherry. Alternative & creative type community.
https://www.auroville.org/

Paramarthananda Satsangs, Chennai. See Google maps.
https://www.arshasampradaya.org/user/177

Vasanta Vihar. Krishnamurti foundation. Chennai.
https://www.jkrishnamurti.in/stay-on-campus/

Krishnamurti foundation Bangalore.
https://kfistudy.org

Sivananda Madurai Yoga Center.
http://sivananda.org.in/madurai/

Ramana Ashram. Tiruvanamalai.
https://www.sriramanamaharshi.org/ashram/

Anantha Niketan Ashram. Just outside of Tiruvanamalai. Events and retreats with visiting teachers.
http://www.srianantha niketan.com/

Amma's Ashram. Amritapuri, Kerala.
https://www.amritapuri.org/ashram

Anandashram. Kanhangad, Kerala.
http://www.anandashram.org/

Kurisumala Benedictine Ashram, Kerala
http://kurisumalaashram.in

Sat Darshan. Kottathara Kerala, Near Coimbatore. Relaxed schedule & Modeled after Bodhi Zendo. Great reviews.
https://satdarshan.org

Sadhguru's Ashram. Near Coimbatore, Tamil Nadu.
https://isha.sadhguru.org/in/en/center/isha-yoga-center-coimbatore

Dayananda Vedanta Ashram. Near Coimbatore, Tamil Nadu.
https://arshavidya.in/

Bihar School of Yoga. Munger, Bihar.
http://www.biharyoga.net/bihar-school-of-yoga/about-bsy/

Phool Chatti Yoga Ashram. Rishikesh.
https://www.phoolchattiyoga.com/

Anand Prakash Yoga Ashram. Rishikesh.
https://anandprakashyogaashram.com/

Akshi Yogashala. Rishikesh.
https://www.akshiyogashala.org/

Parmarth Niketan Yoga Ashram. Rishikesh.
https://www.parmarth.org/

Yoga Niketan. Rishikesh
http://www.yoganiketanashram.org

Yoga Vini. Rishikesh. Yoga Teacher Training & Drop-ins.
https://yogavinirishikesh.com/

World Peace Yoga Center. Rishikesh.
https://www.worldpeaceyogaschool.com/

Dayananda Vedanta Ashram. Rishikesh.
https://www.dayananda.org/

Ajatananda Ashram. Rishikesh. Non-residential Advaita teachings.
https://ajatananda.org/

Vajradhatu. Pune
http://vajradhatu.in

Osho Meditation Resort Pune
https://www.osho.com/osho-meditation-resort

Pyramid Valley Bangalore.
https://pyramidvalley.org/

Zen Center Central South India, Adilabad Telangana State.
https://zenmonasteryindia.weebly.com/about.html

Tibet House, Delhi. Top center with great online program.
https://tibethouse.in/

Kushinagar. Linh Son Monastery. Chill town and monastery.

Bodhi Gaya- The Sacred Land of Buddhahood

BluRay - An Idiot Abroad Season 1 Episode 2 - India

An Idiot Abroad S03E02: India

Nepal

Panditarama Lumbini. Excellent Mahasi style retreat center for serious meditators.
http://www.panditarama-lumbini.info/

International Buddhist Meditation Center. Kathmandu. Affiliated with Panditarama.
http://www.ibmc.org.np/

Korean Temple Dae Sang Shakya. Lumbini. Lodging or self-retreat.

Kopan Monastery. Courses and November one month lamrim course.
https://kopanmonastery.com/

Rangjung Yeshe Institute. Boudhanath. College level Buddhism courses.
https://www.ryi.org/

Pullahari. Boudhanath.
http://www.jamgonkongtrul.org/section.php?s1=2&s2=3

Lawudo Gompa. On Everest Base Camp trek. Self retreats in the Himalayas.
http://www.lawudo.com/

Thrangu Sekhar Retreat Center. Bhaktapur.
http://namobuddha.org/retreat.html

Benchen Monastery. Pharping.
https://benchen.org/en/

Pokara, Nepal is a traveler mecca with trekking, paragliding, meditation and yoga. There's an FPMT Buddhist center.
http://gandenyigachozin.com/

Thailand

Doi Suthep International Meditation Center. Doi Suthep, Chiang Mai. Good for beginners.
https://www.fivethousandyears.org/

Wat Chom Tong. Near Chiang Mai.
https://www.watchomtong.com/

Pa Pae Center. Near Chiang Mai. Short meditation courses. Good for beginners.
http://www.papaemeditation.org/en/

Imonastery. Outside Chiang Mai, near Pa Pae Center.
https://imonastery.com/

Wat Pa Tam Wa. Between Pai and Mae Hong Song. Beautiful place. Good google reviews.
https://www.wattamwua.com/

Wat Sopharam. Chiang Mai area, high Google reviews, relax and be aware approach.
https://watsopharam.org

Wat Ram Poeng. Near Chiang Mai. Ajahn Tong style.
http://www.watrampoeng.com/

Wat Pha Nanachat. Bung Wai, NE Thailand. Highly reviewed but it's also a working wat organized for westerners who are interested in becoming monks.
https://www.watpahnanachat.org/

Wat Subtawee Dhammaram Monastery. NE Thailand, close to Khao Yai Park. Good reviews, Ajahn Ganha, relation of Ajahn Chah is here.
http://www.watpahsubthawee.org

Angthong International Meditation Center. Pa Auk style. Champa Lo, Ang thong
https://www.paaukthailand.org/en/home-en/

Boonkanjanaram Meditation Center. Pattaya. Good for advanced meditators.
http://boonkan.com/
https://m.facebook.com/boonkanpattaya/
Email: boonkanmeditationcenter@gmail.com

Thai Plum Village. In tradition of Thich Nhat Hanh. Ban Sa Sai Sai, Pong Ta Long, about 240 km northeast of Bangkok.
http://www.thaiplumvillage.org/

Kow Tahm International Meditation Center. Koh Phangan. Monthly ten day courses.
http://watkowtahm.org/

The Sanctuary. Beach yoga. Koh Phangan.
https://www.thesanctuarythailand.com/

Blooming Lotus Yoga Center. Koh Phangan.
http://www.thailandyoga.net/yoga-retreats-thailand/thailand-yoga-retreat

Dipabhavan Meditation Center. Koh Samui. Monthly ten day courses
https://dipabhavan.weebly.com/

Wat Suan Mokh. Chaiye, close to Surat Thani. Monthly ten day courses.
https://www.suanmokkh.org/retreats

Little Bang has more options for retreats in Thailand. See
http://www.littlebang.org/retreats-2/

Malaysia

Malaysia Buddhist Meditation Center (MBMC). Penang. Mahasi-style.
https://www.mbmcmalaysia.org/

Vivekavana. Bukit Mertajam, Penang.
http://vivekavana.com/

Bodhi Heart. Penang.

http://www.bodhihearts.net/

Sasanarakkha Buddhist Sanctuary (SBS). Taiping.
https://sasanarakkha.org/

Sri Lanka

Nilambe. Monthly 5 day vipassana courses. Off grid but a good place.
https://www.nilambe.net/

Paramita Center, Kadugannawa
http://paramitaibc.org/

Rathmalkanda Insight Meditation Center. Ella.
http://www.dhammikaweb.com/?p=5302

Kanduboda. Colombo.
http://insight-meditation.org/

Krishnamurti Center. Colombo.
http://www.kinfonet.org/places/19-the-study-centre-colombo
See Facebook. https://www.facebook.com/Krishnamurti-Centre-Sri-Lanka-710699285633410/
And
ravi.paliha@gmail.com

Burma / Myanamar

Mahasi Center. Panditarma Forest Meditation Center. Forty miles north of Yangon, Burma. Sixty day winter retreat draws yogis worldwide.

https://www.saddhamma.org/html/panditarama.shtml

Pa Auk Center. Pa-Auk Tawya Meditation Centre. Mawlamyine. Retreat center.

https://www.paaukforestmonastery.org/

U Tejaniya. Shwe Oo Min. Retreat center.
https://ashintejaniya.org/

Chanmay Myaing Meditation Center. Metta retreats January-February.
http://www.meditation-in-burma.com/en/index.php

China

Datong Xingguo Chan Temple. In Tangshan, Hebei Province. Yearly one month course.
https://www.woodenfish.org/

Other & Miscellaneous

Goenka Vipassana Centers. Many worldwide. Operate on donation.
dhamma.org

IMS. Massachusetts, USA. https://www.dharma.org/

Spirit Rock, California USA
https://www.spiritrock.org/

Gaia House. Devon, England. Reasonable long-term rates.
https://gaiahouse.co.uk

Amaravati Monastery. Hemel Hempstead, Hertfordshire, UK. Home of Ajahn Amaro. Regular donation-based retreats.
https://www.amaravati.org/

Satipanya Retreat Center. Wales, UK. Mahasi style.
https://www.satipanya.org.uk/

Jaya Ashmore. Retreats in south and north India (Tiruvannamalai and Sattal) and Europe.
https://www.jayaashmore.org/

Patrick Kearney. Retreats in Australia, India and Malaysia. Fine teacher.
https://patrickkearney.net/

Mingyur Rinpoche. Worldwide teachings, including Nepal and India.
https://tergar.org/mingyur-rinpoches-schedule/

Antaji Monastery. Zen monastery in Japan which accepts foreigners.
https://antaiji.org/en/

Marija Drezgic. Leads hiking and yoga retreats in Serbia, Eastern Europe, and Turkey. Reasonable rates.
http://www.myyogicadventure.com/

Sanghaseva. Led by fine Dharma teacher Zohar Lavie. Retreats in Israel and India.
https://www.zoharlavie.org/

And

https://www.sanghaseva.org/infosanghaseva.html

Tallahassee Florida Chan (Zen) Center
Many online events.
https://tallahasseechan.org/

Gyobutsuji, Zen center in Kingston, Arkansas. Monthly retreats or Sesshins. Very small Zen center with a good teacher, good sangha. Email them for zoom sessions.
shoryu@gyobutsuji.org
Website:
Www.Gyobutsuji.org

Korinji. A Rinzai Zen center in Japan and Wisconsin USA. Online resources accessible through Patreon.
https://www.korinji.org/

Hridaya Yoga & Spiritual Retreat Center. France & Mexico.
https://hridaya-yoga.com/activities/10-day-hridaya-silent-meditation-retreat/

This condensed list can be found at:

https://docs.google.com/document/d/131O8PBjNXyH8BR0v_9Jixv8iC7ph4LM7wEuaabufdUc/edit?usp=drivesdk

Lion's Roar Guide to Going on Retreat
https://www.lionsroar.com/why-is-doing-a-retreat-helpful/

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Here is a link to my free guide to Dharma Books & Curriculum:

https://docs.google.com/document/d/1hlk6x2XJy8ZQfdYYTibCx2ADRtZDLPqJifQrggic47k/edit?usp=drivesdk

Here is a link to Wolf's Guide to Dharma Practice:
https://docs.google.com/document/d/1dDu6AyT880iWPMaSEpp47r69bwprAhBz5WPqrUXUuiM/edit?usp=drive_link

This is a Guide to my Guides and what I email to people to access my Guides and Cloud Links. You are free to share this:

https://docs.google.com/document/d/1ge00DGEP3vxal4aXTRF8qjHpbPbayLmuTLsGUKQuPFg/edit?usp=drivesdk

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Why Study Dharma in Asia

There's three main reasons for studying Dharma in Asia:

1) Cost. Dharma retreats in the west often run into thousands of dollars. Many retreats in Asia are donation-based or a nominal fee. I often budget $10 a day for a retreat that I like and that has good food and provides private accommodation. It's also nice to provide an additional teacher donation (dana). In comparison, to stay at the famous IMS center in Massachusetts, USA, the base rate *minimum* for dormitory accommodation is $40 a day. This doesn't include a teacher donation. Many other places are more expensive. I look at some retreat places in the West and get sticker shock. I don't quite understand why if the West is so rich, there's few affordable retreats, while poorer countries like Burma and Nepal, they're often held on a donation (Dana) basis. I suppose Western Vipassana has bought into the Gentrification model.

   It used to be though, historically, it was the Buddhist monks and teachers who begged and relied on donations. Now, instead, in this degenerate age, at least in the West, it is the dharma students who are forced to beg so they can afford Dharma teachings and a retreat in Europe or America! My social media feeds regularly have appeals from students for financial assistance to their GoFundMe page so they can afford a retreat. It's a bit galling that these Western teachers themselves received their training in the East without having to pay vast sums of money yet they're not above selling the Dharma out to those who can afford it. I may be too harsh on these Western teachers but the bad part of me considers that they're not even really Dharma teachers. Instead at best they're self-improvement coaches. If you read my *Wolf's Guide to Dharma Books and Practice,* you'll find I have other names for them, like *self-serving dharma whores*. No offense meant against an honest and hard-working whore.

   One retreat in the West can run into thousands of dollars easily. Sure, a plane ticket to Asia is expensive. But everything else is cheaper and if you have extended time and you're interested in multiple retreats, you might be better off forsaking the West and its rapacious dharma whore retreat model and instead come East.

Many centers try to ameliorate the upper class old White people conclave that many Western Buddhist centers turn into by offering assistance programs. Bravo. However there's often still a bit of stigma taking advantage and not fully paying what's expected or hoped for. I don't find being a poor Dharma bum stigmatized in the East. I feel welcomed.

2) Culture & Growth: I think Indian culture and Asian culture is conducive to practice. As a backpacker, you'll have to be adaptable. Things won't always go the way you planned. Things won't be done the same way as in the West. Travel can be liberating though.

3) Cross-training opportunities. A trip through Thailand, Malaysia, Nepal, and India - could have you study and train in Theravada Vipassana, Tibetan Buddhism, Zen, Advaita Vedanta, and Yoga. This is a fantastic, fantastic opportunity. Even if you fall in love with one system, it's good to lean about others.

4) If I knew I was going to die in six months, I wouldn't be doing anything else as traveling and studying dharma is amazing. Being a dharma bum is glorious. There's nothing like studying the Dharma as it's good in the beginning, good in the middle, and good at the end. I used to refer to myself as a Dharma bum in a jokey way, but Christopher Titmuss had a different take on the dharma bum: That the dharma bum was probably similar to the early buddhist practitioners, before they wore robes, before there were all the monkly rules, rituals, and regs, before all the sectarianism and bureaucracy. They practiced and traveled and studied with different teachers. Christopher told me that the world needs more dharma bums. This was an interesting insight that I appreciated. Being a dharma bum isn't all a joke, it's also a beautiful and liberating experience. May you also find it so if you decide to go down this path.

Don't Go looking for Mystical experiences
https://youtu.be/UUZ9eyzsRxc?si=BaoyYcpSHmXbhYIM

Retreats and Teachings

I think it's worthwhile to do at least one Vipassana Retreat in your life. Did you know that most Buddhists don't meditate? And even many monks don't either! In one American retreat I did, one afternoon there was no scheduled sitting meditation. There was no time! Instead, there was a nature walk, a reflective writing workshop, yoga, teacher interviews, a Dharma talk--great stuff

but I couldn't help but think that my favorite Lumbini Nepal Panditarama Vipassana traditional teachers would have a cow of a schedule having an entire retreat afternoon with no scheduled sitting meditation! Imagine!

So if it's a Vipassana retreat – how can there be no time to meditate on the schedule??

It's a Western Vipassana retreat, Sayadaw…

At Panditarama, it's walking meditation followed by sitting meditation followed by walking meditation followed by sitting meditation and so on, and so on...

I've written a lot here, but my experience may not be your experience. Anything I feel about a center doesn't have to be what you feel and experience. Everything does change, as Suzuki Roshi says, and with time, these centers will change: teachers come and go; policies change; cooks are replaced. A center that was friendly, with top-notch instruction, and good food can become blase, with a new teacher who dislikes Westerners, and a new cook whose speciality is bland faux pork ball soup with a side of Saltine crackers.

At least you have names of centers and places you can now look up. If a place doesn't suit you, try someplace else.

After near fifty years of annual India retreats, Christopher Titmuss is no longer coming to India anymore, but co-teachers of his, such as Radha Nicholson, have taken over the retreats.

Doi Suthep International Meditation Center in Chiang Mai, Thailand is also a good vipassana retreat for beginners. Pa Pae also near Chiang Mai looks good with four day meditation courses. Wat Pa Tam Wa also gets excellent reviews. Bodhi Zendo in Tamil Nadu, South India is a chill place which is a favorite of mine. Bodhi Zendo is excellent for a longish stay (even 30+ days) especially if you have your own practice, are self motivated, and are flexible, adaptable, and chill yourself. Thosamling nunnery in Dharamsala, India is a cool place too and another place one can spend an enjoyable thirty plus days in self-retreat.

Panditarama Vipassana Center in Lumbini, Nepal is excellent but it's even better if you've done a prior Vipassana retreat elsewhere and have a somewhat decent handle on meditation. It's definitely not chill, it's like the opposite of chill, but still it's really good. There's few places that one can spend thirty days or more on retreat that respects the meditator and their schedule. Bodhi Zendo, Thosamling, and Panditarama are my top picks. Although Panditarama, again, is not a self-retreat, not chill, and you're expected to work hard. Check it out, maybe for a short stay on your first trip, see if the intensity is your cup of chai.

Burma is good for serious meditators as with a meditation visa you could stay in a meditation center for months. U Tejaniya's monastery, Shwee Oo Min, may be the most relaxed Burmese

meditation center I know. See the review in this guide. Although current conditions may make Burma off limits for meditators.

It's not that you have to be some great meditation expert to do a retreat at Panditarama or a self-retreat at several places mentioned later. Being self-motivated, self-disciplined, following rules and instructions, and having even just a couple meditation methods you're familiar with and comfortable with, will put you in good standing. If you can get up early, follow rules and instructions, and keep yourself busy and meditate on your own, you're golden. Bonus if you can do it with a smile on your face. It's a myth that retreats, even Vipassana ones, have to be such glum affairs. If you find yourself fortunate to attend a Dharma retreat, realize you're part of the 1% of 1% of the population that is ever so lucky enough to do so.

I recommend reading books from the same branch of Buddhism that you're doing a retreat in. At Panditarama the closest books would be books by U Pandita or Mahasi Sayadaw. Excellent books, well worth reading, and great prep for a Panditarama retreat.

Both the books and Panditarama Retreat center are serious. In Panditarama there's Teacher interviews nearly every day. They don't suffer fools or foolish behaviour. If you want a chilled out retreat and to smoke hash in the garden -- try a self retreat at a Kasol guesthouse in Himachal Pradesh -- not Panditarama.

Panditarama expects hard work, the entire day spent in Mindfulness, as well as a daily report with you taking your breath and really putting it under the microscope. Keep a notebook and try to write down at least one thing after each meditation session. I wrote down first “significant thing” and then erased the significant--because often what you think is significant or cool--the teachers do not. And what you may consider insignificant, the teachers may respond to. In my case, I brought up reluctantly, that I'd been having itches like mad just in the evenings of the last two nights. Venerable Vivekananda asked me about them, and I believe I could write a book on itching and scratching. He said that I should have mentioned this right off. Here I thought I was complaining and noticing itching was not so much something I'd think to put in a daily report.

My .02 worth of advice on retreat reports at Panditarama: omit saying you're a terrible meditator or had bad meditations or couldn't concentrate. Everyone has this. The teachers hear this all the time. Instead, focus on the instructions you were given. What happened? When problems arose, did you note them and turn the spotlight on them? What did you do to remedy the problem? Did you notice everything that came up and if it was powerful, put it under the microscope? So if you noticed distracting thoughts and then had the thought “I'm a bad meditator.” -- you can sit with that thought. Notice it's just a thought. You don't have to believe it. You can see it as an example of the judging mind. What's it like? Then go back to the breath.

Venerable Vivekananda is German so I think it pays to cut out the small talk and be direct. Don't mess about with Vivekananda and don't mess around at Panditarama.

Many people cook themselves pretty good at Panditarama. It's a great place to go deep into practice. Nepal provides up to a 90 day stay visa for citizens of many western countries upon arrival.

Panditarama does about everything right for a meditation center. Excellent facilities, food, and instruction. Cost is by donation. Your sole job while there is to meditate and be mindful. No karma yoga jobs like cutting vegetables, sweeping, or even washing your own dishes! It's also nice you structure your time spent in meditation yourself. It's your schedule. Fantastic.

I'm pretty fond of Panditarama. Although it's not for everyone, those yogis that have spent time in the Mahasi system, for whatever reason, I find to be pretty cool. I'm not sure why. Is it the discipline instilled? The Insights gained? Or does the Mahasi system attract curious and intellectual seekers? I recommend checking out a Panditarama center and starting with a shortish 7-14 day retreat. I don't recommend strict Vipassana practice for everyone.

Possibly Panditarama teachers Venerables Vivekananda and Bhaddimanika are the best guides of the Mahasi method outside of Burma. Although they'd never mention it, it's nice to give Dana directly to them as your teacher in addition to Dana you give to the Panditarama Center for your stay. Several times I had to search around my last day at Panditarama to find someone so I could pay. I got the feeling money was not a high priority with them at all. Which is refreshing and nice: True Old School Dharma!

This happened to me the first time I arrived at Panditarama and I've seen it happen to others. You arrive at the main gate of Panditarama and find it locked. You shout out a hearty "HELLO!" and bang on the gate. Then you're told there's a small pedestrian entrance to Panditarama immediately on the right side of the gate. Oh.

There may be warm-ish showers in your room but if not you can ask for a bucket of hot water from the outside kitchen. Hot thermoses are also available.

One thing to be aware for Panditarama is around April it starts to get hot. Really hot. I did a retreat in April there and wanted to make it to May for Buddha's birthday celebrations in Lumbini (since the Buddha was born in Lumbini). I was taking like seven quick showers a day. I didn't bother toweling off. Some days I was the only Yogi in the meditation hall, as attendance falls as the heat rises. Currently it looks like the center regularly closes down from sometime in April to Mid June.

Fall and Spring are the best times climate wise for a retreat in Lumbini. I was there in January too, and it was cold, but I'd rather the cold than the heat.

In years past, there used to be a problem with power cuts at Panditarama (and Nepal) with power outages lasting often up to 12 hours. This problem seems to have abated.

Another thing, kinda surprisingly, is that the air in Lumbini, Nepal can be polluted. You'd think Nepalese Himalayan air would be pristine--but Lumbini isn't in the mountains, it's in the plains, and close to some cement plants. Some yogis with asthma have had to cut short their retreats.

There also can be a noise issue from a nearby village Hindu temple (during festival days they may blare prayers from 6am till late) --but honestly, about every retreat I've done in Asia had noise issues. Bodhgaya and Sarnath, India have Hindu wedding music problems. Frankly, I think any UNESCO World Heritage site and pilgrimage place should have a strict noise ordinance. Maybe someday...

Doi Suthep, Thailand, just outside of Chiang Mai, is in the jungle, but there's an insect that makes an extremely high pitched sound similar to a fire/smoke alarm when it needs its batteries replaced. I thought if I had to listen to that for days, I'd go crazy. But I did. There's also a Thai jungle bird that sounds like a car alarm going off. Once, in Doi Suthep, I left a bit early because after a huge tree fell on a section of the yogi rooms, they had chainsaws going for days.

I've thought of noise cancelling headphones or earplugs for my next trip. If they'd even work. But it's not a huge deal. Part of insight is realizing it’s not the noise, but your reaction to the noise that is the issue (same goes for pain too). Still, this is one of those things that is easy to say.

Read books by Mahasi Sayadaw and U Pandita before attending Panditarama. Start with *In This Very Life* which is a collection of talks U Pandita gave at IMS in Massachusetts to western yogis who may have been new to the Mahasi system. Reading U Pandita will help you get a background for the Mahasi method and philosophy. The practice section of Mahasi Sayadaw's *Manual of Insight* was recommended by Yogi Robin. Panditarama recommends U Silananda's *Four Foundations of Mindfulness*.

Strive to follow the center's rules and instructions given. Don't underestimate the power of meditation to bring everything up. But if you've read this guide and especially my Guide to Dharma Books and Practice, you know to be prepared for aversive mental states. That they do and probably will come up. Just knowing that unpleasantness will arise is a big help. Being equanimeous about it all and knowing pleasantness-unpleasantness shifts will happen will stand you well. Being prepared with some tools, such as walking and lying Meditation and Metta meditation, which help create new causes and conditions.

U Pandita taught Metta during his retreats in the West, though not so much back in Burma. It wasn't that U Pandita was getting soft, less strict, or making it easy for Westerners. U Pandita felt Westerners were just so stressed that when they did intense vipassana practice, sometimes it was like a bomb (Christopher Titmuss, personal communication). So don't forget you can do Metta meditation and walking meditation as a preventative too, including just a regular slow mindful walk around the compound. No reason why you can't meditate in all four postures, including lying. Be kind to yourself, be willing to mix it up, to add more walking meditation and

lying meditation sessions if needed and to take your foot off the gas. You'll do okay. See also Yogi Robin's review of the Panditarama center in Burma later in this document.

Remember *Your Mileage May Vary.*

*

Concentration & Rigidity (OR MORE CONCENTRATION -- MO' PROBLEMS)

Sitting for long periods in a quiet place
is fine in itself.
The concern is why.
Is it just a natural result of right practice,
or is it an effort
towards prolonged sensory deprivation?
How long one can sit has also been used to measure how well one meditates,
thus turning meditation
into somewhat an endurance training.
Some teachers even insist on long sitting without allowing any movement,
scaring many away from meditation.
Some even enforce it
with no movements allowed,
traumatizing the students.
Of course we can't find this idea
promoted in the Suttas.
What's the point of the practice anyway:
to increase or decrease stress?

-- Bhikkhu Kumara. *What You May Not Know About Jhana & Samadhi.*

I've mentioned before about the misfortune of the translation of samadhi as concentration when a more accurate word might be composure, collectedness, or stability of mind. Bhikkhu Kumara does a great job discussing this in his book, *What You May Not Know About Jhana and Samadhi*.

I was always pretty skeptical on the whole building concentration by sitting with single focus determination.

I played chess. I had nine hour tournament chess games. I can play chess blindfolded. This, I suppose, requires a certain level of focus, but I'm not sure if this concentration extends past chess. Kids with Attention Deficit can play computer games for hours but can't work forty long division math problems. Does chess count as concentration practice but Starcraft or first player computer shooter games don't? What about someone watching television, bicycle riding, or driving? Do we count this as concentration or single focus or what? If we count them all, then concentration practice seems like bullshit, if we don't, why not? Why is staring at a candle flame more sacred than starring at a chessboard, starcraft game, accounting spreadsheet, book, or phone?

What's sitting and looking at a candle for a couple hours gonna do? Imagine sitting and looking at the candle for 14 hours a day for a three month retreat? What do you think might be the result? Hallucinations? Delusion? Mental unwellness? Do you think the practice is conducive to insight? What insight might be gained by watching a candle flame? There's many meditation methods espoused by the Buddha. I don't recall starring at a candle flame, or anything similar, being recommended. In the Pali canon, the Buddha never even recommends a mantra (although mantras do play a part in Mahayana). Theravadins may say reciting *Buddho* is skillful means that may be shorthand for recollection of the Buddha and building focus and joy but not technically a mantra.

If you look at the Pali canon's main meditation suttas (e.g., Satipatthana, Anapanasati, Metta suttas) -- you find they are heavy on insight or directly engaging in a practice that's conducive to something like loving-kindness or equanimity. Although Kasina practice is mentioned in a sutta that's extremely sparse on any details (AN 10.25) and is just a listing. In MN 77 however, kasinas are part of the methods the Buddha recites.

What I'm trying to say here is that concentrative meditation methods like mantras and kasinas barely rate a mention in the Pali tradition. Single pointed concentration methods are not emphasized by the Buddha (At least in the Pali Canon). It's an option. Don't mistake a side dish for the main meal or worse, the only meal. I'm not against kasina or mantra practice. They're a tool. Just be aware of what you're practicing for. If it's for a cool experience or to explore, fine.

Just beware of limiting your practice by thinking concentration methods are all there is.

When our experience is artificial,
how are we to know reality?
-- Bhikkhu Kumara. *What You May Not Know About Jhana & Samadhi.*

My .02 is that a high degree of single pointed concentration just isn't all that. So you can sit for four hours, so what, a chicken can sit for twenty-four! I think a certain amount of discipline is helpful and probably necessary for meditators. Not only to keep sitting and bringing one's mind back to the meditation object, but also in following directions, respecting others, getting up at 5am for sitting, not quitting a retreat, and not being a drama queen or starting drama. If you're seeing auras and your samadhi puts you in trance-like jhana -- yet you're doing loud yogic breathing in the meditation hall, sleeping in your room during early morning sits, absent for work chores, talking loudly on the phone, getting salty with the kitchen staff about the food, or just generally not following the rules, schedule and participating because you're special -- you've really missed the plot. Wouldn't wanna be you, despite the seeing auras schtick.

Ajahn Brahm told a story of a man, deep in a trance like samadhi or absorption, was found by his wife. When she couldn't wake him and didn't detect breathing, she called an emergency ambulance. The man woke up in an ambulance. Ajahn Brahm says the story is true, but I have my doubts. EMTs routinely do a painful sternum rub to assess consciousness on a patient. They must have put his body on a stretcher and carried him out. He's lucky he didn't get zapped by a defibrillator.

It's funny after this I heard someone sharing my dinner table bring up the amazing tale of Sadhguru who when being tested by brain scientists who had his brain wired up became very concerned because, according to Sadhguru, their tests showed Sadhguru in deep meditation was actually dead. I assume that means the scientists didn't detect any brain activity. Good for Sadhguru, I guess. I'm tempted to make a smart remark like I guess this lack of brain activity explains Sadhguru's wack YouTube videos like: *The Secret to Bruce Lee's Blinding Speed* and *How Tantrics make Dead Bodies Walk*.

Even if these meditation=death like trance stories are wholly true (which I doubt), how does entering a trance or blanking out ease suffering or make for spiritual insight? These guys were almost indistinguishable from being dead. What's the point, really? Does coma lead to insight and awakening? I don’t see it. Lazarus was dead before he was resurrected by Jesus and no one treated him anything special evidently. The Bible doesn’t recount any of Lazarus’s insights. Jesus’s first words to his disciples upon his return was to ask for some fish. So much for death insights. When you watch Zombie movies do you ever wish *Gee, I wish my brain was dead like one of them*? – if so, concentration meditation might be for you.

Also, for concentration meditators, consider drugs which provide a cornucopia of altered effects and would provide the same results in a fraction of the time. Xanax can provide a calm and a peaceful feeling. There's powerful drugs that can zombie a person out. Sleep provides us with hours of blanking out every night. These may be helpful at times or provide a temporary solution. We need sleep. Drugs are not *the* answer for the average unruly mind. Certainly no easy total answer. Even if you have a transformative spiritual experience on psychedelic drugs, the hard work of integrating it remains. Sleep's great, sleep's healthy -- but sleeping your life

away or sleep in general doesn't provide more insight or wisdom. To be noted here is the word *Buddha* means *awakened one.*

Drugs, sleep, and trance-like concentrative meditation states can be an escape from reality and investigation of that reality.

Walk the Path, your Path. Be kind. Be a person of integrity. Practice equanimity. Practice insight.

If you want insight
or to decrease suffering,
practice accordingly.

Frankly, I don't see concentration making much of a difference in a person's practice. In fact, it's almost the reverse – the more *hardcore* picture-perfect, full-lotus sitter you are the more likely your practice is due to fuck up.

Discipline sure makes a difference though. Meditators fuck up all the time with discipline. The real issue for most isn't being able to sit for hours with singularity of focus -- it's sitting down at all.

So if you only stare at the candle for thirty minutes before deciding *well fuck this ain't working* and taking a tea break -- I don't have a problem with this. Why would I? Maybe it was a quality 30 minutes. Maybe today sets you up for longer sits in the future. Maybe it was a more insightful sit than zoning out for three hours. People can sit in a trance state looking at their phones (or volleyball girls) for hours too.

Consider that concentration practice may have an inverted U shape curve. A point can be reached quite quickly where additional concentration practice doesn't bring benefits, but instead risk of mental unwellness.

You need a certain amount of concentration, I suppose, but ordinary run-of-the-mill concentration seems to be adequate. As U Tejaniya writes, the meditator's job is to see the mind *as is*. It's not purifying the mind somehow, someway, and using this super-powered mind to cut through the mysteries of the universe and the self. Like zen master Nansen said, *Ordinary mind is the way.*

Take a look at the 85% Rule. Hugh Jackman explains “The 85% Rule”. “**If you tell most of A-type athletes to run at their 85% capacity, they will run faster than if you tell them to run at 100%,** because it’s more about relaxation, and form, and optimizing the muscles in the right way”. If you read Sayadaw U Tejaniya like I’ve told you, you’re likely on board with it.

This is in contrast to Mahasi Sayadaw's view of practice: *The meditative process is like that of producing fire by energetically and **unremittingly** rubbing two sticks of wood together so as to attain the necessary intensity of heat (when the flame arises).*

(Bolding emphasis mine)
Retrieved from: https://mahasivipassana.com/docs/practical-vipassana-meditation-exercises/

This seems to mean continuous effort. You can't start a fire rubbing two sticks together if after ten minutes you stop just when things start to heat up. You'll have to start all over again. According to this view, if you slack off meditation a bit after three weeks or three months of strong effort, you'll never achieve a breakthrough. This can lead some yogis to practice to the point of mental unwellness.

Bhikkhu Kumara writes of how his practice was influenced by an over-emphasis on striving concentration practices:

While following a Burmese vipassanā system, I was taught that one of the faculties to be developed was concentration, though a different kind from that of 'samatha meditation'. I also learnt a more definitive description of it called 'one-pointedness'. So, with this idea in mind, I would from time to time try to narrow my scope of attention to a small—preferably minute—area, so that I could develop greater concentration. The better the concentration, the better the chance of enlightenment, right? Well, at least that's what I believed.

Once, I noticed tension on my head. Following the general instruction then, I watched it. After some time, it became interesting: a constant tapping over an area the size of a palm. As I watched further, the tapping began to appear like uncountable, fine ticking sensations all over that area, really fast. Later on, since it didn't seem like I was getting anything out of it, I thought, "This isn't good enough." It wasn't one-pointed yet, you see?

So I gradually narrowed the attention, until it was just one point—at least I considered it so. It was interesting to see one continuous 'ticking' at a tiny spot. But soon I became dissatisfied with that too. So I watched even more intently at that continuous ticking sensation, and noticed that each ticking seemed like a pulling. So, instead of tick-tick-tick-tick-tick, it seemed more like pullpull-pull-pull-pull.

Concentrating even further into each 'pulling', I noticed that it was actually a series of minute vibrations. Then, I extrapolated that if I could be fast enough to focus on just one instance of the minute vibrations, one wave of it, that would be seen as consisting of even more minute vibrations. I tried, but couldn't go any further. I realised that I was too tired by then, and so I gave up.

But what if I did have the energy to carry on? What if I saw what I predicted? What if I could continue till I directly knew and saw the wave function of quantum physics? Ahaa…. Okay,

maybe not. (Just maybe.) Anyway, even if that's possible, so what? I would still be just seeing form (rūpa)—of a teeny-weeny proportion. How's that going to bring about full understanding of suffering and abandonment of craving? Practically, it's a waste of time and energy.

Still, I must say it was a very interesting waste of time and energy

-- Bhikkhu Kumara. *What You May Not Know About Jhana & Samadhi.* (Appendix 5).

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A friend of mine, Benny writes of his experience at a Mahasi center:

My first longer retreat was at the Winter Retreat at Panditarama in Myanmar, 2015-6. It was not good for me; I did not get in touch with something deep inside me, I did not open up or become relaxed and I felt less accepting of myself afterwards. I am not sure why it was bad for me, maybe because I have been depressed or maybe because my mental life is not like the average persons'. Unfortunately, the teachers at Panditarama certainly did not know either, even though they never hesitated about pushing me on. Let me share some aspects of the retreat which I think is connected to my bad experience.

I never got any encouragement, until I told them I wanted to leave. I was pushed a lot, without any smiles and even without eye contact. Sayadaw U Pandita was then still head teacher, 95 years old. The only instruction he directed to an individual was "be mindful of your fingers" when one yogi moved a pen a little, with no purpose. After that no one moved during his dhamma talks - every evening for sixty days. I really missed a human contact.

The interviews were formal, and every report should start with "When I breathe in ..." followed by a report of the sensations in the belly and nothing else. There were no space to share important experiences, positive or negative. If you feel that you are beginning to sink down into a depression? "No, read the brochure about how interviews should be conducted". If you have interesting, tingling, sensations in the body during line up for lunch or during resting after lunch? No. When I finally reported such sensations the translator scolded me for not telling earlier. The only response from the teacher was "carry on" or something to that effect. He did not try to explain what happened, or if it was an effect of the meditation or of the sleep deprivation or something else.

Sleep deprivation was an issue for me during the retreat. I discovered that I lose my balance when I sleep too little. During the first few weeks I had to hold to the walls or railings to be able to walk in the evenings. I worried that I might be suffering from diabetes, my father had developed that disease in about the same age. It would have been good to have someone to talk to about my medical worries (there were the possibility to visit a doctor), but since these

experiences did not happen in my belly during my sitting meditation I was not allowed to report them (and I know what the teacher would say: "note your feelings and carry on"). I basically passed out my 74 nights there, I did not go to sleep. This was after U Pandita had allowed 5,5 hours of sleep every night, earlier he had only allowed 4 hours.

After a few weeks without any results, the technique got even drier and more mechanical ("In, Out, In, Out"). Repeatedly I was told to use "more effort," which only worsened the problem. A good answer would have been "relax and take it easy, don't worry so much about getting the technique exactly as we teachers say, trust your own experience and inner resource. Play and explore!" Also, when I saw that I did not get any results, my self-esteem sank and I intensified my effort to follow the teachers who looked displeased with me. (I do not think they were so displeased with me, I think it is only their idea of how a meditation teacher should be.)

It did not help that they switched teachers on me three times. Each teacher was strictest in the beginning. I do not know why they switched, and of course they did not talk over these situations with me. And even if they would have, I would have been too exhausted to give a good answer. Still, I had each teacher at least two or even four weeks, which is plenty of time to build a connection.

U Pandita was 95 years old, and he gave everything he had to teach us the Dhamma. He used his last strength to instruct us; one month later he died. I have respect for him. One lesson I learned is that even the most respected teachers might not be good teachers for me. Most of my week long retreats with western teachers have been more fruitful for me than 11 hardcore weeks at Panditarama. My bad experience does not mean that Panditarama is a bad place, but it can be bad for some people and there is no guarantee that they handle a situation right. It is extremely intense, and maybe I will return after say five years of full-time meditation.

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Bhante Sujato writes:

While the intensive retreat has given many people, including myself, a crucial kick-start in their Dhamma practice, it is not without its drawbacks. It's normal that meditators will get a high on the retreat and then fall back to earth. The extreme exertion invites over-estimation, and such retreats are full of people who convince themselves they have attained jhāna or awakening. Even worse, intensive practice with inadequate preparation and guidance can trigger psychosis, which is extremely dangerous. Many meditation retreats are run without the grounding in psychological understanding to recognize or handle these breakdowns, and meditators may be told simply to continue, or even that their psychosis is a sign of insight.
-- Bhante Sujato
Retrieved:
https://discourse.suttacentral.net/t/how-early-buddhism-differs-from-theravada-a-checklist/23019/18

I heard a story of a long term practitioner, a monk, whose mindfulness was held up as an example. The monk would label and note *everything*:

Standing, standing, standing, preparing to sit, preparing to sit, preparing to sit, sitting, sitting, sitting, buttocks pressure, buttocks pressure, buttocks pressure, anticipating eating, anticipating eating, anticipating eating, smelling food, smelling food, smelling food, reaching for food, reaching for food, reaching for food, putting food into mouth, putting food into mouth, putting food into mouth, chewing, chewing, chewing, tasting, tasting, tasting, favorable perception, favorable perception, favorable perception, enjoyment arising, enjoyment arising, enjoyment arising, swallowing, swallowing, swallowing…. .

It's one thing to do this noting practice on retreat for a limited time. Doing this Full Time when off retreat appears to be a bit psychotic. When you cross the river, you drop the raft. If you haven't crossed the river and you're still carrying your precious method month after month after month, with it weighing you down like Jesus carrying his cross -- consider switching up methods. Does this monk sound like he's on the path to liberation or does he sound like he's dissociating into a mental unwellness funk? Are they on the road for a crack-up?

I detail many good methods here. Try Metta & Bodhicitta, Reflective Slow Walking Meditation, and the Satipatthana. If the monk in this story asked me for my practice advice, that's what I would tell him, for Buddha's sake. Not that that would ever happen.

I found this on Reddit from a therapist who worked with some Mahasi style meditators:

Like one client I worked with who said they were "an Olympic level meditator," I started writing down some notes as I was listening and they suddenly asked, "What are you doing?" in this nervous way, and I patiently explained I was just writing down some notes so I would remember what to address. Paranoid mindfulness you might even call it. In other cases it was more like self-critical mindfulness, painfully aware of every little thing that is wrong about yourself. Or noticing every little sound and finding them all highly annoying. It was really heartbreaking to be honest.

Here is an excellent 2024 podcast from Untold: The Retreat about Goenka Vipassana retreats:

Check out this podcast: Untold: The Retreat #untoldTheRetreat
https://podcastaddict.com/podcast/untold-the-retreat/4822535

via @PodcastAddict

And finally a good Esquire article where the Goenka yogi had to be institutionalized.

https://www.esquire.com/uk/latest-news/a25651175/the-other-side-of-paradise-how-i-left-a-buddhist-retreat-in-handcuffs/

Why Some People Find Meditation Retreats Stressful?
By Kumāra Bhikkhu

Meditation should reduce stress, right? So, logically, a meditation retreat should reduce a lot of stress. Then why some people find meditation retreats stressful instead?

Through my own experience in the past and teaching meditation for more than 10 years, I've a few observations on the why:

1) **Forcing the mind to stop thinking**

Some people believe that meditation is about making their minds stop thinking. With this view, they would consciously or subconsciously force their mind to stop thinking. Regardless of whether they are successful in their effort, this forcing creates stress. As one does this over and over, the stress builds up.

2) **Forcing the mind to focus on only one thing**

Some people view meditation as an effort to concentrate. And with that view, that's what they try to do. When the mind is composed or collected, one can focus easily. However, when one tries to do that without having a composed or collected mind, it's like forcing a wild monkey to sit still. Surely that wild monkey that the mind still is will be very much under stress.

This issue is based on a poor translation of samādhi as "concentration". A better translation is "composure" or collectedness". To bring about composure or collectedness, one should avoid forcing the mind to do something it's not willing to do. Instead, one needs to work with the mind, befriend the mind, understand the mind.

3) **Forcing the body to move very slowly**

Some people try to move in an unnaturally slow way. They believe that it helps them to concentrate. In any case, it's an effortful way of walking. While one is fully physically ready for it, it's still fine. But the body eventually will get tired, and that's when it becomes increasing stressful to maintain the slow movement.

Again, this is based on a misunderstanding of the word samādhi. There's no need to move slowly. Nothing in the Suttas even suggest that. They just say "when walking, the monk discerns, 'I am walking.'"

Meditation should reduce stress, not induce it. So, regardless of the why, if you find meditation stress-inducing, it makes perfect sense to stop and find out why.

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I found it interesting that a Vedantine, Swami Tv, also had a negative opinion of concentration meditation. In a retreat at Rishikesh in 2024, Swami Tv said that concentration practice drains and produces conflict in a yogi, and makes for a frustrated yogi. "It's a sad saga of misinformation and the meditator can mistake a dull and blunted mind for Samadhi." Swami Tv

recommends a Wolf favorite, Loving-Kindness meditation. It's interesting that someone from a different tradition came to some of the same conclusions.

*

One of my favorite retreat centers is, in fact, a Mahasi Panditarama center in Lumbini Nepal. I think it's excellent. It may be even better than the main Panditarama branch in Burma. See my Retreat Guide for full details on these. But I don't recommend beginners try the Main Branch's 60 day Panditarama Winter retreat right out of the gate. The practice can be too intense for some as shown. My rule of thumb for success in a long retreat is to have done at least half the retreat length before and in a similar system. If someone wants or needs a more heart-felt practice or would benefit from a more relaxed practice, I don't recommend strict vipassana like Mahasi or Goenka.

Myself, I have had good retreats at a branch of Panditarama. But I also do a walk around the compound, Metta practice, and lying meditation. I often may use a chair during meditation for ease. I remember lying on the floor of my khutti during a very hot April afternoon. The cement floor was cool. It felt nice to lie and meditate there.

I'm not averse to doing more walking meditation and less sitting if that calls to me. I think sometimes people get into a personal war with themselves and believe if they strive and sit, sit, sit with great determination no matter the cost -- trying to emulate the Buddha on the eve of his enlightenment -- they'll achieve that elusive breakthrough. This can work, to some extent, for some people. For some other people, the cost can be a drop-in to psychosis. The more a person follows strictly a meditative concentration practice the more likely they are to suffer.

I'm an American though and we don't have the discipline to wear masks during a pandemic or not put pineapple on pizzas. If I start suffering during sitting meditation and/or my mind isn't reacting well, hell, I'll try something different. It's an option. Like seriously what's wrong with more walking meditation? Although there is a walking meditation that is divided into parts, e.g., Raising the foot, Lifting the foot, Moving the foot, Lowering the foot, Placing the foot, Settling the foot, Shifting Weight… and this has its place. For me it's indoors. I do multipart walking in my room when it's dark outside. I don't wish a surprise meetup with a cobra. You can also divide walking into two parts, Left, Right. Or three parts: Lifting, Moving, Setting.

I recommend just normal walking, just slower and with relaxed mindfulness.

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I'll end this with a caveat: although I warn against excessive concentration practice as being unbeneficial or even dangerous to some – for some others this practice, combined with insight, could be beneficial. Long hours of determined sitting has a long history in Vipassana, Zen, and many traditions. However for far too long an emphasis on concentration has been like a *sin quo non* of meditation practice. It's not one size fits all. The Buddha is said to have taught 84,000 doors to liberation. The problem isn't that it doesn't work – it may well work (for some people). The problem is that for some people it can be detrimental. Another problem is the striving for concentration is chasing another enlightenment carrot and even if some elusive ideal state is reached – if it's not delusional, it's just another something to be let go of.

Thosamling Nunnery is a nice center and hosts visiting dharma teachers.
Thosamling also offers Shamatha weekends. One taught by a Tibetan Geshe taught visualization on a meditation object. I am critical of meditation that emphasizes concentration. After years of practice, which probably 99% of meditators will never reach, the mind is supposed to be focused, supple, and blissful. The meditator can gaze at a flower or candle with single focus for hours. Now, according to their handout, the practitioner is ready to *start* to reflect on the Right View on Emptiness.

This seems like such a long, painful, and difficult path. And even if one can meditate on a candle for hours – so fuckin' what! How does that lead to insight or decrease suffering? It seems such a shame that this is how meditation is taught to beginner students. I don't object to concentration practices being taught – but why limit the class to only this method. Why not include Lojong, Tonglen, Shantideva Mind Trainings, Mindfulness of the Breath, Choiceless Awareness, Walking meditation, and Dzogchen.

It's annoying to see Meditation presented as Concentration. You'd think Tibetans wouldn't fall for it because Shamatha in Tibetan is translated to *Shinay* as *calm abiding.*

Another Point of View not advocating concentration here is found in the work of the Burmese Vipassana teacher, U Tejaniya who advocates a Relax, and Be Aware approach. U Tejaniya's books are available free for download from his website. I highly recommend his *Don't Look Down on the Defilements*

Available here:

https://ashintejaniya.org/books-dont-look-down-on-the-defilements

If you read and grok U Tejaniya it will save you a lot of time and pain.

Bhikkhu Thanissaro writes:

And as I've noticed in years since, people adept at blotting out large areas of awareness through powerful one-pointedness also tend to be psychologically adept at dissociation and denial. This is why Ajaan Fuang, following Ajaan Lee, taught a form of breath meditation that

aimed at an all-around awareness of the breath energy throughout the body, playing with it to gain a sense of ease, and then calming it so that it wouldn't interfere with a clear vision of the subtle movements of the mind. This all-around awareness helped to eliminate the blind spots where ignorance likes to lurk.

An ideal state of concentration for giving rise to insight is one that you can analyze in terms of stress and the absence of stress even while you're in it.
-- Bhikkhu Thanissaro. *Jhana Not By the Numbers.*
https://www.accesstoinsight.org/lib/authors/thanissaro/jhananumbers.html

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Hillside Hermitage. Ajahn Nyanamoli Thero.
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Why 'Focusing' Meditations are Wrong | by Ajahn Nyanamoli Thero

Harper's article, *Lost in Thought*
https://harpers.org/archive/2021/04/lost-in-thought-psychological-risks-of-meditation/

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Goenka Worldwide Vipassana Centers Discussion

I have some friends who are SN Goenka fans and they have many vipassana centers worldwide and an Internet presence at dhamma.org. The SN Goenka technique is good and it's fantastic that they operate on a donation - based model even in the West where retreats can be pricey. I did one of their retreats and on day two there was a two hour sit! I wouldn't recommend one of their retreats (especially for beginners) unless you can sit cross-legged fairly comfortably for two hours, take a five minute break and then come back and sit for an hour. Be prepared to do this pretty much all day for ten days. I'm wary of too much continuous sitting because of poor circulation in my legs. I've read articles that describe too much sitting to be as dangerous as smoking. The Goenka centers could fairly easily remedy the dangers of too much sitting by including alternate rounds of walking meditation. However it's hard for entrenched rigid semi cult-like religious systems, like Goenka, to change.

I understand why Goenka doesn't have walking meditation as you lose control over the yogi. The yogi leaves the meditation hall during walking meditation time, uses the bathroom, goes to get a jacket or mosquito repellent from their room, sits on their bed, digs around for a snack, eats it, maybe even God forbid lies down, etc -- all not really doing meditation. If you were doing a Vipassana program that had an individual walking meditation component in prison and the warden asked where is Inmate Jones right now -- the Retreat Manager would be hard pressed to say! Maybe they're in the bathroom, maybe reading a comic, maybe lying down, maybe even doing the proscribed walking meditation. Who knows?

Whereas in the Goenka method, they can look on their master schedule and say you're in a group sit as you haven't been reported absent. Really, they wouldn't even have to look at their schedule as you're almost always in a group sit with a Goenka curriculum. If you're not at the group sit, they come looking for you.

By the way, see the fine movie *Dhamma Brothers* about a Goenka retreat in prison. It's on my Google Cloud Drive #6:

https://drive.google.com/folderview?id=1-LkLHzsaBlgYx8mo3QRgNq5YffVYnlvC

I heartily recommend Goenka meditation for prisons --it seems about perfect for prison or for people who have little or no capability for self discipline and independent thought /s.

Contrast the SN Goenka sitting schedule with the Thai Doi Suthep Vipassana Center where Doi Suthep starts you off with ten minutes walking meditation and ten minutes sitting meditation which you're free to do on your own. Christopher Titmuss's retreats do sitting meditation too of course, but only 50 minutes or so, and chairs are always available (chairs are not usually available at SN Goenka retreats unless you have requested one beforehand. You are expected to meditate through any pain that comes up.) In Christopher Titmuss's retreats there's also walking meditation, group interviews, guided meditation, a dharma talk, and usually an evening inquiry. At Bodhizendo, the sits are 25 minutes and you can sit in a chair if you want to. Panditarama you set your own schedule and chairs are available. I made a nest of pads, cushions, and blankets at Panditarama and had a chair next to it. It paid off as I often would sit for hours.

Still, if you're in the West, don't rule out a Goenka retreat because they may be the only retreats that young people, students, senior citizens, those working a near minimum wage job, and the unemployed -- can afford. If you're not sure you can sit cross-legged for hours at a time, my advice is to request the option of a chair before the retreat on your admission form. I strongly suggest this especially for your first Goenka retreat. It can be difficult to get a chair once the Goenka retreat starts.

At a Goenka retreat, you must ask for permission to use a chair and it's often refused if you didn't get prior approval and you'll be told to meditate on the pain. That it's your samskaras coming out, and that you'll have pain after the retreat in your life so you may as well look at it now. This is kinda logical, it sounds plausible enough – but it's Wrong View. There's no stories of the Buddha ever requiring monks to sit past what they feel is enough.

Meditating through pain is asking a lot of someone, especially for beginners. It's poor teaching and pedagogy. And there's pain and then there's *pain*. Many Westerners are entirely unaccustomed to sitting cross-legged and now they're asked to do it 10-14 hours a day for ten days. Maybe it's not a minor pain like a routine mildish knee pain that could be dealt with, it's possibly loss of circulation, unhealthy for the body, and could lead to deep vein thrombosis (DVT) -- which is quite serious and can be lethal. Frankly, it's irresponsible for Goenka centers to mandate sitting, only schedule sitting (no walking meditation), and then Goenka management, who are usually part-time volunteers, refuse yogi requests to use a chair -- irrespective of physical pain and warning signs. See you in court. It won't be pretty. Not my circus though, and not my monkeys.

Pain and suffering is sure to come into our lives and meditation anyway, I don't understand the Goenka belief that somehow we need to propagate pain and so meditate and suffer. In the teachings, the Buddha and other teachers recommended a relaxed meditation posture. The Buddha rejected asceticism. If someone needs or wants a chair, let them use a chair. It's rather dictatorial to presume you know another person's pain, their physical condition, and their limits. Are you a f*cking doctor? Ultimately, it should be up to them.

Finally, it's wrong view to think a physical pain in the calf, for example, is a samkara instead of being caused by more mundane causes and conditions, i.e., poor circulation.

A Goenka person told me that 90% of Goenka retreatants never return and are not meditating in a year. A 90% failure rate sounds high to me. Anyway, I recommend that you ask for a chair option on your retreat application if it's your first Goenka retreat.

Not all Vipassana retreats are the same. Some, like the Goenka ones, are like a marathon, and if you're new and expecting a peaceful, blissful Retreat experience -- it's going to be a rude and painful awakening. Still, there's people who love running marathons. Like I said, I know several people who like Goenka retreats a lot. Often they tend to be young males without a ton of experience with other Vipassana systems or other meditation. I'm not trying to discount their own experience with Goenka. They had a good experience with Goenka and reading my write-up they don't understand my critique and position much. In my mind, I think if or when they get more experience with western Vipassana teachers and other styles of Vipassana – they may see where I'm coming from. I'd warn people who scuba dive against cave diving too – but sure I concede there's people knowledgeable and well prepared who do it and it's fine. They are not my audience here.

One acquaintance who read this section said I wasn't *wrong*, but Goenka practically saved his life when he was in a dark place and he deeply appreciated them and especially that the teachings are affordable. Fair enough. Not my preferred method, but each his own. This Guide doesn't seek to stop you from attending anything -- it's just my point-of-view and I hope it may be useful to others. If you know a Goenka retreat will be challenging, that it will be hard, that you may be counting the days until it ends, and you request a chair option beforehand and you're mentally prepared for a ten day slog -- you greatly increase your chances of successful completion and a good result -- and I've done my job and I'm happy. Or you could just shop around and go to a beginner friendly vipassana retreat and get all the benefits without the tears, stress, and possible grave physical consequences of too long continuous sitting.

It's a bit frustrating to me that when someone inquires about doing a Vipassana retreat on the Internet (e.g., Reddit), often the answers talk mainly of Goenka. It's like Vipassana=Goenka! (which may be because the reddit /r/vipassana subreddit is for the Goenka version of vipassana duhh …) There are other options. Most of them, in my opinion, probably far better for most beginners.

Here's a good take on Goenka by Christopher Titmuss:

https://www.christophertitmussblog.org/10-day-goenka-courses-in-vipassana-time-to-make-changes-12-firm-proposals

And a recent 2021 Christopher Titmuss Book review of Daniel Stuart's book *S. N. Goenka: Emissary of Insight*:

https://www.christophertitmussblog.org/s-n-goenka-emissary-of-insight-a-review-of-a-biography-by-daniel-m-stuart?fbclid=IwAR1ieENDdiP2c3G3_QTI-mooNrx81MAdBs_0fr5wgw5PGulevrJCG3mjInI

A good Harper's article.
Lost in Thought, by David Kortava.
https://harpers.org/archive/2021/04/lost-in-thought-psychological-risks-of-meditation/

Here's a recent 2024 critical podcast from Untold, *The Retreat*:

Untold: The Retreat about Goenka Vipassana retreats:

Untold: The Retreat #untoldTheRetreat
https://podcastaddict.com/podcast/untold-the-retreat/4822535

Although there may well be tens of thousands satisfied Goenka Vipassana customers – it can't really be denied that some people, like the people and families interviewed in the *Untold* podcast, had a terrible reaction from a Goenka retreat.

Here's a traveler take on her Goenka vipassana experience in Leh, India
https://www.natashathenomad.com/vipassana-meditation-leh-ladakh

And another person's experience with Goenka
https://humanparts.medium.com/what-really-went-down-at-a-10-day-silent-vipassasna-meditation-retreat-taught-by-s-n-goenka-7c3ad60d027e

Here's a Guardian article
https://www.theguardian.com/society/2016/mar/31/meditation-retreat-vipassana-new-zealand-exhausting-silence-spiders

And finally a good Esquire article where the Goenka yogi had to be institutionalized.
https://www.esquire.com/uk/latest-news/a25651175/the-other-side-of-paradise-how-i-left-a-buddhist-retreat-in-handcuffs/

There are Goenka vipassana centers all over the world. Go to the Goenka web site dhamma dot org for a list. Since you can probably do a Goenka retreat in your home country, if you come to Asia, I'd try something other than Goenka then. This guide is an attempt to provide information on some of the myriad possibilities on the spiritual path.

I have retreat-focused tips too in my guide to Dharma Books & Practice. See the FAQ in this Guide for example for retreat tips and even a suggested packing list.

https://docs.google.com/document/d/1hlk6x2XJy8ZQfdYYTibCx2ADRtZDLPqJifQrggic47k/edit?usp=drivesdk

Article India Syndrome
'Travelers who were lost forever': why tourists experience 'India syndrome' | Life and style | The Guardian

Tricycle article. *Meditation Sickness.*

https://tricycle.org/magazine/meditation-sickness/

Here are 12 Limits to Insight Meditation (Vipassana). Views, Beliefs and Concerns
By Christopher Titmuss

1 A view that morality/ethics are confined to the five precepts
2 An exaggerated emphasis on striving and strong determination
3 Belief that the path of insight meditation by itself leads to enlightenment
4 Belief in meditation, meditation, and more meditation
5 Belief practice is primarily a daily meditation, once or twice a day
6 Dryness of the formal practice,
7 Inability to cope with the wide variety of emotions
8 Ongoing adherence to the same techniques with one medicine for all attitude
9 Rigidity of views.
10 Tendency to go over the same old ground in the mind
11 Tendency to get stuck in the same method and technique
12 Treating sexuality only in moral terms or versus celibacy.

Our exploration includes practice of meditation, reflections on meditation/practice, questions and much more.

Retrieved
https://www.christophertitmussblog.org/what-are-the-limits-of-insight-meditation-vipassana-views-beliefs-concerns-reflection-questions

Selected Retreats Discussion & Reviews

Retreats in India

There are several dharma/spiritual centers in India: Dharamsala (McLeod Ganj and surrounding Himachal Pradesh region), Bodhgaya, Tiruvannamalai (Advaita) and Rishikesh (yoga). There's also a dharma scene in neighboring Boudhanath, Nepal but I haven't spent much time there.

What makes India special is the Dharma scene in places like Dharamsala, Rishikesh, Bodhgaya, and Tiruvannamalai. Thailand is great for Theravada Vipassana centers. But the difference is, in Thailand, around one Vipassana center that'll be all there is probably Dharma-wise. Sure, it's a fine center in Thailand, but that center is it in that area. In India in

places like Rishikesh it’s full of yoga places and in season several satsangs. In Tiruvannamalai, in season there's a circus of satsangs.

I go from area to area, north and south India, and at the end I can start my dharma circuit over again. If it's Spring it might start with Dharamsala, Dharamsala - South India - Tiruvannamalai (Late Fall & Early Winter) - Bodhgaya - Rishikesh (early Spring). After Rishi in April, it starts to get hot, and Dharamsala area is much cooler and there's a lot going on. Rinse & repeat (visa permitting …).

If you go to one of these places you'll find out many opportunities from other travelers and notice boards. Be aware that the scene in these places is very seasonal. Bodhgaya is popular in winter when many Tibetans come down from the mountains. If you go to Bodhgaya in the summer you'll bake in one of the hottest places on the planet, wonder where everyone is at, and there won't be much going on.

Sometimes people will recommend not going to a place like Rishikesh or Dharamsala (McLeod Ganj) in April high season because of over tourism, but if you're staying in a retreat it really doesn't matter so much. Then there's the fact that teachings, courses, and satsangs are often scheduled during the busy season. Sure, McLeod Ganj is overcrowded in April and May. Last time there I spent a couple nights, shopped, enjoyed the many delicious restaurants in McLeod, got my Bir Restricted Area Permit, then went to Deer Park in Bir for several teachings. After a month, I came back to McLeod and immediately went to Tushita for a ten day course on Peaceful Living & Dying. For a few days, I enjoyed McLeod well enough, even in high spring season. I've also been in McLeod in the Fall, and it didn't seem all that different. There's still severe traffic issues. McLeod is just too small for all the cars. Perhaps Dharamkot sees a bigger difference. I could see Dharamkot being better in the Fall.

Rishikesh too in high spring season has satsangs. Sure, April in Rishi may be less crowded, but satsang season is over and Rishi gets really hot!

If you listen to a hipster and visit McLeod in January you'll avoid tourists all right but it will be *cold* and not much will be happening. Tushita will be closed. March is a very popular month for Panditarama Lumbini because of terrific weather. If you decide to miss the crowd and instead go in April, you'll suffer in the heat and find Panditarama closes sometime in April. I like Tiruvannamalai sorta (mixed feelings), but show up in Tiru in April and it will be sweltering also with not much going on and you'll wonder what's the attraction. You could really miss out on great retreats and teachings.

I recommend if it's your first time don't be afraid of high season. It's not really a problem and if you're keen to do a retreat or attend teachings it may be a necessity. If you try to be clever and go off season you could miss out. On the other hand, if you know what you're doing, are an India vet, are familiar with the area and what's going on and when -- then sure, strike out on your own. If you've already done your retreats and courses, are open for a self retreat and be on

your own, don't mind the cold, have local friends in the area -- then perhaps McLeod in January could be the dog's bollocks. It might be empty enough you might be able to walk down the narrow streets of McLeod without feeling you're at risk of being nicked by a car's side mirror.

See relevant sections of the *Lonely Planet India* Guide. Although nowadays, like a lot of stuff, the quality of Lonely Planet has gone to crap. Consider Rough Guide instead. Don't make the mistake of waiting to be in India before reading up on India and especially read up beforehand on travel scams. As there's scams waiting for you even at the airport. Take the prepay taxi or perhaps even better ask your Guesthouse for a taxi on arrival. Make sure you're taken to the Guesthouse you request. Don't believe anyone who says your Guesthouse is closed or there's rioting between Hindus and Moslems. Very old cons but I know two young British backpackers who were tired after getting off the plane, then were approached and asked if they needed a cab. Since they did, and were tired from their flight, they took the easy way and just went with the man. The driver supposedly called their Guesthouse on his phone and the driver said the Guesthouse was closed. Not to worry, the helpful taxi driver had another good guesthouse he recommended. Then the friendly taxi driver took the lads to an *official* (not really...) India travel agency who confirmed that there was rioting in New Delhi and the best thing was to book a car and driver tour package and get out of Delhi. All lies, golden oldies really, but still they work, evidently. The real Guesthouse called their home number in the UK and asked why didn't they show up. Their second mistake was not going to the Prepaid Taxi booth. Their first mistake was not reading up on scams and basic information useful upon arrival.

If you arrive in New Delhi there's two popular budget places to stay. The Tibetan Colony, Majnu ka Teela, is good if you're heading to Dharamsala and surrounding Himachal Pradesh. Parhanganj is good if you're taking a train somewhere. Paharganj is a madhouse though, crowded and a bit dodgy. Read about common India scams before your trip. If it's your first trip to India and you've just stepped off the plane, Paharganj is an assault on your senses.

Connaught Place is nearby, on a metro stop, has lots of good restaurants, and overall might be a more sane place for a stay.

Still, Paharganj is right next to the New Delhi Train Station, so it's convenient. As a Westerner you may be a target for salespeople, transport people, guesthouse touts, and scammers. My rule is simply keep walking when approached. It's up to you if you talk to them or not as you walk. Many times I do--as long as I keep walking it's fine and I don't mind keeping it friendly. Sometimes if you're rude to a tuk tuk driver you may see him around where you're staying for days as it's like his area and post. Maybe one day you do need a tuk tuk ride. Better to keep it civil. Plus, tempting as it may be to tell them to sod off, they are human beings and it's not an easy life for them either. My pro tip is to learn their names and use it the next time you see them and ask them about how their day is going.

For females it may be better to ignore them and focus on where you're going. And don't believe anyone who tells you anything while you're walking: that your guesthouse is closed or that the

Train Ticket Tourist Office has moved. These are old scams. A good general rule on the street is not to be distracted enough to stop and also never allow yourself to be rushed either. If someone is telling you that your bus left early but you can catch it if you hurry and follow them to the bus's next stop--I'd take my chances and continue on to the original bus stop. Stick with your original plan. See with your own eyes that the guesthouse or tourist office or site is closed. You can change plans then.

In Paharganj New Delhi, I stay at Cottage Yes Please, not to be confused with Guest house Yes Please (which I confused and mixed up when I was very sick). Cottage Yes Please is very near the Imperial Movie Theatre. It's also near Natraj Yes Please (a sister guesthouse) and both Major's Den and Backpacker Panda. All are good choices and friendly places. So you have multiple choices if one is full. Cottage Yes Please is about a 20 minute walk from the New Delhi Rail Station through crowded, narrow, and mad Paharganj. Have your game face on. Just keep calm and keep walking. Pretend like you've been there before and are a bit bored. Or it's a 70 rupee tuk tuk ride from the New Delhi train station. If it's your first time there, and you've got gear, I'd pay the $1 for a ride. To be honest, it's not a bad idea to pay the $1 even if it's not your first time there.

Let me repeat: Paharganj, New Delhi is mad. Be prepared for its chaos and intensity. If you're prepared, you'll find it's not that bad. You walk, ignore the touts with a smile, and you'll get to your destination. Don't get stopped and sucked into tout drama on the street and you'll make your life less complicated.

The staff at Cottage Yes Please were very kind to me when I arrived from Dharamsala with cellulitis in my leg. They went above and beyond. Two staff helped me walk to my room as I could hardly put weight on my leg. When I was discharged from Max Sackett Hospital in New Delhi I came back to Cottage Yes Please. I had home nurse visitation and the staff showed the visiting my nurse my room. When the nurse started the process of bandaging my leg, the staff member didn't leave. I thought of asking him to leave, privacy you know, but meh, couldn't really be bothered. As it was, the nurse could use a hand to help raise my leg while the nurse bandaged it. So the young man was glad to help! And not only that day. The next day the nurse was back to clean my leg and put on a fresh bandage, and my friend the young staff member, showed him to my room again, stayed, and assisted. This is hardly in his duties. This is one of those nice things that happen in India. I gave him a nice tip at the end of my stay.

There's excellent restaurants across from Cottage Yes Please. The Cottage Yes Please room service food is quite tasty too. I recommend the veg curry. Across the street the chicken tandoori at Cafe Malhotra is delicious and reasonably priced.

I often recommend people get out of the India big cities as soon as possible. Maybe not even leaving the airport and instead, depending on the season, catching a flight to North India, and the Himalayas, or South India, and Tamil Nedu or Kerala. You're far, far better off starting off in India in the very north or the very south. Why not fly into Bangalore if you're doing South India?

Most of the India travel horror stories happen in the big cities in the center.

Tushita is a Tibetan Dharma center in Dharamkot, just outside of McLeod Ganj, Dharamsala. Tushita is one of the Dharma centers run by the Foundation for the Preservation of the Mahayana Tradition (FPMT). The FPMT runs centers all over the world. The FPMT was started by Lama Yeshe and Lama Zopa in the 1970s. Tushita has a well regarded *Introduction to Buddhism* course and also runs other cool courses and talks. Tushita is well known and a quality place. I recommend their courses. The courses are good for meeting other dharma people too.

Tushita and the FPMT do things right. My only complaint at Tushita are the monkeys. The monkeys will mess with you. Newbs identify themselves by their monkey reaction: Newbs may think the monkeys are cute and try to get a selfie with them -- they'll learn soon enough when a big monkey leaps on their picnic table and screams at them so as to intimidate them into giving up their snack. People do get bit by the monkeys too. Of course, being a Gelugpa branch of Tibetan Buddhism, Tushita says it's because these people, even nuns, have poor monkey karma! Because there's many people who do not get bit. Tushita I think has a local guy whose job during meals is to keep the monkeys from hijacking tables. So if you have bad monkey karma, be wary of Tushita or bring a walking stick or large sturdy umbrella.

(Game: Endeavor to use the term "monkey karma" as often as possible in your Tushita class. Double points if you get the instructor using it.)

Tushita has sister institutions with Root Institute in Bodhgaya and Kopan Monastery outside of Kathmandu in Nepal.

All run regular dharma courses. Kopan Monastery runs a famous one month Lam Rim course every November. Check Kopan's website and sign up first day for the November course as it tends to fill quickly and the best rooms go quick. Usually registration for the November course opens in July or August.

It's important to realize the difference between a Vipassana center and a Dharma Center like Tushita. A Vipassana Center or Meditation Center will focus on meditation. Though they may have supporting activities. Dharma centers like Tushita, Root Institute, and Deer Park may not emphasize meditation much at all. Instead it's Dharma courses and talks. You'll have a completely different experience doing Tushita’s ten day Introduction to Buddhism course versus a ten day vipassana meditation course. Do both if you can.

Many travelers refer to Dharamshala, McLeod Ganj, and Dharamkot nearly as the same place. McLeod Ganj is just up a hilly twisty road from Dharamsala. Dharamkot is up another hilly road from McLeod. There's a real Dharma scene in the Dharamsala area with three top retreat places with Tushita, Thosamling nunnery, and Deer Park Bir headlining.

McLeod Ganj is a traveler Mecca. Try the Tibetan momos and Butter chicken at Tibetan Kitchen. They are delicious. Snow lion cafe and Nick's Italian are backpacker favorites. I often run into people I know from other places and Nick's Italian's terrace is a good place for this. Four Seasons is a small, cute, not fancy place with great food.

Shangri-la Vegetarian Restaurant, which is run by a monastery, serves large portions at good prices. Shangri-la's banana pancake is thick and like a banana cake! -- not to be missed. My only gripe about Shangri-la is that they should have a pot, half pot or French press coffee option. Otherwise it seems perfect. I tried getting them to make me a pot of coffee too but although I was optimistic that I'd gotten my point across, still there's a language barrier with the monks that work there and I'd end up just getting a cup of coffee. Multiple times. So no, my life is *not* perfect!

I often stay at Kaeriri Lodge there as it's a friendly, small, well-located place that takes reservations. Other cheaper places in McLeod Ganj such as Om Guesthouse, Loseling Guesthouse, or Tibetan Ashoka Guesthouse do not. Krishna Boutique Hotel and Kunga Guesthouse are nice. A German friend of mine stays in the Green Hotel and likes it for its cafe and terrace. There's tons of nice 5 star reviewed guest houses in Mcleod.

Up another hill from McLeod Ganj is Tushita which often holds Buddhist courses and a daily free drop in meditation session. Tushita is next to Dharamkot which is another backpacker Mecca. McLeod Ganj can be a bit mad with too many cars and thirty minute traffic jams. Dharamkot (little Tel Aviv) is quieter, there's not a road, at least a good road, that goes through it, yet, which is an advantage. Dharamkot is very popular and seems entirely Guesthouses and restaurants though they do get full during high season. It's hard to describe Dharamkot as you almost need a 3D map. A place can show up nearly right next to another place but be a 20 minute walk up a steep hill.

In Dharamkot, Paul's House is a good choice with a good location. There's also a good value guesthouse just below Paul's. I stayed at Conifer Lodge, a bit further further down from Paul's. Conifer is next to the Iyengar Yoga Himalayan Center. There are several unmarked/unsigned Guesthouses around Henna cafe in Upper Dharamkot which are quiet and good value. I often had breakfast at Moonlight cafe or Milky Way cafe and the owner seemed very nice and helpful and also has rooms to rent.

I did two weeks at the Dharamkot Iyengar Yoga Himalayan Center. It's a bit more expensive than the many drop-in yoga classes around. It's three hours of practice straight-thru a day. That seems like a lot, but there were some days that it was twenty minutes before we moved to our second pose. There were people in the class who'd completed yoga teacher training in some other yoga, mixed in with beginners, but Iyengar is so different, it was fine. The best part was the care and assistance into getting into poses. The teachers might surround you with cushions for a twenty minute child's pose. It could feel pretty luxurious. They asked at orientation the first day for any injuries and it seemed the majority of people had knee or back issues. Iyengar yoga

is very good for people with injuries. Iyengar is big on alignment and using props. The second week curriculum is more challenging with handstands. I learned a lot, especially about alignment and proper care for the neck. A negative is doing the Iyengar yoga sequences at home or on the road could be a chore because sometimes it takes ten minutes to set up an Iyengar pose with all the mats, blankets, and straps. The center also has a more isolated Ashram further in the mountains that does yoga camps. They do a Yoga for Vipassana Meditators course in Dharamkot during the year. Check their website. Just as I stress Vipassana can be very different, yoga can be too. An Iyengar class here isn't like most yoga. Go and watch a class beforehand and you'll see.

Just up the hill from Iyengar in Dharamkot, is a branch of Universal Yoga. The head teacher, Vijay, has an excellent reputation.

People always seem happy with their yoga classes though. A friend took several Sivananda style yoga classes on the other side of Dharamkot, down from Ever Green cafe and liked it.

A Wolf tip: I have many yoga videos on my tablet. I download yoga YouTube videos. It's nice having excellent free instruction. On YouTube, I recommend Yoga With Adrian, Ekhart Yoga, Yoga With Kassandra for yin style yoga, and for a bit harder yoga try Yoga/Movement with Tim Senesi, Sean Vigue, and Five Parks Yoga.

On my cloud, I have some bodyweight calisthenic training books, such as *Convict Conditioning*. Doing bodyweight training is a good change of pace from yoga. Also look at HIIT (High Intensity Interval Training). All these work well on the road. See my FAQ in my Dharma Book and Practice Guide for a no mat room yoga routine and a HIIT workout.

Tushita has a webpage with links to various Buddhist teachings in and around town:

http://tushita.info/links/buddhism-in-dharamsala/

Thosamling Nunnery is a wonderful place and has started running regular short Shamatha (concentration) meditation courses (open to everyone) and other events. I've known several friends who stayed there for an individual retreat and loved it. It's a nunnery but welcomes everyone.

Thosamling hosts visiting teachers and events. They're getting to be like Tushita. Check their schedule. It appears in 2024 that events can be posted on short notice. So it pays to recheck their schedule.

Thosamling is a beautiful, friendly place with great food perfect for a self-retreat too. Although it would probably be nice if you participate in a retreat or event. A friend of mine stayed for a month and attended an event by the popular Geshe Dorje Damdul. Although if you're doing a self-retreat, and wanting perfect quiet and silence – be aware that sixty students can come in for an event, all excited to be there, and talking. In Gelugpa Tibetan Buddhism, silent meditation isn't really emphasized. Geshe Damdul's course was a lot of lectures and talking. Other than your fellow guests, Thosamling is a quiet place. Very much recommended. Although if you attend an event primarily, your experience will be influenced by whether you liked the teachings and teacher. A Shamatha weekend taught by a Geshe taught meditation as concentration and visualization which isn't my cuppa chai (See the section here on Concentration & Rigidity, More Concentration, 'Mo Problems).

A friend of mine did a Thosamling Shamatha retreat after me with Aileen Barry and said it was the best thing she experienced in her life.

Thosamling is a wonderful place. I recommend it for a course and a private retreat. My only suggestion is that I wish the Thosamling library was open everyday, perhaps manned by volunteers, like the Bodhizendo library. I also think having one required group sit in the morning, say 6:15-7:00 might also help build community. Otherwise too people can come and pay little and treat it like a holiday camp.

It's a ten minute walk to Thosamling through a wheat field on a narrow concrete path. Most cabs familiar with the place dropoff on second road on left from highway. If your taxi isn't familiar, look on Google maps for: past Nandini cottages, school ground, near Khunde Khangsar, Architect Singh. There's a Thosamling sign, small pedestrian bridge, and narrow concrete path to Thosamling. Otherwise if you get off at another place nearby like I did, you'll probably have to take a path through wheat fields until you get to the narrow concrete path.

I had a beautiful nice room with a bath, with a geyser, with all meals for 1300inr. Wifi available throughout the compound. Dorms are available. Thosamling gets full for events. If you're staying long-term on a private retreat, and a big sellout event comes through (like Geshe Damdul), you might have to leave and make room or sign up for the event yourself.

Thosamling also has a yearly Winter retreat open to all. It'll be cold-ish there but I suppose your retreat mates will be dedicated yogis (Or Swedes).

Deer Park in Bir, Himachal Pradesh, North India is similar to Tushita in that they run regular courses. You can also stay at Deer Park between courses. It's a pleasant place to stay. I stayed for a month there and liked it quite a bit. Nice staff. You pay for each meal you take and I thought the food was good. Although it's often minimalistic, it's fine. I love dhal bhat. But mine seems to be a minority opinion. Two friends rank the food at Deer Park as terrible.

Unfortunately, Bir doesn't have much in good restaurants, although I heard a pretty good one recently opened up close to Deer Park. NOTE: I returned in 2019, Bir has improved in the last two years, there's more restaurants and homestays. it's still no McLeod Ganj, but it's significantly better. A small place, SK Food Point, just meters off the main Bir Tibetan Colony Main road has beautiful cappuccinos and an excellent value food selection. It's a Wolf favorite. Nyingma cafe is a nice coffee bar too and next to Nyingma cafe is Nyingma kitchen which serves meals. Personally, I think the Deer Park food is fine, although extremely basic in 2024. One lunch we had lentil dhal and bread. That's all. Nothing to write home about. Still they only charge 150inr so I'm okay with it.

I'd say Deer Park is a relaxed place for self retreat. I tried to do some slow mindful walking around Deer Park and twice I had nice people approach me and ask if I needed help or even a cane. I suppose walking meditation isn't so much of a Tibetan thing. I then would go to a nearby stupa to slow walk as it's more obvious around a stupa it's a meditational thing. There's a wifi area at the Deer Park meal area and people talk. There's not many people doing a strict retreat there. I found my fellow retreat participants (majority Indians) for a Theravada meditation retreat very curious and very friendly. Many wanted to talk Dharma after the retreat. Thosamling was also good for this too.

Deer Park can be more like a hotel, than a strict formal meditation center, and it doesn't bill itself as a meditation center. Still, it doesn't stop you from meditating in your room. Deer Park and Thosamling are favorites of mine.

In the summer of 2017 Deer Park started a one month Rains Retreat Dathun which gets good reviews. You can stay at Deer Park if you've signed up for an event. There's also Hari Om Guesthouse which is a cheap, excellent value, and a close by alternative. Unfortunately there’s no shortcut direct path between Hari Om and Deer Park and I have that on fairly good authority as it would change a 15 minute or so walk to 5. Paloma Guesthouse and Vegan cafe is more upscale.

There's also Dharmalaya in Bir which has an Ashram you can stay at for eco work-retreats. I've known several people who did a work-retreat there and liked it. One mentioned he particularly liked making the mud bricks. Bir is also big for paragliding which for about 2k rupees (about $30) you can do a tandem flight.

Beware of the dogs near Deer Park as they seem to bite people all the time. It's crazy. Next time I may buy a trekking pole in Dharamsala to carry with me for dogs. If you're reading this guide in your home country, you might look into getting a pre Rabies vaccine as India has a high rate of rabies. In 2019, the dog situation seems to have improved somewhat, but it's still recommended to walk on main roads, give dogs a wide berth, and to keep your head on a swivel. I'm not sure which are worse, the monkeys at Tushita or the dogs in Bir.

Close to Bir is the beautiful Sherab Ling Monastery which does an occasional event. Tai Situ (it's his monastery) and Mingyur Rinpoche hold talks there. You can also stay there in an on site Guesthouse on an individual retreat. Although it's a bit strange to recommend any particular place for an independent retreat since you could setup your own retreat anywhere I suppose. Sherabling is peaceful though.

Also close to Bir (2 km) is Gunehar. National Geographic did an article on it.

https://natgeotraveller.in/fine-art-finer-air-in-himachals-gunehar/

Tenzin Palmo has a nunnery, Dongyu Gatsal Ling (DGL), in Himachal Pradesh, about 2/3rds of the way to Bir from Dharamsala. When she's there, she has days and time slots she's available for interviews, that you can sign up for. She gives good practice advice and is an effin' impressive lady. Read about her meditation for years in a cave in: *Cave in the Snows*. DGL also has facilities for experienced women meditators for a self retreat.

Hampi town way down in Karnataka gets mixed reviews: The ruins are amazing but it can seem overrun with tourists. Hampi unfortunately seems to be one of those places that *was* pretty cool -- ten years ago. Still, it can be nice shoulder season and if you get out of town a bit. Badami has ruins too and is quieter and might be worth checking out.

There's overnight buses from Hampi to Gokarna which has beautiful beaches. Gokarna is a better value than Goa generally and is very popular with the backpacker circuit and long term India vets. Recently Gokarna made a list of World's best secret beaches, so it's probable it will see an influx of tourists. Which means it may get the Hampi treatment. Some beaches like Om beach already have a problem with trash, partying, sleeping on the beach, and all night rave music. There's a Zostel hostel branch in Gokarna at still nice Kudle beach and Zostels generally get good reviews. I've heard there's a branch of the Bihar school of Yoga just outside of town.

Mysore, Karnataka is a beautiful city. Mysore makes it on a lot of traveler favorites lists, but it's a large city so it doesn't feel so overrun. It's on a plateau so the weather is more temperate. Mysore is a city you can walk around in and not feel you're taking your life in your own hands because of traffic. Gokulam, Mysore has a lot of yoga places, cafes, and health food shops. Gokulam has a green smoothie type scene. There's a ton of nice cafes in Gokulam, but a friend said she had the best meal she's had in India at Mystic Rose cafe.

The Gokulam neighborhood of Mysore is like the South Beach of India. Mysore is famous for yoga, primarily Ashtanga style. I like Mysore quite a bit. If you're into Ashtanga or Power yoga -- you'll probably enjoy staying for a couple months in Mysore. I stayed at a place called Vertical Gardens, in Gokulam, which was cheap, with very basic plywood cell-like rooms but the host was friendly and nice and he makes the place. Vertical Gardens, like the name suggests, is overrun with plants. There's a discount if you're associated with an Ashram or something I think. Associated is a loose enough word, that I'd consider an email to a center or Ashram an

association. Om Shanti Guesthouse is also a cheapie in the posh area with all the necessities and was recommended.

A yoga place in Mysore highly recommended to me for all levels is Yoga Vasha which has five star reviews on Google maps.

Bodhi Zendo is a highly rated zen meditation center just outside of Kodaikanal in Tamil Nadu, southern India. Believe it or not, this is a Zen center (and an excellent one!) -- and it's run by the Jesuits! Believe it or not! But it's cool, it's a good crowd with Buddhists, Zen people, Christians, Hindus, Moslems, Jewish people (Israelis), and Advaita people practicing Zen together. Don't sweat it if you're not a Zen person and don't know anything about Zen or if your main practice is something else, it's not a problem. Father Ama Samy, a Jesuit priest and Zen master and founder of Bodhizendo, is one of the most impressive teachers I've met in Asia. His Zen is Zen, not a Christian version of Zen, nor is his Christianity a Zen version of Christianity. But his teaching is also eclectic in that he'll often bring in teachings from other religions into his teishos (talks) and books as well as bringing in psychology and philosophy. In 2018, Father Cyril received Zen transmission and in 2020 Father Ama moved down the hill to construct a new Zen center, Kanzeon Zen Center. I visited Bodhizendo in 2022 and Father Cyril along with Sister Severina are doing an excellent job running things.

Bodhi Zendo fills up so it's imperative to make a booking way in advance (many months ahead, even a year -- isn't too long) especially if you plan to stay for a longer time. Otherwise email them, cross your fingers, and hope there's a cancellation and you can get in for at least a short retreat. Mention your dates are flexible and see if there's any space available for even part of your dates. Once you're in, it's likely you can then extend your stay as people cancel all the time because there's no deposit.

Bodhi Zendo is one of my favorite places with nice basic single rooms, a beautiful zen garden, a small Internet center, and a very nice little library. Sometimes I've been asked if there's another place I've found that's like Bodhizendo and, to be honest, I haven't found a place that's as conducive to my practice as Bodhizendo. If there's a gem among my list of retreat centers, I'd say it would be Bodhizendo. Of course, meditation centers, methods, styles, and preferences are an individual matter. Still, among the crowd of dharma bums I know in India, while there's often diverse opinions regarding styles of vipassana or a particular teacher, or practically anything -- opinions concerning Bodhizendo tend to be always favorable. It's a different type of retreat than a vipassana retreat so don't be afraid to book a longish stay. In 2019, Bodhizendo started requiring stays of more than thirty days to have administrative approval. It's pretty easy to get, promise to attend all sittings (have a good attendance record) and be a person who's willing to help out when needed. Don’t cause drama.

My only negatives about Bodhizendo are smallish ones: Bodhizendo is often full, the food can be pretty spicy, sometimes they can run short of a dish if you're near the end of the line, the weather isn't always perfect – it can be chilly and rainy, indoor kinhen walking meditation *sucks*

(in my opinion, though hardly a big deal), they should replace sponges regularly, and for true beginners, there's not a lot of explicit instruction, interviews, or coaching (though this is consistent with a zen approach. You're expected to follow along). If you want a guru to explain to you your life path, or explain the minutiae of the breath and meditation practice, or breakdown why your relationships have failed, Bodhizendo isn't really the place. My practice doesn't really change at Bodhizendo at all when the zen masters have both been absent. Why would it?

Bodhizendo is a relaxed place and helpful if you are independent and have your own practice as there's little hand holding outside of the scheduled Sesshin retreat times. Most of the time it's a pretty easy daily schedule outside of the twice monthly Sesshins so it's good if you have things you can do on your own. I do yoga while I'm there, read, go for walks, sit in the Zen garden, watch birds, nap, as well as the daily 3.5 hour of group meditation sits. Some people want a more rigorous schedule but my response is hey, you're an adult make your own schedule. Sit as long as you like.

You're liable to make friends at Bodhi Zendo. It's all pretty sweet. Don't miss Bodhi Zendo if you can. Don't forget it's a fine idea to read books in the same style as the retreat or ashram you're attending. Father Ama Samy has written some really excellent books. A couple of his books are available on Amazon.

People, and that includes me, often book their Bodhizendo stays well in advance – sometimes even a year in advance. If you email Bodhizendo for a month stay and find its full, you might see if there's any open dates in that month you can get in for a shorter stay. Once in, it's likely you can extend. Or get on a waiting list if you're in the area. Don't give up easily.

There's also hippie-ish resorts too. Try Karuna farms which is not far from Bodhi Zendo. I've, umm, heard of psychedelic mushrooms in the area. Vattakanal is popular with young Israelis.

The Madurai Sivananda yoga ashram would be a good choice if you like yoga and it's only a couple hours away.

Making Bodhizendo an even more attractive destination is the nearby hill station Kodaikanal (Kodai) which is known for its chocolate! Kodaikanal is cooler than the rest of Tamil Nedu and has its own weather system. You can visit here in summer and during Tamil Nadu's monsoon season, no problem. There's not really a bad time to visit Bodhizendo.

UPDATE: In 2023, Father Ama has opened up a new, smaller center, Kanzeon Zendo, formerly Little Flower Zen Center, for his students to study under him. Kanzeon Zendo / Little Flower Zen Center is close to Bodhizendo, just down the mountain from BZ really, in Perumalmalai. I'm not providing more information because for new people you should probably do a retreat at Bodhizendo first and also meet Father Ama and get his okay for a stay at Little Flower. Although recently I've seen new people join at Kanzeon too and it's cool.

I stayed at Kanzeon Zendo in 2023 & 2025, and if you're familiar with Bodhizendo, Kanzeon is, to quote a well known Thai T shirt slogan from some years ago, *Same-same – but different*. Kanzeon Zen is similar quality as Bodhi Zendo – top-notch. I've half-joked that if Kanzeon Zen was in the Andaman Islands or Mysore and not just down the hill and of the Bodhi Zendo family – I'd be raving about it here. There's little need for me to talk about it because if you're the target group for Kanzeon Zen, you most likely already know about it. It's a beautiful place though if you're interested in Zen, I'd probably still recommend staying at Bodhizendo first. I had written here that the policy at Kanzeon Zendo was for new people to follow along best they could as there was no orientation but it seems now that there's an orientation so new people aren't on their backfoot as much. I suppose if Bodi Zendo is full, one might well consider Kanzeon. If only Kanzeon was in the Andaman's…

In Kodaikanal, Astoria Veg restaurant has nice dosas along with coffee and chai. It's a nice place to chill. Near Astoria is the Pastry Corner which is wicked good. The Pastry Corner is not to be missed. Everything is good there. Can't hardly say enough about how special this small place is. Enjoy two slices of delicious pizza, a slice of homemade chocolate cake, and a coffee for 90 rps (about $1.25). Sometimes the owner gives out free samples. She's a real bodhisattva.

Next door to the pastry shop is an excellent kashmiri store, Shalimar Weaves, that sells high quality shawls. I recommend shawls as they're especially convenient not only for Indian weather but also meditation halls as they're easy and quiet to take on and off. Ask for the bodhi zendo discount if you're planning a stay there.

There's many chocolate shops in Kodai, but my favorite place to get chocolate is The Potter's Shed (now renamed Earthen Works) on Cloud street. Second floor, they sell mostly pottery but also have wonderful home made chocolates. I recommend the chocolate covered coffee beans, dark chocolate, and don't miss the roasted almond cookie and biscuits. The Earthen Works / Potter's Shed is on Google maps. Plus proceeds go to charity and Reena has an amazing memory and is absolutely lovely. I think Reena is my favorite store staff ever.

If you're on your way to Bodhi Zendo, stocking up on chocolate is recommended. It would be wonderful to gift chocolates to the Zendo leader, librarian, your Seva work mates, and helpful people at Bodhizendo. Tell them you read of this in Wolf's guide. Chocolate, like coffee, brings people closer together. You're paying f*ck all for your stay at Bodhizendo, so you can splurge and bring chocolates. It will be appreciated and you'll stand out. Small, thoughtful gifts are not a bad idea for all retreats if you can manage it. There's a saying in the running community who get volunteers to work races: *Never underestimate the power of a T-shirt!* Monk satchels, small micro LED keychain flashlights, a good pair of socks, a locally-made handmade journal, chocolate (although chocolate melts in most of India) -- all can make nice inexpensive gifts. Some people recommend chocolates from Meltiez Chocolate Factory on Main Bazaar Road. They're a bit more expensive than next door competitors, but their dark chocolate has more chocolate, less sugar.

In addition, Father Ama & Chitra also run a fine charity, Little Flower, that will put any donations to very good use. Read the Little Flower reports for some moving stories. Please consider contributing--even just a few dollars or Euros goes unbelievably far. Like $15 will pay a girl's school fee *for a semester* and determines whether she gets an education or not. Many local laborers make less than $1 a day! -- but that's alright, that's liveable -- in fact, that's common, and many poor Indian families do manage. But imagine cases where the husband dies, leaving behind a widow with kids -- and one of the children, or the widow, or both, has health problems. These are the cases Little Flower helps along with orphans, special needs, and the elderly who have no one. You can also contribute online I believe too, see the Bodhi Zendo or the Kanzeon website.

A blog post (two parts) on Father Ama Samy and Bodhi zendo (He likes the place and sounds impressed with Father Ama):
https://www.zenrants.com/blog/surfing-zen-masters

In Madurai, I like Mani Residency, 5 Town Hall Road, for lodging. It's good value, good location. Near Mani is Hotel Sree Sabarees -- it's called Hotel but it's a restaurant. Calling something a hotel for what's really a restaurant is common in Sri Lanka too. Whatever it's called, they serve delicious South Indian food, fast, and good value. Delicious south Indian filter coffee too. Don't miss it.

There's a couple Christian Ashrams in Tamil Nedu that have gotten good reviews. Close to Tiruchirappalli (Trichy) is Shantivanam or Saccidananda Ashram. This ashram is associated with the late Father Bede Griffiths. The author and teacher Rupert Sheldrake has stayed here and talks well of it. There's also another Ashram like next door, Ananda Ashram, run by nuns.

Interview with Father Bede

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Here is an extended review of Shantivanam 2023 by Chris:

The historical background is that the saintly Benedictine monk Father Bede Griffiths took over and made this ashram near Thannirpalli his home back in the 1960s. He was a pioneer in the awareness that he himself — and all people from whatever religious background — can learn from and gain by exposing themselves to the traditions and teachings of other faiths. For Father Bede, he made it his life's mission to allow Christians and Hindus to do that in the peaceful environs of this ashram by the banks of the River Kauveri near Trichy in Tamil Nadu.

I first visited it and stayed here in February 1991 while Fr. Bede was still alive. Then the majority of guests seemed to me to be young, western travellers\backpackers with Christian backgrounds who were curious visitors to a space where 'East meets West' was made available to them in an Indian setting, but grounded in Christian monasticism. With the presence of commited Christian monks who shared their teachings and led by example, Fr. Bede created a great place for Indians to learn about or deepen their Christian faith and for Christians to delve into Hindu wisdom and traditions.

Today under the current guidance of a wonderful, friendly, humble monk Father Dorathick Rajjan, that tradition is still being carried on.

The Ashram has grown in size since 1991. More accommodation is available, so now no dormitory accommodation is needed.

There is also now a wall surrounding it. The only difference with that is that there are now restrictions on how late you can stay out if you visit the nearby town.

Another big difference seemed to me to be that there are less people visiting, and those that do visit appeared to me to be, in the majority, more commited and more mature in their spiritual questing. Which I see as a plus.

There is eat-as-much-as-you-want, south-Indian, vegetarian food available at set times, three times a day. For some it is quite spicy, so be prepared for that.

There is free internet available at specific times a day.Coffee and chai are served twice a day.

Some light service is expected for an hour around 9:00 am. Cutting vegetables together is the norm, though as I was trying to maintain silence I got the job of keeping the graves of the founders in good order, which I did alone.

There is an abundance of fruit grown here: bananas, papayas, mangoes, coconuts, etc.

There is ample lighting along the pathways at night, but bring a torch-light.

They have their own well, so I drank the tap water and never got ill. For those not so daring there is filtered water available. For the most cautious, bottled water is available to purchase.

Books, toilet paper, anti-mosquito cream, shoulder bags and other necessities are also available from the office for purchase.

The Guest-Master, soon-to-be-ordained Brother Martin, was helpful and available for any problems or questions. E.g. when I had difficulty booking my train tickets online, he took me into town on his scooter to the railway station to book and buy the tickets.

They have an excellent library with literature on all the major and many minor spiritual traditions.

Silence is encouraged and supported but not compulsory.

Likewise with attendance at the temple for daily services.

As I mentioned, I stayed here this time for 2 months. I had my own hut, under the jungle foliage with views towards the river. It was peaceful, verdant and comfortable.

This is not a luxury place. The accommodation is clean and basic. So, for those who want to use the ashram to deepen their own personal meditation practice, as I did, this is a great location.

For those who don't have a practice and want to develop one Father Dorathick has courses in 'harmonising body, mind and spirit'. He is also an advanced and academically qualified yoga practitioner who gives daily lessons in yoga asana, pranayama and yoga nidra, when courses are not ongoing.

No charge is made for visiting and staying, which I regard as a sign that this is a genuinely spiritual place. And the recommended donation for a day's food and board for those who want to support the continuation of this beautiful place is very reasonable.

Another charming feature is that visitors will share living-space with an abundance of wildlife. There are numerous resident peacocks roaming around. I saw an otter on a few days. There are lizards, chipmunks, frogs, ants, and I saw two snakes. And of course mosquitos, so all rooms come with beds equipped with mosquito nets. Basically, this is a delightful back-to-nature experience especially if you normally live in a city in your home-country.

One enchanting feature that I have never experienced anywhere else on the planet is that every night we were treated to the spectacle of fireflies. When I first saw these here back in 1991 I thought I was hallucinating, as it seemed to me like a Disney fairy-tale, come to life.

The only major negative change is that there is now a major bypass road a couple of hundred metres from the ashram boundary, which is a bit noisy if you have accommodation on that side of the ashram on the southern side. But the land between the ashram and the road is up for purchase and the plan is to buy it and grow trees to help block out the traffic sound.
– Chris C

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Near Dindigul is Dhyanavanam Ashram, however the founder Father Korkos is leaving in 2019 to start up a new Jesuit Ashram in Bengal, which may open sometime in 2020. It's unknown what the Dhyanavanam Ashram will be like without him and with a new Father running things.

UPDATE: Father Korkos 🙏 has been diagnosed with Parkinson's and his ashrams are not open anymore.

There's another Christian ashram, named appropriately enough, Sattal Christian Ashram in Sattal in Uttarakhand, North India. In Kerala,there's the Benedictine ashram, Kurisumala, which a friend stayed at and enjoyed and gave top marks to.

Don't be put off too much that they are Christian Ashrams. These Ashrams seem pretty cool and open and tolerant. They have excellent reviews. You can read about their philosophy on their websites or online. You may be surprised if you've never read the Christian mystics or the Desert Fathers before -- good stuff! *The Cloud of Unknowing* is an old text from the Middle Ages, but amazing.

Also in Tamil Nadu is Auroville, a planned International Alternative type community. Auroville is interesting but it's famous more for long term living than short retreats. Although you certainly can visit and there's restaurants, massages, and often workshops. Joy Guesthouse and Central Guesthouse were recommended. A step up (2600 rps) is an Auroville beach guesthouse, Samarpan Guesthouse. At Joy GH they had a wall of flyers advertising lots of various things happening around Auroville. The week I was there, there was a film festival.

Here is a Drew Binsky travel vlog, *Auroville the real life Burning Man*

The Real Life Burning Man... (Auroville)

I first visited Auroville in 1997. It was hot, dusty, and I was not impressed. It seemed like a sad hippie relic of the 1960s that time had passed by. Visiting again in 2018 Auroville seemed progressive, hip, and lovely. They planted a ton of trees but I think the Internet age has really helped them connect with the world. They've also found an artistic niche. They make and sell crafts and products locally. Now Auroville seems like one of the coolest places around. Good on them.

A lesson to be learned is that things change. I used to tell people to avoid Varanasi because of the hassle but then visiting Varanasi thirteen years later, it was fine. Well, not only fine, but interesting and lovely. I always looked forward to visiting Varanasi on my way to Sarnath for the Christopher Titmuss Vipassana retreat. Maybe another lesson to be learned is to be wary of someone else's experience happening for you. Your experience may be different. When I was a fanboy of the Lonely Planet series (pre Trip Adviser and everyone having smart phones), I was stumped why Lonely Planet raved about some towns or places and when I visited them, that were really nothing special. It was baffling. For example describing a village as friendly and

charming. Doesn’t that depend if you meet friendly people or not? How can a travel writer who is a sample size of one know that their experience will be others? I put more weight now a days into Tripadviser mass reviews.

I told myself that the LP travel writer probably met a local girl and she showed him around and he had a great time. That doesn’t happen to me. There’s a saying that it’s not so much what you do that makes it fun, but who you do it with that makes it so. If I visited Denmark and Danish women hit on me and shagged me – I’d think Denmark was the greatest country on Earth. Well, any country really. Another take away is that the line between getting a glowing enthusiastic review and a poor one might be one shag. Not to fear here though that any of my reviews are blessedly biased in that way.

Back to Auroville, if things aren't your cup of tea at Auroville (aka Hippieville), or it's a quiet week, Pondicherry is very close by. Pondicherry is alright, but the rapacious tuktuk auto drivers by the bus stop sure are a pain. Bargain hard.

Auroville also has shuttles to the beach. If you're interested in spirituality, ecology, and alternate living, I'd recommend checking out Auroville if you have the time.

Mahabalipuram is also close by Auroville and Pondicherry too, at least close by Indian standards, and is a nice beach town with good restaurants and UNESCO World Heritage monuments too. I stayed at Rajalakshmi Guest house and it has a great location, nice rooms, with a friendly owner.

In Chennai, there's Paramarthananda satsangs that's been recommended. The Krishnamurti foundation in Chennai has Vasanta Vihar a residential place to study the teachings of J Krishnamurti. I've stayed at Just Guesthouse in Chennai which is close to the airport. I've had people rave about the Broadlands Hotel *and it's character* – but I can't recommend it because at least the room I got was one of the dumpiest and depressing rooms I've ever stayed at in India. I was also charged for Internet wifi I couldn't use because the signal didn't reach my room. I complained about it but to no avail. I see nowadays the wifi is free. Maybe some other rooms in the grand old dame of a building are clean and somewhat well presented. I dunno. Addendum: I've heard that indeed this is the case. I've seen photos of a friend's room in the Broadlands and it was different than my bleak room. He suggested asking reception for a nice (deluxe) room. He emphasized this as he had to do this.

Close to Madurai in Tamil Nedu, is a Sivananda Yoga Center. The Sivananda Yoga Headquarters is in Kerala and is in a beautiful location but can be very busy and intensely crowded in season. I've known several people who left early from their Kerala Neyyar Dam HQ because it was simply too crowded during yoga teacher training in peak season. Perhaps the Madurai location may be a better choice: Less people, a lot less, better food (so I hear), and a friendly staff. My beginner yoga class at Madurai averaged 3-5 people per class.

Sivananda yoga is different than a Western yoga class. The full class is about 90 minutes long and includes breathing exercises and 12 asanas interposed with resting postures.

Western yoga classes are often creative and change up the asanas if not the yoga styles. Sivananda it's always the same class. A western yoga studio may offer Hatha Yoga, Vinyasa Yoga, Power Yoga, Restorative Yoga, and Yin Yoga classes. Sivananda it's always the same 12 asanas, done in the same sequence. It's good, it's fun, and people do like it -- but it surprised me how popular Sivananda is and how much they can charge for teacher training. It's weird to me, one can stay in a Sivananda Ashram dorm and pay $8 a day, but if you decide to do Sivananda Yoga Teacher Training, it's thousands of dollars, no matter if you do the teacher training in the Caribbean or in India.

The Sivananda method isn't exactly versatile or creative. Perhaps a good way of describing Sivananda yoga is that it's classical yoga.

I wouldn't think Westerners would like Sivananda as much as they do. And I'm one of them -- I do like it. It might be different just doing the Sivananda sequence as a two week vacation here versus if it was my hometown studio and I'm doing the Sivananda 12 asana sequence every other day for months and months.

I do think Sivananda is a bit like Goenka vipassana in that they're both rather inflexible systems run by nice people. I also think that for beginners starting off with difficult and dangerous asanas such as headstand and shoulderstand is just *effin* crazy. With headstand too, the Sivananda method is to train to reach headstand without the support of a wall. The balance issue here is not easy. It's discouraging that the headstand pose seems a binary one -- either you can do it, or you can't. It's not like a triangle pose where everyone can sorta get into their version of it. It's bad pedagogy to ask students to do more than they can do and headstand isn't even a type of pose where in a week yoga camp everyone will master it. It can take months. And you have as students middle aged westerners who haven't exercised in decades and housewives who've had kids. What if instead of headstand you did Legs up Against the Wall? It's an inversion too, but everyone can do it and it's a relaxing pose. One of my favorites. Save headstand and shoulderstand for an advanced class (or for people who like strokes). Like Goenka, there's not much room for flexibility. The system seems more important than the person. Systems that cannot adapt often will not meet the needs of their students.

See the Sivananda websites as they have yoga vacations and seem to have started beginning yoga programs too. There's also Sivananda yoga videos on YouTube. Like a lot of things if you do a Google search and watch some YouTube videos, you'll have a better and more complete picture of what Sivananda is all about. You can watch a video of a Sivananda class and see if it's for you.

Tiruvannamalai (Tiru) in Tamil Nadu, South India, is a popular spot November to February. Some people spend the entire season here. It's not that Tiru-Town itself is that great. It's not a

green city like Mysore. Trash and litter line the streets, like many places in India. There's beggars.

ARUNACHALA | The Story of the Spiritual Heart of the World

I met Camino Teller in Rishikesh in 2024. He's also a great source for the famous caminos, the spiritual walks in Spain.
Why 300K people walk around the mountain during full moon? Arunachala MYSTERY!

But if you only read Ramana Maharshi texts on your own while there and visit his Ashram -- you're cooking with gas. You can also stay at the Ramana Ashram for 3-4 nights by donation. Ramana Ashram *is* a special place.

Tiru's Dreaming Tree cafe is a nice place to hang out too, but it's pricey too. I tell of how I ordered a chai, a coffee, and piece of cake and paying at the register I told them they had to be mistaken as my bill was 450 rps! Nope -- they showed me their price list. It was 450 rps. I stopped going to satsangs to preserve my sanity and spent hours at Dreaming Tree, relaxing on their sofa, gazing at Arunachala (UPDATE: Now view is unfortunately largely blocked), and using their WiFi. Interestingly, after I expressed amazement at the price, the cashiers at the Dreaming Tree discounted me. I mean fairly substantially, like 40%! Perhaps because I was a good customer. Or they don't care…

I used to recommend Tiru as a must on the spirituality circuit -- but I don't know anymore. The teachings there could be hit-or-miss and the satsang situation there is a real fucking circus. And for whatever reason, Tiru draws the most spiritually pretentious of people who group up and become even worse. They're not Neo Advaita -- but rather Neo Annoying. Swami Atmananda noticed this too and lamented in a 2024 satsang how Tiru has changed from serious seekers to spiritual tourists. I spoke to some longtime Tiru Western devotees and they've seen Tiru become a lot more crowded, expensive, with tour buses pulling next to the Ashram and unloading sixty pilgrims all dressed in white who push into the Ashram. In season and especially full moon days, lodging is often full and prices go way up. It's shocking.

At the cheap, fairly basic, family-run and highly recommended Tasty cafe, I saw a table of four Neo Obnoxious types interrogate a very young (minor, probably around 12 years old) waitress with food questions for twenty minutes. *How is it prepared? What kind of cooking oil do they use? Do they use purified water? Can they substitute x for y? Is the coffee French press? Do they have almond milk for the coffee? Does the dish have gluten?* She was the only waitress, being the daughter, in the restaurant. Others, myself included, were waiting. I wanted to choke them, and I'm usually pretty zen. The menu was common dishes to restaurants in India. Then after placing the orders, after the first dish came out, a man wanted to cancel his order and get that first dish. I started wearing headphones in Tiru public places after this.

After writing this up, I asked the young waitress how old she was. She told me she was nine.

What I do is order from the effin' *menu*: *I'll have the #4 veg curry, #7 aloo gobi, #12 garlic cheese naan.* I say both the dish name, number, while pointing at it on the menu, and hold up fingers. . . Still, I've gotten a completely different dish, which was still delicious. I just assume they were out of what I ordered and substituted.

UPDATE: TBH, as a nearly daily long term customer there I have, over time, varied from the menu. For example, they'll do a nice Ice Coffee shake but it's not on the menu because they don't have a large ice maker.

Tiruvannamalai can be a real Neo advaita shitshow in a fairly unattractive and hot town. Still, the Ramana Ashram is a special place.

Stay at the ashram if you can, meditate at the Ashram, read Ramana, walk up to the caves, do a full moon ambulation of Arunachala, see a good satsang (I recommend Atmananda) and a crappy one (a wide choice here) – for a full Tiru experience.

I think it's definitely worth visiting, especially once. Maybe after Covid, the Neo Advaita scene will be a bit calmer. Use your own best judgement. If you go, definitely take your sense of humor. Watch out for the spiritual Karens and Kyles.

Here's a take on Tiru by Christopher Titmuss from 2009.

> *From late December to mid February, spiritual seekers from the international community, as well as thousands of India pilgrims, make their way to Tiru, to sit in the silence of the small hall where Ramana offered satsang, to make pradakshina (devotional walk) around Arunchala, the small mountain that stand immediately behind the ashram. In the past few years, Tiru has become the place for Advaitins – as Mecca is for Muslims, Rome is for Catholics and Jerusalem is for Jews. There are around 200-300 Westerners on a given day during the peak season with numbers fading away to a trickle before and after the season, except for the 50 to 60 Westerners who live near the ashram for the much of year.*
>
> Retrieved from https://www.christophertitmussblog.org/at-the-foot-of-arunachala

Tiruvanamalai, like Christopher says, is more to do with Advaita. There's often various teachings, yoga, satsangs, and retreats happening around town. If I was a newly woke Dharma/Advaita teacher (or a grifter, delusional, or a clown…), I'd rent a house in Tiru and join the Tiru satsang circus. It's almost ridiculous. Let's all wake up, post flyers in Tiru, and hold satsangs on the roof! Why the hell not? I see the disgraced teacher Andrew Cohen has established a place in Tiru and is giving satsangs. But of course. Very fitting.

I recommend staying at the Ramana Ashram for a couple nights (free, but they accept donations). The Ramana Ashram is a charged place. I don't talk about energy anywhere else in this Guide but even for me, meditating in the Ramana Ashram is charged. The meditation room with Ramana's sofa is a fantastic place to meditate and people watch.

I liked my first visit at Rainbow Guesthouse in Tiru a lot. It is about a 20 minute walk to the Ramana Ashram. In the same area outside of town are also the highly rated Sunshine Guesthouse and Kalashetra Guesthouse. Although you need a bicycle, motorbike, or hire a tuk tuk with Kalashetra Guesthouse as it's a 50 minute walk or so to the Ramana Ashram. UPDATE: I stayed at Rainbow again in 2024 and was a bit disappointed and ended up leaving early. It goes to show how things change. It's still super-popular though I suspect they may be coasting.

In high season, you might check Air B&B for rooms near the Ramana Ashram. The road where the Shiva Shakti Ashram is has several guesthouses and rooms. Dwaraka guest house is a new addition I recently found and was well pleased with. On the same road as Dwaraka is Omkara Guesthouse, another nice place with helpful owner and friendly front desk/security. Both recommended. There's well-reviewed Liya Guesthouse, Unga Veedu, Ramana Towers, and Inner Child restaurant & guesthouse which are in the same area too.

UPDATE: Dwaraka GH seems to be a popular place nowadays and prices have really skyrocketed from just a couple years ago. It's crazy. I see on Google maps that here in the off season, Dwarka is posting rooms for 2,600inr – and this for a non AC room. Huh. When I stayed there two years ago, the price was around 1100inr. I moved there from Arunachala Home which was basic, not near as nice, which was 800rps. At the time. Now I see current off season late August price for Arunachala Home has doubled to 1600inr. Crazy.

Unfortunately, Tiruvannamalai seems to have a shortage of good, cheap, well-located guesthouses. Whatsapp help groups say walk through a neighborhood asking if there's rooms for rent. That's not a bad plan once you're there, but it's helpful to have a place when you first arrive and are loaded with bags and tired. Maybe save the walkthrough for day two. If you feel frustrated at the high price of guesthouses in Tiru, maybe book a room at Ramana Towers or one of the above mentioned guesthouses for three nights and then investigate yourself. My take is that if rather plain guesthouses like Arunachala Home are charging high prices, one might as well stay in a boutique guesthouse or apartments like Ramana Towers for a bit more.

Shanti Internet, cafe, around the corner from the popular German bakery, is a friendly place with a good-guy owner that can help in travel, taxi bookings, currency exchange, phone recharge – you name it basically. Seriously, if you have a problem or issue – Shanti Kumar may be able to help. Upstairs is Shanti cafe which is a good place to eat.

For good budget eats, check out Shri Seshadri Ashram’s kitchen, Aakash Sesha Bhavan, just down the main road from the Ramana Ashram before Agni Lingam road. It’s hard to beat.

Anantha Niketan Ashram just outside of Tiru often has seminars and retreats with a nice guy owner, good basic food, along with basic rooms at an economical price. You can stay there independently.

Jaya Ashmore of One Dharma has done a Vipassana deep relaxation retreat at Anantha Niketan in January in years past. I think the premise of Jaya's retreat is near genius: deep relaxation with the lying posture. Lying posture is underrated and often seems discriminated against. I've done her retreat and Jaya is very likable but I'm not sure if I'd do the retreat again as it just wasn't my cup of chai and I find it difficult to explain why. Jaya's talks tend to be too nonlinear for me. Plus although I really was looking forward to doing a lying meditation retreat, I seemed to get lazier as the week went on. I've heard that sometimes too much rest can make one more tired so maybe that was it. Maybe I'd do it again. However I do have friends that adore her and these Deep Relaxation Retreats. It's a heartfelt practice. It's a good sangha too. Jaya also has done her retreat in north India in Sattal in the Spring. Check her website for details.

Kerala is a very nice, beautiful, and friendly state. Kerala would be a great place for India newbies to start their India trip. Though you should check the time of year. High season is winter. Typically people visit south India during Fall and Winter while late spring and summer regions like Himachal Pradesh and Ladakh are popular.

Varkala is a nice beach in Kerala with a good scene. Lungi vibe was recommended as a good dorm with a friendly owner. Blue moon and Darjeeling cafe for restaurants.

A friend, Jonathan, recommends Anandashram in Kanhangad, Kerala. It has hundreds of Google reviews with an excellent score of 4.6. There's a lot of chanting and bhajans in a peaceful place.

Two hugely popular teachers have main Ashrams in Kerala or nearby Tamil Nadu. The hugging saint Amma has a popular Ashram in Amritapuri, near Vallikavu in Kerala. A friend liked it here very much and said it was very efficiently run. The hugely popular proto-guru, Sadhguru has Isha yoga 30km outside of Coimbatore. Near Coimbatore, in Anacati, is the recommended Dayananda Ashram which has Advaita Vedanta courses. Neither Amma or Sadhguru are my cup of chai but your mileage may differ. I'm suspicious of them and their large organization but if you're going for a ten day stay I can see you having a nice visit. If I went to Spahn Ranch on a weekend when the Manson family was staying there – I'd probably have a great time; Hippie chicks, music, and free drugs. What do I know.

A small Ashram in Wayanad, Kerala near Korome has done a few annual retreats on Vedanta at Tiruvannamalai and Dharmapeetham, Kollur. They also have regular monthly ten day intensive retreats at their Ashram in Wayanad. The Wayanad Arunachala Bhagavan Ashram is small and basic and you should contact them beforehand to have a place to stay. If you like it there, there are some huts nearby and some people stay in the area for months or even years. Devotees of

their guru, who calls himself *the Bhagavan*, often show up at other spiritual centers, like Rishikesh, Tiruvannamalai, or Bodhi zendo.

I did a ten day Intensive there and I liked the Sangha, teachings, and location well enough at the time (though the Ashram is hard to get to; Kerala is beautiful) -- but it was a bit Culty for my taste and there's also enough red flags for an old Soviet Moscow May Day parade.

The last day of the Intensive, they presented me with a form of their Precepts to sign, including being celibate (for life) -- if I'm to receive further teachings from the Bhagavan. *WTF!* I believe in teachings that liberate rather than old-fashioned sex morality bullshit.

I refused to sign, of course, so I'm banned, technically, from receiving further teachings from them, the only retreat center I've ever been banned from (although there's been a couple bars I've been thrown out of back in the day). That's alright though because I'm not that keen about an overweight Vedanta guru, a Vedanta teacher who doesn't seem to teach core Vedanta, and who rides around in a new $100,000 BMW car. He claims to teach the real *original* Vedanta and his disciples say he's a living Buddha. Ya. Seriously. I never saw it. Maybe it's my karma that I was never so favored…

I found this blog post on the site zenrants.com about this ashram:

A personal example of Neti Neti, I went to a borderline cult in the jungles of Kerala, India after visiting Ama's Bodhi Zendo.

The teacher had a 2 foot beard and wouldn't open his eyes while teaching because it might "overwhelm you", all while he was stroking a white poodle on his lap.

It was all a bit much, yet the drama of Question & Answer sessions (Satsang) were like spiritual theatre. You sat across from him in a chair, with 40 people huddled around listening to your intimate questions for 45 minutes. It all felt like spiritual Oprah (and a bit of manipulation and priming).

In the end, it was totally Neti Neti for me, and I won't be shocked if it's a sex cult in 5 years.

-- retrieved at
https://www.zenrants.com/blog/surfing-zen-masters

I've done an extensive critical take-down review for this small Ashram. See Appendix A.



Christopher Titmuss runs yearly two-week Vipassana courses out of Sarnath in January-February. They are excellent retreats for beginners or really anyone. Christopher's retreats have good teachings, a fun schedule (for a retreat), and have great retreat food. I like the schedule as it's not all sitting meditation.

UPDATE: In 2021, Christopher announced he was discontinuing intercontinental flights and wouldn't be teaching anymore in India, Australia, and Israel. Covid is still a factor as I write this, but if possible, the retreats may still continue under insight meditation teacher Radha Nicholson. Google for Radha Nicholson's schedule for current details.

Christopher Titmuss's retreats are lovingly and mindfully managed by an attractive Polish woman, Dora, who bares resemblance to Ingrid Bergman. She keeps retreat participants well looked after and has a charming habit of writing notes and leaving them all over: "One Spoonful of Peanut Butter per Person" (I ignored this totally). Dora bought extra trash cans (with a lid) so every bathroom had a trash can with a lid. Then she wrote on each and every trash can: "Do Not Flush Toilet Paper", "Empty Trash Bin When Full". She tries pairing up people sharing rooms by compatibility, talkativeness, even though retreat participants are under Noble Silence, and it shouldn't matter. I like Christopher's teachings well enough but Dora adds a lot to the retreat and may be the key to its fun, friendly, and supportive environment. Once I was doing the *Buddho* mantra during the Sarnath Retreat and found myself after twenty minutes chanting "Bu -(tiful) -- Do - (ra)". Seriously. Where did that come from? So much for focus and a razor sharp mind. Don't tell anyone.

You'll probably leave Sarnath having made a few dharma friends, especially if you get there a couple days early. It's a good Sangha that shows up, with a good international and age mix, with new people and dharma old timers. There's usually a get- together party after the Christopher retreat ends and it's nice to talk with people you sat with. After the Bodhgaya retreat, I put out an open invitation for interested dharma discussers to meetup at Muhamed's restaurant afterwards.

I rarely met anyone at Panditarama, Lumbini! At Panditarama one practices as if you are the sole person on retreat. Just goes to show how different retreats can be. Christopher's 2019 Retreat in Sarnath was his 46th year of holding a retreat in India. That's pretty amazing. Although there was some trepidation that 2019 might be the last year it would be held because in recent years numbers seem to have fallen off, attendance for 2019 was good and the retreat was full. Recommended too is reading books by Christopher, my favorites are *Light on Enlightenment* and *An Awakened Life*.

Sarnath is just on the outskirts of Varanasi. I recommend getting to Sarnath several days before the Christopher retreat and staying at Dr. Jain's Paying Guesthouse. It's a chill place to hang out, with cool people often passing through or coming by for the thalis. There's a nice Korean temple nearby I go to for meditation. On one visit to the Korean Temple, they even served me tea and a sandwich and gave me a dharma book. For Brownie points, read about the traveling Korean monk Hyecho on Wikipedia. There's a monument to him at the Korean temple.

Mrs. Jain of Jain's Paying Guesthouse serves excellent home cooked thalis. Don't miss the egg rolls/wraps sold by the street vendors in Sarnath either. Have some chai at Maha Dev's (he cooks for the Christopher Titmuss retreat and does a fantastic job). Maha Dev's chai shop is across from the main Mahabodhi temple where they do the daily evening chanting. It's under a big tree. The chai shop wallahs can direct you to the not-to-be-missed egg roll places across the street too. Check out the eighty foot tall standing Buddha at the Thai Temple and the Garden of Spiritual Delights.

Namo Buddha Guesthouse, run by a German woman who bakes, is another good place to stay in Sarnath.

Varanasi and Sarnath make good stopping points if you're on your way to either Rishikesh, Bodhgaya, or Lumbini for Panditarama.

Varanasi is amazing. I stay at Sahi River View Guesthouse on Assi Ghat in Varanasi. I splurge here and get a nice room with a balcony overlooking the Ganges ($18). Although best value are probably the rooms without balcony which can be half the price. It's nice though to sit out on the balcony with a big pot of coffee and watch Assi ghat, the river, and people. Better than television. I recommend doing a walking tour of Varanasi with Varanasi Behind Day Tours. Their meeting point is right below Sahi River View GH too. If ever there's a city it's worth doing a walking tour in, it's Varanasi.

By the way, if you're using a trip app such as Make My Trip to make India Railways train reservations, be aware to search out of Mughal Sarai train stop as well as Varanasi junction. Mughal Sarai although it's in Varanasi, has additional trains.

Radha Nicholson, who works with Christopher, has led the Bodhgaya retreats that started back up in 2016 in the new Bodhgaya Thai International Meditators Center. Radha gets five stars. Sometimes I've heard people say negative things about Christopher Titmuss (e.g., that he's too political, that he's like reading *The Guardian*, -- but I agree mostly with his politics so it doesn't bother me. I don't quite understand their complaints, most western Dharma teachers are progressive and green sorts, but I suppose conservatives are offended when he lambasts the big banks. Snowflakes.) -- but I've never heard anyone say anything but they like Radha. I've

heard she was a dharma psychologist in Australia so she brings in psychology as well as metta to her retreat.

The food at the Wat Thai temple for Radha's retreat is very good. Men stay in a large, new dormitory. Wat Thai has modernized in the last ten years. There's a nice charming coffee shop on the grounds.

Bodhgaya is an interesting place to visit and it’s a trip to meditate by the Bodhi tree and watch all the pilgrims. I've stayed at Rama Inn which is in central Bodhgaya and Suma Guesthouse which is out by Root Institute. Both very good places. There's a number of similar good value guesthouses around the corner from Rama such as Beauty Inn and Rahul Guesthouse. I often ate at the nearby superb Mohammad's cafe which is one of my favorites and not to be missed.

Don't forget to visit and checkout the well-known Root Institute which in season has many dharma programs. Root is run by the FPMT which also runs Tushita in Dharamsala and Kopan monastery in Kathmandu.

There's a well known Bihar School of Yoga in Munger. It's more like a university as it's traditional yoga with the eight limbs and the daily schedule includes several hours of karma yoga (work) daily. Not for dilettantes. See their website. But it's less asanas than it may be scrubbing toilets. I've known people who've done it and they loved it, weirdly enough. If your path is Karma yoga, it may be a good fit.

Recently I have personally heard two very unfavorable reports on the Bihar School of Yoga. Watch your health if you go there. If you get sick, there or anywhere, it's a red flag if they try to discourage you from seeing a doctor. This is a golden example of why you should Google ashrams. I had no idea of the charges of sexual abuse there and their secretive nature. It's a reminder that one should do their own due diligence.

If you head up to Rishikesh after the Christopher retreat, you'll recognize faces because many Christopher Retreatants head up to Rishikesh and then Himachal Pradesh afterwards. Rishikesh has many, many yoga ashrams. Check out Tripadvisor for Ashram reviews as well as Google map reviews. Ashrams personally recommended to me are: Phool Chatti, Akshi Yogashala, Parmarth Niketan, Anand Prakash, Yoga Niketan, and then Yoga Vini for drop-ins.

Phool Chatti has a great location and has week long yoga retreats. It's location is prime, in a quiet up river setting. It gets high reviews. I did a week there and enjoyed it. Although it's listed as beginner-intermediate yoga program, the yoga was challenging -- we did Wheel, Headstand, Standing Hand to Big Toe, and Binds. The class was large so many times we held a pose for a longggg time while the instructor walked around the room, checking people. Still, it was fun. One of the best things is that there's some nice beautiful Ganga beaches close that the class took trips to.

You'll have a completely different yoga experience if you go to Anand Prakash in the Rishikesh suburb of Tapovan. Tapovan is yoga central and rather busy. Like most places in India, you'll dodge motorbikes walking down the alleys. Tapovan in 2024 isn't particularly a nice place to stay. And it'll likely be worse after what seems like a recent construction boom.

Many long-distance buses to Rishikesh don't actually go all the way into Rishikesh but instead drop off at Nepali farm flyover, which is about 10 km from Rishikesh and 15 from Tapovan. I took a shared auto rickshaw for 100 inr into Tapovan but it was really packed, the auto took the back bumpy streets, and faced a traffic logjam Delhi style finally entering Rishikesh city. It took probably 50 minutes to get to my Tapovan guesthouse. It was an exhausting tuktuk ride with three of us in front seat, grabbing on to front bar from road jolts, and having my leg bumped everytime the driver shifted gears. It's possible to book an auto for single use. If you're heading to Dharamsala after Rishi be aware it's nausea-inducing ride. I'm rarely travel sick but found the trip miserable. Pack a throw-up bag and I recommend motion sickness medicine and some ginger lozenges.

I booked OLT hostel online but moved after one day because of noise from dueling construction sites. I went to a rooftop restaurant nearby, Tailavar, and again, two nearby buildings are being constructed. Not OLT’s fault and the owner is nice.

Try out different locations in Rishi if you can. I'd stay across the river from Tapovan in Jonk. I doubt if I would choose to stay in Tapovan more than a couple days unless I was going to a specific yoga school I liked or satsangs with Ajatananda at his Atmananda Ashram.

The problem with yoga in Rishikesh is that there's so many options you can almost feel overwhelmed. Many yoga places seem to emphasize yoga teacher training over just regular yoga classes. Can't say I blame them on an economic basis -- yoga teacher training courses can cost thousands of dollars whereas a drop-in yoga may be $6.

Govind residency in Tapovan is pricey but seems nice. Close are two good value guesthouses: Aastha and Bhandari guesthouses. But they're hard to contact via email and aren't on the usual booking sites, so it's easier to book in person upon arrival. Dostel, which used to be Yashraj Guesthouse, has been renovated, is bookable online, and has great reviews. Zostel has a branch too in upper Tapovan Rishikesh with the best Internet I've had in India.

Unfortunately the Laxmi Jhula bridge is closed. They are building a new bridge but it's not finished yet. There is an overpriced boat across.

Across from Tapovan, in Jonku, is the Sonu Guesthouse which is right behind the Shiv Shakti Hostel. Both places get high reviews and are in a great location. Zostel also has a branch in the area.

Dayananda Ashram was recommended for Advaita Vedanta teachings to me and after a ten day retreat there, I recommend it too. There's morning, afternoon, and night Vedanta teachings so you should have an interest in Vedanta, obviously.

Dayananda is a nice Ashram, runs off of donations, nice rooms, hot showers, generous and friendly servings of food, and the teachings are very fine. In season they hold a number of Vedanta 10-day camps. You're getting real Advaita Vedanta teachings here. They do everything right. Highly recommended especially if you're a bit keen on Advaita. Brush up on your Sanskrit though. The Mooji Ashram is right next door too. Dayananda also holds various courses throughout the year. Dayananda also has Ashrams near Coimbatore, Ashya Vidya Ashram, and one in Saylorsburg, Pennsylvania, too. A nice thing about Dayananda and Advaita Vedanta is that they believe liberation can come from teachings and philosophy and they have a curriculum and a plan to do it, they've got it down, and they also try not to turn people away.

All Dayananda Ashrams have courses you can take. I see the Coimbatore Ashram is offering a 108 day course covering the Bhagavad Gita and Tattvabodha and Dayananda Rishikesh has a three year course that you may be able to sit in on with special permission even in the middle of it. You'd increase your chances if you sat previously in a Vedanta camp and were studying Advaita somewhat on your own, and have an interest in liberation and the Dayananda teachings. Dayananda Ashram is a place that after my Vedanta camp I wondered how come I hadn't heard more about the place before. It's really pretty good. I was impressed. Though spiritual teachings can be extremely individualistic.

I talk more about Advaita in my *Wolf's Guide to Dharma Books & Practice* book, but I'll put this out there: if you've been on the spiritual path for a while and nothing much has happened (not terribly unlikely if you're honest and not delusional) and you're feeling a bit desperate and despondent – you're a perfect candidate to be an Advaita Vedanta student. You're ready to sit down and shut up and listen. Most Westerners are not and enjoy dharma - entertainment shitshow. In which case, I recommend a visit to Tiruvannamalai in satsang season.

Ajatananda Ashram has been recommended more than once to me for satsangs. I attended a couple of their satsangs in Tiruvannamalai on the roof of Rainbow Guesthouse and I attended many of their satsangs in Rishi at their Ashram there too. Packed satsang probably with 70 or so people. Very nice live music, a step up in professionalism, and Swami Atmananda Udasin is a westerner, speaks good English, and gives excellent talks understandable (little Sanskrit) talks on Advaita Vedanta. They have a couple multiday non-residential retreats in-season. Recommended.

Shanti Mayi also gives satsangs every year in Rishikesh. A friend said he used Shanti Mayi as reverse signaling, as in people who told him they liked Shanti Mayi he judged at a low level of spiritual insight. Funny. I wasn't impressed by her either and at one point almost felt like walking out when she started talking about a woman's sexual abuse at the hands of her guru and the need for forgiveness and to make things all light. There was little on the guru's responsibility

throughout but surprisingly for a supposedly woke Western woman guru there seemed to be victim-blaming through the doctrine of the woman's karma being a factor in the abuse. Oh. Is that so?

Shanti Mayi had our group practice saying *No!, I don't like that!*, so we chanted that in unison. Effin' Ridiculous. That was easy: Just say **No**! Which is like the conservative pundits solution from everything from the opioid epidemic to teen pregnancy. Like we're a Junior High School DARE class. In reality, it's often not quite so easy. Remember when I mentioned the words, *dharma - entertainment shitshow*, earlier? Maybe it seemed unfair. It's not.

She also nagged at another young woman for not buying the right kind of crystal: "*Why didn't you listen*?" -- and this in front of a big crowd. Crystal Believers amuse me. Once a long time ago there was a hippie chick I really liked and I remember listening to her talk of her love of crystals. At the time, I had an older friend, Lee, who I played speed chess with. Lee gave me this advice on women: *Like what they like, hate what they hate, love what they love*. So I loved crystals too and asked enthusiastic questions and was open-minded concerning their efficacy. Not one of my prouder moments (facepalm). It didn't work. Evidently crystal gullibility doesn't necessarily transfer to other areas such as easy pick-up.

You'd think gurus could put their best foot forward for 90 minutes and not be a bitch. You'd think wrong however. Unfortunately my chair was on the far side of the exit and I couldn't make my way out, at least gracefully. I was kinda tempted to return and see at least one more of Shanti Mayi's satsangs to see if they always go off the rails. But nah. I'll go do a drop-in yoga class and then have an amazing breakfast somewhere. This honestly has it all over attending some guru who really does come on like the crackpot Red Queen from *Alice in Wonderland*.

There's a lot more going in-season in Rishikesh. Although Tapovan fails to impress, Rishi is definitely worth visiting. I recommend studying Yoga and Advaita Vedanta and Rishi is hard to beat for this.

A new place I heard about is Vajradhatu, which is in Pune. They bring in teachers such as Tenzin Palmo, Geshe Dorje Damdul, and others. Also in Pune is the famous Osho wellness and meditation resort. An Iranian-Canadian friend stayed there and while it's more expensive than other places, he loved it and raves about it.

Tibet House in Delhi is good if somehow you're stuck in Delhi and can't leave. Several people have mentioned how impressed they are with founder, Geshe Dorje Damdul. Tibet House also has a recommended online program at India prices.

If you're into Buddhism and want a quieter place to stay, I enjoyed Kushinagar which is close to Gorakhpur, just north of Varanasi. Kushinagar is where the Buddha passed away. I stayed at a Vietnamese Linh Son Buddhist Monastery which had nice cheap rooms. Kushinagar was like a breath of fresh air away from the mass of tourists and backpackers you find in so many places

now.

A funny look with traveler Karl Pilkington in India
Karl Pilkington An Idiot Abroad India S1 E2 (2010)

An Idiot Abroad S03E02: India

Retreats in Nepal

Nepal is very good for Buddha Dharma. I have to give a big thumbs up overall to Nepal. Most tourists and backpackers only see Kathmandu, Pokhara and trekking environs around Pokara, and maybe Royal Chitwan Park. I can't help but think one would be well rewarded if one added more stops in Nepal. The Nepalese are incredibly hospitable. And Nepal needs the tourism.

Boudhanath and nearby areas have dharma courses going on, for example at Rangjung Yeshe Institute, Kopan Monastery and Pullahari. If you're looking for a picturesque self retreat way up in the Himalayas, Lawudo Gompa, run by the FPMT (same organization that runs Tushita and Root Institute) is on the Everest Base Camp trek. Daily costs there are about $35 a day. Looks way cool. It's funny: they make a point to explain the high (for Nepal) daily fee of $35 (everything has to be carried in by porters)--but to many Westerners thirty five dollars a day for a retreat in the Himalayas sounds almost too good to be true. I haven't stayed here, but it's run by the FPMT and they are a legit group that usually organizes and does things right.

FPMT's Kopan Monastery, just outside Kathmandu, does regular courses and events like Tushita (though not nearly as many), but they're famous for their November one month Lam Rim course that they've been doing since the early 1970s. The Lam Rim uses Lama Tsongkhapa's *Graduated Path to Enlightenment* as its text which is a synopsis of Buddha's teachings. The November course isn't a Vipassana retreat. It's more like a Buddhist summer camp, which isn't a bad thing. Primarily there's teachings with questions and answer sessions, but there's also small group discussions, chanting, and some guided meditations. You'll meet people and make friends. There's usually tears at the end of the course on the last day. I liked my month there and several friends I made at Kopan returned after a couple years for a second run through of the November course. I'd be tempted to take it a second time too but the Lam Rim is only so-so for me. I like Compassion and Bodhicitta but the hell realms, importance of lineage, guru devotion, and the heavy version of karma leaves me cold, bleh. If you're interested, checkout who's teaching it, as that's obviously important. Try to sign up early on the first day of registration, even the night before (keep on hitting "Refresh" on your browser until registration opens up), to snag a premo room. For good karma, if you do get a nice room, offer the shower

to the other people in your discussion group who may be staying in dorms and working with intermittently wonky hot showers.

October is prime trekking season in Nepal. It's also good weather for a vipassana retreat at Panditarama Lumbini. Someone industrious and efficient could probably fit in all three. Really, if you go, I strongly encourage you to make the most of your trip and do a trek, take the November one month Lam Rim course at Kopan, and try a 10-14 day vipassana retreat at Panditarama in Lumbini. Wow, wow, and Wow!

In Bhaktapur, Nepal, Thrangu Sekhar Retreat Center provides rooms, meals, and a good view of the valley. A Rinpoche, Drupon Khen is in residence nine months of the year and provides guidance to Retreatants.

In Pharping, Nepal, the Benchen Monastery has small kuttis available for retreat for Westerners. I don't know much about this place. So better check their website and contact them to be sure.

Pokara, Nepal is a chill place. It's a backpacker Mecca as it's the jumping off place for several treks. Since Pokara is such a magnet for travelers, there's opportunities for Dharma, yoga, and myriad other spiritual practices and adventures. I recommend Harmony Guesthouse in Pokhara.

I talked about one of my favorites, Panditarama Vipassana Center, earlier which is in Lumbini, Nepal. Panditarama is one of the best places to do a serious retreat. For lodging or a self retreat in Lumbini, the Korean temple is a good choice. You get a room and nice basic meals for $10 a day, dormitory $5. Nice place, quiet. I stayed here in 2023 for a couple weeks and even peak season there only were a handful of people.

Getting off the bus in Lumbini Village, I stay at Sunflower Inn, which seems to be a step up in quality from many cheapies in Lumbini village. Good rooms, good food with large portions, WiFi, hot showers, and they're helpful and nice. If you're leaving early in the morning, tell them the night before as they lock the front gate.

Retreats in Thailand

Thailand has several places you can do meditation. I like Doi Suthep's International Vipassana Center in Chiang Mai. Nice weather, facilities, hot showers, food, and I like the head monk. I also like you have your own room and you can practice on your own.

Note that many Thai Buddhist retreat centers mandate wearing white clothes for meditators. Sometimes they are provided like at Wat Pa Tam Wua or they can be rented for a small fee as at Wat Sopharam. Check the retreat website and FAQ.

In Bangkok, I like Victory Monument area for convenience. I stayed at Victory Park Hostel which has a friendly owner and great reviews. Close to MBK mall and National Stadium BTS, the White Lodge has a great location, decent price, and is pretty good.

In Chiang Mai, Libra Guesthouse and Northland House are good cheapies in the NE corner of the Old City.

If you're looking for a good beach in Thailand I liked Koh Phayam about the best. Ko Phayam is close to Ranong.

Thailand is famous for medical tourism. I've had great checkups at Bumrungrad Hospital. Google them and check their website. Especially if you're American, and have shoddy healthcare at home, get a baseline checkup and make sure you're healthy and don't have parasites.

There's several other places in North Thailand that offer Vipassana retreats similar to Doi Suthep. Wat Chom Tong is one.

Wat Pa Tam Wua beyond Pai, word of mouth is a beautiful forest sanctuary with a friendly teacher. It's a nice place, relaxed, and popular with backpackers, with 30 kuttis for women and 10 kuttis for men and a new dharma hall. If you stay long enough to score a kutti -- you're cooking with gas. Otherwise you'll be in a big dormitory with backpackers. Bring earplugs. Excellent Google Map reviews.

I stayed at this monastery in 2023. It's beautiful, very modern and well-kept. You can drop in without a booking. I think it's fantastic for Thais, new-ish meditators, and casuals. I'm not sure how great it is for serious meditators wanting to go deep or practice on their own. There's a lot of group activities, walking meditation,group meditation, offerings to monks, and chanting. I like the place, the scenery is stunning, I had a friendly Russian volunteer who registered me and showed me around – but if I'm being honest – I think I've gotten more out of most other Vipassana retreats. For example, Doi Suthep Chiang Mai and Panditarama Lumbini your day was your schedule. At Christopher Titmuss's and Radha's Vipassana retreats the schedule was alternating sitting and walking meditation throughout the day with instructions in the morning and a dharma talk and inquiry in the evenings. No chanting or offerings. These other retreats felt like you had your whole day free mostly to meditate.

It doesn't feel that way at Wat Pa Tam Wua. It could be partly me, I'm here during the hot season and the heat tires me out. That's the beautiful thing about meditation centers on a mountain (like Doi Suthep or Bodhizendo) – they are cooler. I not only didn't met anyone at Wat

Pa Tam Wua, I don't think I talked to anyone, despite the monastery not being very strict (A Thai man ahead of me on a group walking meditation line took out his phone to chat! – I told him off). There's an opportunity to ask questions to the monks in the afternoon after class but I never took advantage of it. I thought one day I probably should but I saw five young Thai women sitting in front of the monk and was dissuaded. Let them have it.

The new kuttis are fantastic. However the beds are hard wood and you only get issued one thin pad to put on top. I didn't sleep well my first night so second day right after breakfast I went to a pile of turn-ins and scarfed a second pad. I don't understand the reasoning behind not supplying a reasonable amount to allow people to sleep. There's enough dukkha going around anyway without resorting to hard beds and wooden pillows. But easily rectified if you don't have a fetish for the precept of not taking what's not offered.

I'd recommend checking out Wat Pa Tam Wua for a relaxed 3-10 day stay and then decide for yourself.

Here is a Youtube video filmed at Wat Pa Tam Wua, *Walk to be the Knower*:
https://youtu.be/6bmlgOevF3I?si=ihMIjfoJgbUulRRw

Pai is between Wat Pa Tam Wua and Pa Pae center. Pai isnt really my style these days as it's a resorty town overrun by young partying Westerners. YMMV. Sunset bar in Pai serves up nice Magic Mushroom shakes. I recommend taking yours back to your room, if a trusted trip sitting friend isn't available. Don't underestimate psychedelics. One person might have a beautiful, relaxing trip seeing bright colors walking thru the fields by Sunset bar. Another might want to lie down, close eyes, and not move for two hours. Crying is not uncommon. Many cultures have intricate ceremonies for ingestion of psychedelics. They have guides and use music. And here we are handing them out to young people at a bar. Best O' luck,buddy! Optimally there should be support for people taking psychedelics. Seriously.

I'm just a bit amazed that a bar sells these…(See my FAQ about psychedelics in my *Wolf's Guide for Dharma Books & Practice).*

Pa Pae center also outside of Chiang Mai and before Pai has a three day meditation program. Although you can extend your stay and stay longer. It seems to be a relaxed place with a minimum number of required group meditation sessions. A Taiwanese reader recommended this place. Check out the Pa Pae website. It does look nice. I love the huge meditation swings with cushions. Perusing the excellent Google map reviews of the place, it appears that Pa Pae is affiliated with the Thai Dhammakaya sect. Google for more info on this controversial group.

Here is a Reddit review I found on Pa Pae:

First of all, its very beautiful, remote set in lush mountain jungle about an hour from Chiang Mai. Transport in and out is a minor hassle, but shouldn't present too much of a barrier. There are forest paths to walk around.

Its also quite cushy, with a cafe (drinks are free to monks and novices). There is also pizza/ice cream parlour, a steam room and thai massage onsite. So a level of luxury that could prove a distraction for some, or simply ease the transition into meditative life, you decide.

There are about 8 or so junior monks from Europe and Canada mostly, as well as a lot of Thai senior monks. There are separate areas for lay meditators and monks, no nuns as far as I can see. I know that lay meditators pay 500 baht per day for food and accomodation, no charge for ordained. Becoming a monk seems a very simple and straightforward process. Doing paperwork and religious visa is also apparently straightforward.

Onto the practice. Have not got teachings here yet myself, I know its mainly samatha/concentration excercises. Dharmakaya have a reputation for some kooky esoteric practices that might not be everyones cup of tea, but those I've spoken to are mostly doing mainstream anapanasati, nothing unusual. There is also reportedly a great amount of freedom to do ones own practice plus a few different samatha techniques taught.

Dharmakaya has a reputation for being a bit culty, my friend who lives here inititally had concerns based of this reputation. However, they say their fears were allayed and it is well run and straightforward, with no odd pressures or dynamics to speak of.

Overall, seems like a decent place to practice, a little bit light on the teaching but a welcoming community in a good, peaceful environment.

*

Wat Sopharam is a 45 minute or so drive south of Chiang Mai's Old City. High Google reviews and helpful volunteers. They are Mahasi influenced but more relaxed. A nice German nun Janet gives introductions and is available to help. If the Thai heat is getting to you, you can rent an AC kutti unit for 300 THB a day. Why be miserable?

A British friend recommended two meditation places in Thailand for me. The first is Angthong International Meditation Center, which is a Pa Auk center in Champa Lo, Ang Thong. The second is an unusual center in Pattaya, Boonkanjanaram Meditation Center. My friend said he was the only meditator there when he went, but he was impressed by the teaching and meditation instruction and liked it a lot. Pattaya is also famous for its beach (so-so but hey it's a beach...), shopping, and sex trafficking. Check out Tiffany's in Pattaya which puts on a world famous Ladyboy show.

Robin wrote of Wat Pha Nanachat, in Bung Wai, Northeast Thailand:

“*The international Ajahn Chah tradition monastery, the monastery is very elegant and in a well kept forest. Not actually a retreat center, they're more of a training center for new international monks that ordained in the Thai Forest tradition.*

The schedule is that of this kind of monastery: 1h30 of meditation + chanting morning and evening, around 2h30 of chores (sweeping, etc) and 1h of preparation of food offerings - so you have to make your own meditation schedule whenever you have free time.

*There is only one meal a day at 8 and it's only by food that has actually been given by laypeople living near the monastery. The goal is to live as close to how the bhikkhus were living in Buddha's time and that's very nice to experience. The meal is usually a *feast*, which doesn't really help sense restraint but hey, you get to work on your attachments...*

There is very little actual teaching - once a week on Wan Phra day a senior monk took did a Q&A until late at night, but when I was there the Ajahn was away, I understood that he sometimes makes Dhamma talks and Ovada (short Dhamma talk after the meal). The chanting are suttas, both in Pali and in English, it's nice to know what your chanting about.

For me it was a great place to meet other laymen practitioners, we were around 10-15, a good portion was looking for a place to ordain as a monk and were both quite erudite and very eager to discuss the Dhamma in passionate conversations. I have also rarely seen such gentle people, always trying to be mindful of their thoughts and words, which was very refreshing. A great place to talk about Ajahn Chah as well, of course.

I wanted to stay longer but you have to shave head and eyebrows (if you're a male) if you stay more than a week, and though I considered it I wasn't attracted to it at the end of my stay (+ might makes it hard to travel, as you're not looking like your passport photo at all afterwards) so I left. But they're quite nice and would probably allow a few more unshaven days if you wanted.”

There's a Thai Plum Village, a branch of Thich Nhat Hanh's lineage. Thai Plum Village has very good reviews. It is located at Ban Sa Sai Sai, Pong Ta Long, Nakhon Ratchasima Province, about 240 kilometers northeast of Bangkok

Koh Phangan, in the south of Thailand, famous for its full moon parties, has Kow Tahm International Meditation Center which has a ten day meditation retreat from the 10th to the 20th each month. Koh Phangan has annoying transport cartels with high fixed price unless they can get away with charging you more.

Someone who liked my guide said this about Kow Tahm:

Wat Kow Tham is a lovely forest spot that is a lovely escape from the bustle of southern Koh Phangan. The retreat is pretty similar the ones at Suan Mokkh. The teacher monk, Dr Marut, teaches at both. So a fairly relentless schedule, with morning bell at 4 am and meditation finishing at 9pm. I experienced a lot of sitting pain, and that was after my 'priming' at Wat Tam Wua, so those guys up north must have been really gentle on us!

This particular retreat seemed to lack any volunteer help, so the whole thing was run by Dr Marut and an older lady whose family own the land the temple is built on. There were volunteers to assist on registration day, but they were gone the following day. The lack of guidance meant that discipline broke down pretty fast. I reckon 75% of the participants just gave up on the silence. I imagine there would normally be volunteers to ask questions and prod people into behaving themselves.

The facilities at Kow Tham are fairly basic, and the showers and plumbing need some repair, so physically sometimes it felt like camping. Many of the mens' sinks had no plumbing at all, just water splashing all over your feet! So not recommended for anyone who needs their creature comforts. Dorms for men were just two per room, with mattresses, so not as basic as Wat Suan Mokkh. I would go back again.

Koh Phangan is also excellent for yoga. I stayed at Bamboo Huts on the Haad Yuan beach just north of Haad Rin (the full moon party beach). Bamboo Huts has a great restaurant and includes Blooming Lotus Yoga Center which I liked and it gets five star reviews on TripAdvisor. Just down a hill, maybe about a fifteen minute walk, from Bamboo Huts is The Sanctuary (www.thesanctuarythailand.com) which also has a thrice-daily yoga program. The Sanctuary gets good reviews and they have all-inclusive packages, which aren't bad -- but if you stay at Bamboo Huts and pay a drop-in yoga rate -- you can cut your costs down by quite a bit.

A neighboring island to Koh Phangan, Koh Samui has Dipabhavan Meditation Center which has bimonthly retreats from the 3rd to the 10th and 20th to the 27th each month.

There's a well known monthly 10-day retreat in south Thailand in Chaiye, close to Surat Thani, at Wat Suan Mokkh.

Wat Suan Mokkh is the only retreat I quit early (like Day 1!). It's a forced participation group retreat. I had just gotten into Asia and was still jet lagged. We did a long orientation walk the first day. It was hot, because Wat Suan Mokkh is in the jungle. Then it rained on us. We had some free time before a movie started and I fell asleep on my concrete slab of a bed (extremely poor cell-like facilities). They came and got me. I was told participation was mandatory and if I didn't attend I would be reported. Oh my. I attended but thought if I'm in quasi-trouble before the first official day, the Retreat might not be for me so I left the next day. Instead, I went to Koh Phangan and spent more time on the beach. My back and hips hurt though for days because honestly you sleep on effing concrete with a ultra thin straw mat. And then there's mandatory yoga first thing next morning! I like yoga, but making something mandatory is a great way for me not to like something! Not to mention I felt exhausted and like dog crap the next morning.

Mandatory exercise seems very 1984 (classic book on totalitarianism available on cloud) or Japanese: "Sorry, I wasn't in a mentally happy place for mandatory morning group exercise, comrade!"

I don't really see the point of not making it easier or more comfortable. Veterans just bring an air mattress or yoga mat to lay on the concrete and a mosquito net for their meditations outside there. Beginners will have a bad time--sleeping on concrete and getting eaten up by mosquitoes. That's not how it should be: Newbies and Beginners get fracked. They told me up to 30% of Retreatants don't finish the ten day program. Seemed like nice people running things though, they tried to talk me into staying, even offered me a normal bed to catch up on rest if I needed. But I'd already made my decision. I don't want a special bed anyway and feel I'm getting special privileges. I really wanted to like Wat Suan Mokkh. I like the founder Venerable Buddhadasa and I've read several of his books and liked them a lot. Checkout his book *Handbook for Mankind*.

I don't think Wat Suan Mokkh is a bad place, just know what you're getting into and have your game face on. If you're young, well-rested, have done a retreat before, have a yoga mat to put on your concrete bed as well as maybe a mosquito net, you might love it. Don't let my experience stop you. My report is probably the exception.

I tell this Wat Suan Mokkh story to emphasize that retreats can be very different and even though I was a fairly veteran Yogi I bailed out of a retreat on Day One. Well, it happens. Group retreats can suck if you don't or can't follow the group. I wish organizers of group type retreats would realize one size does not fit all and be a bit more relaxed and lenient.

Why should someone 50 or 60 or 80 years of age with leg problems have to do the exact same full daily schedule as someone who's 25 and just completed yoga teacher training? Why should meditation retreats, which has as the biggest component just sitting, have to have a physical endurance aspect with mandatory group long sits? Does this make any sense? Aren't we supposed to be working on the mind? There's nothing in the Buddhist suttas or the Vinaya where the Buddha even attempted to formulate strict sitting hours or practice!

If someone skips and misses the last session of the day because they're fagged out -- but they're still benefiting tons from the retreat -- what's the problem? I'm not even convinced that a small adaption of the daily schedule is even a problem. The problem lies with the inflexible system, not the person. Please fix the system.

I've been a group leader on retreats and on one, there was an elderly gentleman with Parkinson's Disease. He missed fewer sits than some, but he still missed them. He didn't do the group walking because of his balance issues. Do you think I admonished him for not participating 100%? The orientation talk I gave clearly stated that one was expected to come for all the sittings. Of course I didn't admonish him! -- I'm not a Jerk (at least when it comes for making adaptions that allow people to be successful).

There's a saying in Special Education that equity isn't treating everyone the same but giving everyone the tools they need to be successful. *Retreats may treat people equally, when they should be treating people equitably.*

Little Bang dot Org has a good list of meditation options in Thailand.

http://www.littlebang.org/retreats-2/

Retreats in Malaysia

The Australian vipassana teacher Patrick Kearney recommends Malaysia for retreats. If you know places, he says you could go from Retreat to Retreat in Malaysia indefinitely. Malaysia is an easy country to travel and be in. It's nice also Westerners get a 90 day stay on arrival.

MBMC in Penang, Malaysia is a Mahasi-style center. The Appamada Vihari Meditation Center I heard a good report from. Nandaka Vihara is another possibility.

Sasanarakkha Buddhist Sanctuary (SBS) in Taiping, Malaysia is a newer place and has an open-minded philosophy. SBS has guided retreats with various teachers throughout the year and you can also stay in a self retreat with an application. The methods taught by the abbott and head nun are influenced by U Tejaniya. They do seem to be Tiger Moms when it comes to the Karma Yoga jobs at SBS! Your sweeping technique may not pass muster. In my case, I can't say she was wrong though...

I've also heard of a couple other places in Malaysia: Vivekavana in Bukit Mertajam, Penang and Bodhi Heart on Penang. Both independent Retreat type places.

Bhikkhu Kumara, a disciple of Sayadaw U Tejaniya, is planning on buying land close to KLIA 2 airport near Kuala Lumpur to build a retreat center. This is great news but it may be mid-late 2020s before it's available.

In Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia I like Orange Pekoe Guesthouse (now closed). In Georgetown Penang, Hotel Noble is a classic standby. In Langkawi, there's a couple of highly reviewed backpacker places close together: Soluna Guesthouse, The Coconut Langkawi, and Two Peace Hostel.

Retreats in Sri Lanka

In Colombo I've stayed in the dormitory at Drift B&B and its sister, Moss B&B. Both good places, but about $15-17 a night for a dorm bed. Colombo is expensive though. Fortunately, prices go down once out of Colombo. In Kandy, there's the Burmese Vihara which is dirt cheap, like $2-3, though it was full when I went which is unusual because it's after the terror attacks in 2019 and it's shoulder season. A friend of mine checked it out in 2023 and he said it looked closed. Close by though is an excellent guesthouse, Lady Gordon Homestay, which I like a lot. Nice rooms, friendly, and good breakfast. Near the Buddha Tooth relic, is a good cheapie, Empire hotel (on Google maps, Empire cafe).

In Sri Lanka I did a retreat at Rathmalkanda Insight Meditation just outside of Ella. It's a beautiful place and had the most amazing food I've had at a retreat. The food was donated and brought in by locals. Nice having a Buddhist retreat in a Buddhist country!--best food goes to the monks and yogis! You may just have to arrive at Rathmalkanda and see if there's a place, forget about an email reservation or confirmation.

A friend of mine, Hana, did retreats at three Sri Lanka centers and writes of Insight Meditation at Rathmalkanda: *Insight meditation in Ella has no schedule at all. Food is also like Kanduboda - local support. There is also a library. Rooms are spacious and have a separate entry. It is set in the woods. Weather is colder in the mountains, but this depends on the season. The chief monk used to be the head of Kanduboda. He has good English and a good command over the Pali/Theravada sutras. He is available for questions etc everyday 4-5 but it's also not compulsory to meet with him at all. Rathmalkande is better for people already established in a self-practice or people just looking for a short respite. Here the silence is not too well maintained and you have to ask for the key to use the meditation hall each time.*

Kanduboda, is just outside of Colombo, Sri Lanka. Hana writes:

Kanduboda has beautiful grounds, the food (breakfast/lunch) is very generous from the local support, really top-notch. They do daily and evening chanting in Pali, and there's sufficient walking paths. There is a schedule but only 3 of the group sessions are mandatory sitting otherwise it is just asked to try and do 8 hours sitting and 4 hours walking daily. The chief monk speaks english and comes almost everyday. You can see him or not. It is not mandatory after the initial instruction/interview he gives to meet with him again. I really connected to several of the nuns there and found them as Sangha to be very beautiful, graceful, compassionate, and mindful. Also I appreciated the freedom to meditate in the hall, outside, or in your room. There are fans in the foreign yogi sections which made it possible to be there during the heat and still meditate comfortably.

The well known Nilambe Center near to Kandy, Sri Lanka, I've heard both positive and negative reports on. Nothing major, and it's not about the teaching, content, or delivery. Two friends complained about the extremely primitive facilities there. One friend complained and said the food there was terrible. Another friend said the food there was good -- but the rooms are horrible. Neither really recommends the place.

On the other hand, Hana writes:

Nilambe is also very beautiful. I highly recommend a retreat with Venerable Upul, the resident teacher. Here schedule is more fixed but also freedom as to where you meditate. I stayed 17 days there because the energy I felt in the meditation hall and in the center was very powerful. There is a library you can check out three books at a time before and after the retreats. I did his five day retreat but then followed the schedule for a self-guided retreat for the remainder of my time. It is very crowded with westerners but the silence was maintained and everyone was very sincere. Upul has a great/mindful presence and his guided Metta is beautiful. He also does Q and A in the evening and a 1 hour Dharma discourse during his retreats. Great English and great responses. Personally, the pros of Nilambe outweigh for me any cons of the room and not having electricity. Being without electricity ensures that people are not electronically connected too.

So what to think: I do think the facilities are pretty basic, forget Internet or even electricity. But if you go there ready for all that, it can be good. The five day course especially would be excellent for beginners. If you haven't done a Vipassana course before, find yourself in Sri Lanka, near Kandy, and are ready to live rustically for a few days, you might give it a try.

UPDATE. Nilambe is beautiful, very quiet and peaceful. It can be a bit chilly. Bring a sweater or shawl definitely. Staff and residents are kind and the food is good. I accidentally arrived a day early and they put me up and fed me when I arrived. A German teacher there, Thomas, seemed nice and I enjoyed several short conversations I had with him about books.

I agree mostly with Hana's review of Nilambe. The biggest downside was no electricity especially to recharge my phone (to use for time and alarms) and even my watch (my fault, I had a Garmin fitness watch that needs recharging every few days). Although my room had a minimal solar powered light.

Another Nilambe downside I suppose, is that the trail, barely a road, going up to Nilambe is very bad and slow going for transport. I didn't see the sign-up form for the share taxi on the last day. I think they just put it on the dining table without an announcement. Sometimes I fast and skip meals. I certainly skip entire sections of the food line. It's a bad idea to put a semi-important notice like this where it's easy for people to skip over. So the share taxi was full. They offered to

call a tuktuk for me but that would be x10 the price of the share taxi. So I walked down to the main road, about a 40 minute walk and semi-hitchhiked into Kandy. There's a bus stop at the bottom but I got a ride into Kandy immediately from a driver going there anyway. If you were walking up it would be a steep one hour climb up. I took a tuktuk from Kandy using the app PickMe but I felt bad for the driver navigating the terrible road going up to Nilambe as it took a lot of patience. I left a good tip.

I'd recommend Nilambe to others. Five days is a good length of retreat time especially for beginners. A friend from the Christopher Titmuss retreat spent a couple months here and really liked it. They're good people, beautiful surroundings, and your practice is supported.

Nilambe isn't premium lodging, but I've also stayed in far worse. One that comes to mind, was the cellar of the Bodhgaya Thai monastery (before they built their new International Meditation Center) -- and that was very rustic (let's call it *rustic*, yes). One had to duckwalk partly into the cellar where the beds had been stored for most of the year. It was a basement cellar so rats would even run over people's feet at night. The bathroom was a distance away. At the time, I didn't think too much about it. Not a big deal. Now I and others laugh about it and I suppose it gives us some cred as old-timers. Nilambe is a step up, a pretty big one, up from that.

Paramita center is close to Kandy. Foreigners welcome for retreats. http://paramitaibc.org/

If you're looking for a good beach, I liked Trincomalee a lot. Trinco is an idyllic small backpacker friendly village with many good guesthouses and restaurants. I stayed at Alass Ga Rooms and Guesthouse. The White House also had high reviews. These places are maybe a eight minute walk to the beach. At Alass Ga Guesthouse, like Lady Gordon's Homestay in Kandy, there's a good and cheap breakfast provided that you can modify easily enough to get more eggs, coffee, and toast. If they're cooking one egg anyway for you, it's easy and often great value to have them throw in three more eggs for a filling breakfast. My favorite restaurant around there was Premi.

I'd buy a Coke and a milkshake from the Golden Cottage's cafe, and use one of the shaded beach lounges in front of Golden Cottages. I stayed at Golden Cottages several years ago. Golden Cottages is right on the beach, but it's more expensive too. Instead of around $8 at Alass Ga or $15 at the White House, Golden Cottages is around $40. A friend of mine stayed at Lobster Inn, in a dorm (though they have rooms too). Lobster Inn dormitory would be a cheap option and you're almost on the beach.

In the south of Sri Lanka, Tangalle has a fantastic guesthouse, Ananda Homestay. Tangalle is nice. Tangalle beach isn't so great for swimming though. I've heard there's good beaches only a tuktuk ride away though: Try Goyambokka or Silent Beach. Although when I went it was about the same as Tangalle beach -- wavy.

There's a fairly new bus going by highway direct from Colombo to Tangalle (and Tangalle to Colombo) that's only a couple of hours drive. If not take a bus to Matara and change to Tangalle there. Fast and easy.

If you're a fan of Krishnamurti (anyone? anyone??), I really liked the Krishnamurti Center in Colombo, Sri Lanka. Very nice people and staff there. It's not a Guesthouse though and you should have a real interest in Krishnamurti staying there. If you do have an interest, and think of it as a short retreat to learn about Krishnamurti, it's a calm and charming place. Best value in Colombo, too. There's another Krishnamurti place in Chennai as well as Bangalore that people have recommended.

I hesitated putting the Krishnamurti center in here because I don't want anyone to take advantage of them. So please if you go there be on your best behaviour and use the time there to bone up on your Krishnamurti. It'd be nice if you read a Krishnamurti book before you go (there's many on my cloud) and read the Wikipedia page on his very interesting life. That way you'll be able to prove your bona fides and engage in a discussion on Krishnamurti. Both times I stayed there, I think I was mostly the only guest. Which is a bit strange since it's such a nice and beautiful place. Because you'll most likely be the only guest, you can't go there and be anonymous. You'll share meals so be prepared to talk about Krishnamurti.

Sri Lanka has many places to do a retreat. I'm hardly doing it justice.

Sri Lanka is a beautiful country with friendly people and amazing food. However I had an unpleasant experience with a smallish private bus displaying "Airport Bus 178" at the Colombo Petah Bus Stop. At the airport, after they had let everyone off, the bus conductor tried to charge me 1000 SLR! -- which is much too much. Evidently it's a private bus that posts a sign 178 Airport (no law against impersonating a bus I suppose) and overcharges foreigners. A bit earlier the conductor had been evasive when I asked him how much it was. I wasn't too worried because usually if it's a transport scam, they extort you midway through the ride, when it's more inconvenient than at the end, when you're there at your destination. But they wanted me alone.

I knew what I paid on the public express bus coming in, and it was only 250 SLR. And this private smallish bus didn't take the expressway. I offered two hundred. They refused. I asked to be let out of the bus and we'd continue bargaining. He refused and barred my way. I threatened to call the police. I banged on the window, even yelled for help. Instead, the driver started to turn the bus around and go back to Colombo. If we went back to Colombo, I would have missed my plane.

I grabbed the conductor by the throat to move him out of the way, he resisted moving, so I pushed him sideways and down a bit and punched him several times. Now -- *now* the bus driver, seeing his conductor receiving a beat down, turned his wheel back to the airport where uniformed soldiers or police were standing, he said "You want police -- Here's police!" Finally, the conductor stuck his tongue out, crossed his eyes and slowly opened up the door. I thought

he was making a face at the time, but now, who knows, maybe it was a concussion. It was less like a fight than a spanking. Not like a fight you see in movies. It was kind of weird. It felt a bit restrained. But thank Buddha I didn't get hurt, or even punched, so I can't bitch too much.

I did complain to the police that these guys were scammers, but they didn't seem too concerned about it. No blood, no foul, I guess. Sri Lanka just got done with a civil war so maybe the police have a broader perspective. But I'm sure Mr. Bus Conductor's head hurt that day and the next. What a freakin' way to make a living! I mean even if the scam works, and they get a 1000 SLR from a tourist -- that's like $5.50! And they could just get that from a couple more passengers on the trip.

And damn, if the scam starts to go bad, and you've got a large, angry foreigner who outweighs you by fifty pounds -- why not open the damn door man! Take the two hundred rupees! But still, he persisted. Maybe he's on drugs or he's just stupid. Maybe they hadn't dealt with this situation before. I'd think if you're scamming people, and then technically kidnapping them by preventing them from leaving -- you'd be prepared for escalation. Like some scammy Bangkok bars back in the day that presented foreigners with an exorbitant bill after having a few drinks. The Thai bars would have a *couple* Thai boxers standing by. Most scams involve more than $5.50 too! To be noted, I'm sure this bus scam goes both directions, both to and from the Colombo Airport. Beware of a van or smallish private type bus displaying a bus route number. Evidently it's not a crime to impersonate a bus. Find the real bus. Ask the price beforehand if in doubt.

I can't remember another time traveling where it even got this physical. Transport people tend to be the most dodgy whatever country you're in; whereas small phone shops and electronic places tend to be the coolest in my experience.

Retreats in Burma / Myanmar

Retreat centers outside of India I am not so familiar with. I've thought about doing a long retreat in Burma/Myanmar. There are Mahasi, Pa Auk, and Tejaniya meditation centers there. There's a lot of opportunities for retreat in Burma, for example, there's many Mahasi and Pa Auk Meditation centers. On the Pa Auk website they say there's 40 Pa Auk Centers with 29 of them in Burma.

Burma is a good place to visit right now as it's just opening up. In ten years Burma will probably change a lot.

UPDATE: In 2021, the Burmese military staged a coup and seized control of Burma. Check online for current travel information for Burma.

A nice thing about Burma is that you can get a meditation visa easily enough in Bangkok and have a retreat of several months or longer. Longish retreats are a good counterweight to the spiritual shopping mall syndrome.

Although it's possible to do retreats in Burma too on a tourist visa and it's probably easier and more flexible. People as of 2018 overstay their tourist visa and pay a small fine on departure. This is one of those things you always have to check as who knows, 2019 or later, Burmese policy could change. With the tourist visa you have more flexibility than the meditation visa. The meditation visa makes the meditation center responsible for you. It might be smart to do your first visit on a tourist visa, check out a couple centers, and then you know which one you want to commit to for a longish stay on a meditation visa. Write prospective centers ahead of time and read their websites and see what they recommend.

I did a retreat in South India with the fine Australian dharma teacher Patrick Kearney. He travels and does retreats in India and Malaysia. He likes U Tejaniya (author of *When Awareness Becomes Natural*). U Tejaniya recommends a more relaxed focus on continuous awareness for vipassana meditation. It's a pretty different feel than Mahasi Vipassana.

U Tejaniya's Burmese center is Shwe Oo Min (SoM). Since U Tejaniya runs it, he may be busy and not so available to Yogis and I wouldn't go there only for teachings from him. Or he could be gone, teaching elsewhere. You may be just hearing mp3's of his talks. You could be better off catching him when he comes to the West and doesn't have to deal with his Monastery day-to-day affairs. Being flexible is a good skill for yogis. Recently I've heard that U Tejaniya has been having health issues.

Still, though, I have heard good things about Shwe Oo Min: great method, teachings, with a loose schedule. If you haven't been to Burma before, don't have a strong affinity towards another Burmese method, I'd recommend starting with U Tejaniya and going to Shwe Oo Min.

To be noted, U Tejaniya has another place very close, within the same block, as SoM. Pre Covid, SoM had a max yogi visit of 90 days. After 90 days, if U Tejaniya approved, yogis would move to his place. U Tejaniya's place is newer and has better facilities.

Robin, a guide reader, spent time in Burma and Thailand. He writes of Shwee Oo Min:

Found the teachings really good, a clever modern approach to meditation. Sayadaw U Tejaniya's (SUT) goal is to make you learn about the process of meditation, not getting you to high pleasant states if you don't know how you got there (then you cling to it by trying to be "extra-mindful" to not lose that sweet peace), so he does push you to explore. Also good stuff

about handling pain, letting wisdom develop by itself instead of trying to force things, not making yourself miserable…

His meditation technique was a bit difficult for me (you don't have a fixed point of focus) but you do learn about the process of watching yourself !

About the center: people can talk (and they do quite a lot!), SUT encourages "talking meditation" to practice mindful talk - which sounds great but as it was unrestrained felt slightly too chatty for me. I hear there are specific periods for talking when he teaches retreats abroad, I'd love to attend that.

Also pretty noisy and smartphon-y all around, again as part of the approach - if you're disturbed with someone's behavior watch that feeling arise and realize the attachment is with you, not with them. It can be difficult but you do confront internal stuff!

You'll probably share a room with someone, the food not great but OK, I made very nice Dhamma friends over there and got fine retreat tips from other people.

SUT is undergoing chemotherapy, he was there but not officially teaching. If I had questions or difficulties about my practice I could try to get a short interview in between his activities, like every 3-5 days. It was just a few minutes but he's a good teacher with a good sense of humour, so those were good minutes.

When you arrive they give you 3 very good books by SUT which I read and reread, the answer to many of the questions that were arising were there.

I definitely learnt things that are applicable to any other practice and though it was difficult to get deep insight in that atmosphere it was a very interesting experience.

Also Myanmar people are really happy to see a foreigner travel all the way to their country to learn more about Buddhism, and will give you their contact if you want to visit or practice together."

Yogi Benny writes of Shwee Oo Min, Myanmar

Six hours of recommended sitting every day. Recommended, not enforced - since we are adult and have responsibility for our own practice (or learn from our mistakes). U Tejaniya is a teacher that smiles, laughs, and gets bored by theoretical questions – Sayadaw U Tejaniya is a very human master. He is wise and intelligent. Sometimes he misunderstands questions in English if the translator is not around, but his answers are always interesting even if they do not always answer the question asked.

Some mornings when I had a bad day, I just came in to him and sat listening to his discussions with other students. Just being in his presence and hearing his voice relaxed me, and of course I often was reminded of something during these conversations.

You can use different meditation techniques and meditation objects (like Mahasi or Goenka), Tejaniya stresses awareness of awareness. What is your attitude, when you know a meditation object? "The object of attention is not really important, the observing mind that is working in the background to be aware is of real importance. If the observing is done with the right attitude, any object is the right object."

The monastery is quite busy at times, people are talking and walking together. It is encouraged to do this mindfully, but of course not everyone is so mindful all the time. I appreciate silence a lot, but I was not disturbed by the talking. It is possible to stay in complete silence, if you choose that. Usually I exchanged a few words at tea time in the afternoon, or after the meals (which are in silence). I appreciated hearing a little bit about other students experiences and practice, and there were some long term students that can be very helpful. For me it was a very good mix between rules and silence that benefits the practice, and relaxation and talking as another way of practice.

As of 2024, SoM still isn't open to foreigners. I'm not overly optimistic on it reopening like it was, as word is Sayadaw Tejaniya isn't keen on traveling or even teaching the large number of foreign yogis that made their way in the past pre-covid. If you have contacts there and they know you, or someone they know can go to bat for you, there might be a place for you.

*

Panditarama Forest Meditation Center, forty miles north of Yangon, Burma, does an annual two month Winter retreat from December 1st to January 31st. Yogis come from all over the world for this retreat. Note: Panditarama has several centers across the world. Before, when I said Panditarama, I was referring to the Lumbini, Nepal branch.

Robin writes of Panditarama in Burma:

"*Following Mahasi/SU Pandita style of practice (noting everything), it was pretty intense. Full noble silence, 14 hours/day of meditation on the schedule (usually cut to 12 with breaks/shower), not too much sleep, you're expected to do everything very slowly and be extra-mindful all the time.*

Every other day there are formal interviews, for me with a monk with a kind translator. They were useful and didn't shun me when I asked about specific difficulties (I read that it happened to someone else going there, maybe a different monk). You're not here for idle chat either of course :)

Other people (around 10 men, same with women in their Dhamma hall) seemed very dedicated and diligent, and you're expected to be the same.

At night there's a recorded Dhamma talk, I think translations from Pandita talks. I was probably unlucky as I really dreaded those at first, the translation was far from fluid and kept insisting on the need for "moral fear" and "moral shame" to motivate you to practice. Not my cup of tea, it ending up being a good exercise in letting go but I was very happy I had a few books on the technique to guide me a bit more (the "practice" section of "Manual of Insight" by Mahasi, "In This Very Life" by U Pandita were both very useful).

Better to have some meditation experience beforehand, the first day you get a 1h instructional audio tape and then that's it (the books were all the more useful).

The center is very beautiful, secluded and you're really in a forest. There are lakes so mosquito repellent is a must. I was there just before their annual December/January retreat so they had space and I got a beautiful kuti. If you're scared of big spiders you'll get to work on that too! (though they do their things, they won't jump at you and I had none in my kuti)

Food is great, the place is big so you get some physical exercise and though difficult the first week I was beginning to go pretty deep by the end."

On the other hand, a good friend and yogi I respect had a difficult experience at Panditarama Burma Winter Retreat. I first met yogi Benny immediately after he finished his 2015-2016 Panditarama Winter Retreat. I don't know how to exactly describe his mental state but it wasn't good, he seemed frail with a 1000 yard stare. Christopher Titmuss said it isn't good when post retreat, yogis look like they just got back from Afghanistan.

See yogi Benny's report in the section above, *More Concentration, Mo' Problems.*

I appreciate Benny's sharing of his experience. Some people do have bad experiences meditating. See my Dark Night sections in my Wolf's Guide to Dharma Books & Practice.

I don't know if I have to say this or not, so I'll just say it so I won't worry that some beginner yogi goes off to Burma for the two month Panditarama Winter Retreat for their first retreat without having done any longish retreats and without having done a Mahasi-style retreat. It's like running a marathon without having even run a 10K before. I mean, it's possible, but I wouldn't recommend it for the Average Joe or Joanna.

It's better to make sure your first Vipassana retreat is beginner-friendly. Once I was talking to a woman in Dharamkot and she was vocal that she absolutely hated vipassana. When I asked her why, it became clear she hated Goenka style vipassana where cross-legged sitting can become

a real endurance test. If she had done a Christopher Titmuss or Jaya Ashmore vipassana retreat, she would have had a much different experience. She didn't hate vipassana -- she hated Goenka!

It's wise to do a short retreat at the center you plan to do a potential long retreat at. If you wish to do the 60 day Winter Retreat retreat at Panditarama Burma, it's wise to have done half of that length (30 days) in a similar-style retreat. You can go to Panditarama and stay at other times besides the Winter Retreat. There are Panditarama Meditation Centers worldwide. In Asia, they are in Burma, Nepal, Malaysia, and Singapore. I can recommend Panditarama Lumbini Nepal.

There's also a Mahasi style center that has been recommended in Rangoon, Chanmyay Myaing Meditation Centre. They also have two two-week Metta retreats in their branch close to Mandalay in January and February. Two western Chanmyay Myaing nuns may be available to translate.

Robin writes of Pa Auk Meditation Center:
"*The other center I heard mentioned all the time was of course Pa Auk in Myanmar, where I didn't get to spend time. A friend I meet at Shwee Oo Min spent a month there doing concentration on the breath and told me that she really enjoyed her time (and got very strong piti) but had a hard time maintaining her concentration in daily practice afterwards.*

They're really big on concentration practices, reaching Jhanas and following the Visuddhimagga to the T. They have quite nice PDF documents that explain their approach on their website. I heard the center praised by both Myanmar locals and foreigners.

She told me you could pick any of 40 meditations to build your concentration, and pick your teacher for interviews as well - they have old famous teachers with impressive concentration powers there (some say siddhis as well, if that's your thing), though she said she preferred younger & more talkative teachers after a few interviews :)"

I've heard amazing stories of Pa Auk practice. There's a couple books that recount a ridiculously detailed Jhana curriculum and practice that includes blissful jhana states, formless realms, and knowledge of past lives.

Pa Auk seems to be a highly regarded place for Jhana practice. Jhana practice was highly recommended by the Buddha too. It takes a while to develop Jhana. Shaila Catherine who wrote *Wisdom Wide and Deep: A Practical Handbook for Mastering Jhana and Vipassana*, spent many months at the Pa Auk center.

Retreats in China

Sometimes people think of going to Tibet to live in a monastery and study Tibetan Buddhism. I've never met anyone who has done this. I'm not sure if you'd be allowed by the Chinese government to do this. Paradoxically, it may be easier to study Tibetan Buddhism outside of Tibet in either Nepal or Northern India. China could one day be huge in dharma opportunities. But for right now, it's not. At least for what I've heard.

I did see on Reddit that there was an economical yearly one month study course at Datong Xingguo Chan (Zen) Temple in Tangshan, Hebei Province. Visit woodenfish.org for more information.

Other Retreats & Miscellaneous

IMS. Massachusetts, USA.

Spirit Rock, California.

Gaia House. Devon, England. Reasonable Rates.

I like Ajahn Amaro. He's at Amaravati Monastery, UK now. Amaravati has regular donation-based retreats. He's made his way out to Asia recently to do retreats too.

Guo Gu's Tallahassee Florida Chan (Zen) Center has many online events.

There's a very small Zen center in Arkansas, Gyobutsuji. I've visited and regularly attend their sangha meetings on zoom. It's a good sangha, with a cool teacher, Bradley Shoryu. Gyobutsuji holds monthly Zen meditation retreats or Sesshins. There's not a flat fee but instead it's donation. In 2022, a man from California visited and stayed at Gyobutsuji for several months. Their website was down writing this, but here's a wikipedia link:

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Gyobutsuji_Zen_Monastery

You can find Gyobutsuji on Google maps too. There's a Facebook group. Email is: shoryu@gyobutsuji.org. If you're interested, email them and attend some zoom meetings and make plans to attend a Sesshin if you can.

If you've spent time in jail in the Nordic countries – I hear it's plenty posh. Would you recommend a light drug charge for some month(s) retreat in Sweden? From what I understand it's free and you get a nice room, nice meals, and it's all quite civilized. Viva Sweden! I mention this possibility half seriously, though it might be an interesting adventure.

There's a couple favorite teachers that do regular events in Asia and I check their websites for their itinerary. Mingyur Rinpoche teaches in Nepal and India. Anam Thubten does events in Malaysia. Jaya Ashmore, as mentioned, usually does retreats in south and north India. Patrick Kearney has done vipassana retreats in India and Malaysia. Ulla Koenig is a young, dynamic Mindfulness teacher from Germany. She's an associate of Christopher Titmuss. I expect her to be doing retreats in diverse places in the future. I like Bhikkhu Kumara who has written a wonderful book, *What You Might Not Know About Jhana & Samadhi.* He is Malaysian and does retreats in Malaysia. Check in late 2020's and see if he's built his own meditation center.

The last two pre-covid years Alan Wallace has done short retreat seminars, with one at Deer Park, Bir, and another at Tushita in Dharamkot, India. Alan Wallace is a big draw, his teachings fill up fast. It's a good idea to regularly check the websites of Deer Park, Tushita, Root, as well as the personal individual websites of teachers.

Finally, Sanghaseva led by Zohar Lavie, does cool work-dharma retreats in Israel/Palestine as well as a yatra (walking pilgrimage) in the Himalayas and a work-retreat in a leper colony in central India. I believe recently Zohar and Nathan are only coming to India every other year. See sanghaseva.org for more.

I would like to participate in one of the Being Peace retreats that take place in Israel/Palestinian areas each Fall. Zohar is a good teacher and I've heard good things about the Being Peace retreats. A friend of mine liked her husband, Nathan, quite a bit and found his advice practical and helpful. If you're coming to India (or leaving it) anyway around October -- I'd sure be tempted to stop off and see Israel and Jerusalem and do Zohar's retreat and work with the Olive growers on the West Bank.

A fellow meditator raved about Neot Semadar kibbutz in southern Israel.

https://neot-semadar.com

Another reader, Jan, stayed at Hridaya Yoga Center

Hridaya Yoga & Spiritual Retreat Center. France & Mexico.
https://hridaya-yoga.com/activities/10-day-hridaya-silent-meditation-retreat/

Jan writes of his experience:

Wonderful place, atmosphere, teachers and Karma Yogis.

- Schedule of the retreat: quite full, it's a serious retreat, meditating most of the day. At the same time: not as brutal as Goenka. Almost no walking meditation. Sitting meditation starts in shorter segments, also there is an option for toilet break in the middle (at least first days). Possible to grab a chair. More teachings than in other retreats. One short Yoga session a day, a bit of community service a day, going for a walk possible in the breaks (though little time). Check schedule on webpage.
- Retreats and teachings are based on many different traditions (Advaita Vedanta, Tantra, Buddhism, Kasmir Shaivism, focus on non-duality and many others). Biggest influence self-inquiry, Ramana Maharshi, I would say.
- Retreats are quite big, no talking to teacher, can write questions on paper for Q&A.
- Food: Delicious, mostly vegan, regional and seasonal. Some visitors have troubles digesting food in the beginning, 3 meals a day, option to use a small fridge (but no cooking) with many other people.
- Mauna (silence) is quite strict
- Average participant seems much younger than in similar places (maybe 35ish)
- Can be pricy, cheaper in shared rooms, you can ask for financial assistance.
- General vibe is being rigorous about meditation (in a healthy way), but also very tender/loving/supportive.
- Overall: highly recommended! Wonderful retreats! Try it!

If you're new to Asia, I definitely recommend starting off in Thailand, Malaysia, or Nepal first before India. If you don't like Nepal, don't even bother going to India. India is like Nepal but turned up to eleven. I am always a bit impressed with travelers whose first trip outside their country was to India. I think of India as like the Graduate school of backpacking.

There's no place like India though and I love the place: the people, along with the diversity of scenery from beaches to mountains to deserts to jungle. Arguably, Indian chai, Indian food, and Indian trains are the best in the world [other countries may have more modern or high speed trains--but Indian trains are an incredible value--you can travel halfway across the country for like $12.]. India, like Nepal, is a great travel value too. You can live pretty well on $25 a day. Stay in one place for a while and your costs will go significantly down. Do a retreat and see costs from $10-25 a day.

If you're not sure if you'll like India (India can be intense), definitely try Nepal first. Nepal is great. Some great trekking and whitewater rafting and friendly people. They need the tourism too. There's dharma centers in Kathmandu, Pokhara, and Lumbini.

Google any places that interest you and read their websites for more information. At your first

stop in-country, ask people about retreats they've done and heard about and any recommendations. Use Google Maps, Trip Advisor, and the Internet, which are good sources at least currently. It used to be the Lonely Planet travel guides were *the* shit (*the shit* means good) – but now after being bought out they are shit (*shit* with no *the* preceding it means bad). Maybe try another publisher, like Rough Guides.

Be adaptable in that when you go, things may be different. *Everything changes.*

Take a look at my Wolf Guide to Dharma Books & Practice which includes some practice tips (Read the FAQ) .

https://docs.google.com/document/d/1hlk6x2XJy8ZQfdYYTibCx2ADRtZDLPqJifQrggic47k/edit?usp=drivesdk

If you had a great experience at a retreat center in Asia, please let me know. If you know of any good Zen retreat centers around the world, especially South Korea or Japan, I'd love to hear about it.
aware.wolf.ko@gmail.com

All the Best,

Wolf



Appendix A **Detailed Review of the India Kerala Wayanad Bhagavan Arunachala Ashram**

It's rare at least in my circles to hear anyone slag off this small Ashram. Most people don't know or don't care. I hope to correct this. Buckle up.

The Ashram is a bit culty and demanding. For example, the last day they presented me with a form to sign with their precepts. Including a precept to be Celibate! *WTF!* This was way too presumptuous to ask a layperson (me) who is also not a member of their Sangha. The precept form said not following their precepts meant no longer being able to return to their Ashram and receive Bhagwan's teachings, as well as *facing karmic retribution* (oh! Scary scary!). One must be pure to receive the Bhagwan's teachings, they say. Erp!

This somehow didn't feel right to me, so I refused to sign, not that I'm *very* likely to be celibate anyway, but I don't see sex as bad, sinful, or impure. I believe in liberation and freedom. I don't need more old fashioned bullshit sexual morality guidelines. It's especially galling as Gurus and spiritual teachers are some of the biggest horndogs out there. Birds do it, bees do it, and so-called pure gurus, lamas, and roshis do it too -- often leaving a wake of destruction in their midst. Why me?

We had a big argument over it. Which was fine since I took the form, the premise, and the whole presumption -- the audacity -- rather badly and didn't mind the opportunity to vent and tell them how I really felt about it.

Finally, even the next day, after the huge argument, the poor guy in charge of trying to get me to sign the form, came back *again*, asked me if I'd signed the form and I welcomed the opportunity to tear into them again. Thank you! Namaste! --the Buddha was right, anger really does have a honeyed tip!

There was some confusing semantics on their end that I'm just signing that I'm aware of the precepts and it's up to me whether I choose to violate them or not. Well of course it's up to me. And no way in Hell I'm signing it.

What about the relationships this has ended? Doesn't the Bhagavan feel anything when he's the cause of breaking couples apart? I asked what happens to couples that come to the Ashram for the Intensive and want to continue studying: *Some couples find celibacy makes their relationship stronger*, they told me. Bullshit! Bullshit! Bullshit! I can't believe they were able to say this to me with a straight face.

For most couples, when one person decides to become celibate so they can be spiritually pure so they can be a clean vessel to receive the Bhagavan's teachings -- it will mean the end of the relationship. But cults are well-known for breaking people away from people they are close to, so I suppose it's par for the course. It's one thing if one person decides becoming one of Bhagavan's "monks" is the path for them and commits to live near the Ashram and enjoy their special lifestyle. But hey, people can make their own choices. People can run off and join the French Foreign Legion too. It's your life.

Imagine though traveling to India with your boyfriend or girlfriend, exploring spirituality, and wandering into one of the Bhagavan's ten-day Intensives and at the end, your partner signs the Precepts, makes a decision to become celibate, and wants to stay and live near Bhagavan, because, they say, he's a living Buddha. Sad. You'd think an Enlightened guru would have compassion for both people in a relationship and want to work with them both in the confines of their relationship rather than break them apart, and foster heartbreak. I think someone is due for some karmic retribution here. And it ain't me.

They tried bringing up the Buddha & Buddhism in support of their arguments, which is a mistake against me, since I'm pretty well-armed here, and let's just say I have the ability to effectively counter. After bringing up dodgy Buddha references in support: For example, *The Buddha only gave teachings to people who were pure; The Buddha recommended celibacy; The Buddha also waited until he had a mass of followers before teaching; The Buddha gave secret teachings only to those he deemed worthy.* How about a ***NO***. All untrue, and it's strange they're appealing to Buddha as an authority when they're not even Buddhist! I corrected their faulty Buddhism and they stopped bringing up false Buddhism assertions in support of their own practices. I wonder if they still claim Buddha supports their beliefs with other people though. I wouldn't be surprised as it would require intellectual honesty for them to refrain.

Afterwards, I wondered what celibacy even meant. Is Masturbation alright? Masturbation with asphyxiation? Sexy Mukbangs? Sex dolls? Glory holes (so you are not even in the same room!)? Giving Blowjobs? Toe sucking? Yiffing? Ballroom dancing? Pole dancing? Lap dancing? Electrostimulation? Humiliation? Klismaphilia? Alien egg impregnation? Pooing in the shower? Blumpkins? Dead mouse taxidermy porn? BDSM male chastity? Dutch Ovens?

Where does it ever stop?

Technically, if one uses a condom, you're not even touching her. What about Squat Gobbling? -- getting naked, then sitting in a pie and wriggling around. Also known as Boston Cream Splat. There's a variant called Crybaby Squat Gobbling where the participant cries profusely while performing. It's pretty hot.

I've got a million questions like this if you really want to attempt to dictate my sex life. If it exists, there's porn and a fetish of it.

These type of questions are why I would be a terrible recruit for any cult. In addition, I fear no man, like to speak my mind, like to make fun of pomposity, and I can even take a beating if they're up for that.

I believe it's far wiser to have a general precept like “Don't misuse sex.” --otherwise you get trapped into defining what sex acts are acceptable and which are not. Sex acts not on the prohibited list become de facto acceptable. Now. How hard is it to know all the sex acts and fetishes out there? Like impossible, right?

If squat gobbling is okay and so is *giving* blow jobs in a Lassie Furrie costume at a truck stop -- because they are not specifically prohibited (and also they may not involve sexual gratification, at least directly, you know…) -- but intercourse in a loving relationship is out -- it's pretty messed up. *In my opinion.* The wisdom of the Bhagwan may disagree. If the Bhagavan's deciding factor is whether sexual gratification is involved – sometimes I may fuck not for sexual gratification at all. Seriously. And I'm not going to claim I fuck for tantric union. What if I want to fuck her just to shut the bitch up? One of my best friends in my younger days, would always recommend Greek anal style for any type of relationship issue. The first time I heard his advice, I thought hey it could make sense, I've heard crazier relationship advice (like "The Rules"). Then I saw my friend offer the advice to go for anal sex for any relationship problem. Can't one have sex for other than sexual gratification? What if it's a hate fuck? What if I'm going for some personal record? What if my partner is horny and I'm not but I've taken the Bodhisattva vow and want to give her a good time? What if it's about power and I want to hump her leg like the bad alpha dog 🐶 I am?

Or how about, BMW Bhagavan fanboys, as long as I'm not hurting anyone, when it's consensual, and especially as I try to leave a partner better than when I found them -- you keep your goddamn judgmental pie hole shut? Or you can face your own karmic retribution when we're not on your territory.

Maybe you can tell I didn't take the Form well. Most people I was told just signed the form. Like whatever. It's like the Terms & Conditions for Apple or other software companies, I was told. Seriously. Again, this struck me as wrong, oh so very wrong. I've thought these one hundred plus page terms and conditions were bullshit and it's beyond me why a small Ashram in India would model accepting their precepts on Apple and Facebook's Terms & Conditions. I thought I was getting away from this shit. If I was running a small Ashram and ever defended an Ashram practice by saying: “Well, it's like Facebook's Terms & Conditions…” -- I would stop and freeze. But I guess that's just me. Like What. The. F*ck. Am I doing? Really modeling themselves on Facebook practices is hardly way to win me over. I was practically snarling.

There was also a required sit where we sat and listened to *a recording* of Vedic chants. I suspect it's a recording because the youngish core inner group of Westerners and Israeli backpackers don't know the chants well enough to lead them in person. It felt like a waste of time. One female devotee colored during this time.

Another obnoxious practice is that they ask you to put your name on the donation (Dana) envelope at the end of the course. Now, why would they do that? Unless it's to see what people give and to put subtle pressure for people to give more. A member of their Sangha tried to tell me it wasn't about the money. They aren't about the money. I laughed. Sure. How fast would they change if they started getting *less* cash? Deposits are required to reserve a spot at the Wayanad Bhagwan Ashram and full course payment is expected upon arrival. PayPal add an additional 10% fee. Bring a Form C Guesthouse form with photo or it's a 100 rupees (about $1.50). I had locked up my valuables and asked if I could bring them the 100 rps on the last day. The next day though they asked me to pay them the 100 rps *now.* Fine. It felt a little like being nickel-and-dimed though.

But the Bhagwan got a new car, a nice car, a BMW X7 (98 Lakhs or $100,000) in 2018 and they even built a new garage for the car (over where a much needed new dormitory had been planned). God's work, bless em.

Ashram devotees gush that their guru Bhagavan is a Buddha or a Ramana. But I don't recall these teachers buying obscenely expensive things. Osho might be a better comparison since he had a fleet of Rolls-Royces. At least Osho had the common sense that he built up an infrastructure first. Wayanad Arunachala Ashram has been described as a shithole in the jungle. I think that's too harsh, but I think it's trashy and low-class to put donated money into a fancy new car instead of improving the buildings. Is an expensive new car what the donors had in mind when they gave? Is this a wise use of the money? And this guy has the secrets to me having a better life? -- when he spends money like a drunken sailor? I would ask if the Ashram organization has yearly audits -- I strongly believe every organization when they get a certain size should audit themselves -- but I think we all know the answer to that question. Grifters don't care about proper accounting procedures (neither do dumb-asses). I know bringing up the right way to do finances isn't sexy, but what do you think happens to organizations that lack proper accounting safeguards?

I spent twenty days (10 day Intensives x 2) with the Bhagavan and although he seemed nice enough and I was generally satisfied with the teachings at the time, a lot of it didn't seem like anything that special especially if you've read Ramana Maharishi. Bhagavan also never seems to spice up his teachings with stories. There's nothing about his childhood or when he was a student studying. He's like a blank slate and often rather dry with a lot of Sanskrit words thrown in. His English is okay but personally I had trouble understanding him. Devotees might opine that it's my poor karma I'm not fortunate to understand the deep profound and subtle message of the Bhagavan. I understand Dayananda teachers fine though. I read and appreciate Ramana Maharishi and Nisargadatta. If it's my karma that I'm not wetting myself over Bhagavan's guru bliss -- well, thank you karma! I don't know what I did to deserve it, especially when some smart people seem to have had ultra-spiritual experiences in his satsang. I can't really explain it.

It's a bit wyrd too, them being Vedanta and all, but they use what they call a Zen stick to poke suspected sleepers during meditation. Even in zen, a lot of zen schools don't do it, or you can opt out, or you must ask to be hit.

I think it's difficult to screw up managing a meditation session. What else is there to do besides let people sit undisturbed and have a beginning bell and ending bell? I can't think of anything. Maybe you don't even need the bells! Yet the Bhagwan Wayanad Cult people have someone circulating the room with a stick to poke people who *may* be sleeping. Eyes closed, you look too relaxed -- POKE.

The Zen stick is yet another story as when I was meditating and not sleeping, yet still was poked--I told them off. Bitch slapping someone is very old school Zen. I know Zen. I love zen. I'm a Bodhi Zendo fan. If they want to play Zen games--sure I'll play. And we were close to playing. The next meditation session after I told them to *never do that again*, they announced that if the Zen stick triggers you--maybe you should look at yourself. How considerate! I thought if they want to trigger me, and help me look at myself, I should return the favor: Disarm the Zen stick, sweep them to the ground, then whip their legs. Then they can look at themselves, their welts, triggers, and reflect. Ommm yourself, Bro. How do it feel now?

I had a bit of a concern that in their Ashram that this wouldn't be a wise move. There's a lot of young Israelis there and they all served in the army and if one of ‘em knows Krav Maga, it could be pretty bad for your trusty old narrator! Better to just finish the Intensive and try to leave on good terms. So I just meditated with my eyes open and glared at the stick guy when he came close. If he'd had poked me with my eyes open, it would have been Game On. This all did provide some interesting meditation sessions LOL. Overall, I prefer a nice sit in a zen garden with nonpoking.

Someday, I'm told, when the Ashram attracts a certain number of hardcore followers, Bhagwan will start teaching the *real* Vedanta stuff. Bhagavan has to bring people around slow, they say. But there's devotees that have been there for years -- and they're still not ready? How come other teachers don't have a problem with giving out real teachings? Dayananda Ashram has regular Vedanta camps and teachings. Most good teachers I've met teach like their hair's on fire -- they have a passion to get their message out. They don't just sit there silent, twisting their beard, patting their little white dog, for thirty minutes in satsang. Devotees tell me that's an invitation to share in the Guru Bliss. New Age Guru-speak like that makes me almost throw up a little bit in my mouth.

I doubt Bhagavan ever really teaching Vedanta will happen. When I was there, it was mostly Question and & Answer (Q&A). Now a year later, I hear it's still Q&A. There's Sangha members been living in the area there for ten years, waiting. For the Q&A, Sangha members would take the chair in front of the guru during satsang, and ask questions like, why do their nipples tingle during meditation in the blissful presence of the Bhagwan?

These type of questions in public often seem to be the questioner seeking glory and a pat on a back. I call these type of questions, *cookie questions*. As in, someone's wanting to show off... "Oh. You're having an altered state? Fine. Here's a cookie." Here, the answer was it was the heart chakra opening up or True Self emerging or something like that. It was hard for me to pay attention as although the Bhagwan's teachings were alright, sometimes even pretty good -- they had a soporific quality and were eminently forgettable. I blamed myself as others went on and on and on about how great they were and even moved out there, with some building houses close to the ashram. Okayyy.

If there was a video of his teachings you could see for yourself. Or if there was a book authored by the Bhagavan, you could read it, ponder it, and decide for yourself. Interestingly, there's not a video and there's no book. I wonder why not? If he's a Buddha, a living Ramana -- and he's got a message -- why not put online some videos and put out a book? I'm sure the Ashram Inner Circle has some bullshit reason that his teachings are too powerful, or too secret, or that the teachings are only for the select discerning few who travel to receive them personally in the ambiance of his moist guru bliss. But nowadays what teacher doesn't have audios, videos, and books? The Dalai Lama does, Ramana Maharishi, Nisargadatta, Krishnamurti, the Karmapa, Tenzin Palmo, Swami Dayananda -- you name it -- good teachers teach with an open hand. Before I cancelled, I was in their Wayanad Bhagavan Facebook group. They posted interestingly enough quite a few zen memes. Rarely anything by the Bhagavan. A few times they posted a brief Bhagavan teaching, but warned it may not be an accurate representation of what he really said. Nice. They can't even get a few inspiring lines right. I don't blame them. The Bhagavan is hard to pin down. If I asked a devotee to quote something the Bhagavan said, it would likely be embarrassing. *It's not about words, Wolf, it's about his presence, it's like the taste of sugar, impossible to put into words,* they might respond. Erp. Excuse me, I just threw up again.

So maybe that's why there's no Bhagavan book. It's gobbly-de-gook. I've attended near twenty days of his teachings and can't really disagree. See my *Guide to Dharma Books & Practice*, the FAQ on Gurus where I talk about the Bhagavan, Bentinho Massaro, Charles Manson and word salad gurus. Yet despite both receiving no teachings and when he does teach, when you parse what he actually says, it’s nonsensical or simple -- despite this -- his young backpacker devotees think he’s the greatest thing since sliced bread, *a living Buddha,* and that they’re lucky to be around him. It seems to be less about studying actual Advaita Vedanta than a cult of personality. At least the few devotees I’ve questioned about Advaita Vedanta, despite spending months or even years at their Wayanad Vedanta ashram -- didn’t seem to know all that much about Advaita Vedanta.

Then there's the whole issue of his name: Bhagwan. Alright. It's a little Osho-like. Bhagwan or Bhagavan means God. So, there's that. And why would you choose a name that is already fairly notorious? His real name and background --unknown. He doesn't share that information. Seems a bit one-sided to me: *A Vedanta teacher who doesn't teach core Vedanta along with a mysterious background* -- it's almost like the documentary *Kumare (*a recommended

documentary where an Indian-American pretends to be a Guru and builds a following. See my cloud drive:

Kumare
https://drive.google.com/folderview?id=1_wETYCbuNjZbjPRIJdYUfOlu_2DsgRa-

-- yet it's common for his followers to commit to move there and *build a house*, which they won't own, to prove they're serious seekers. You'd think such serious and ernst seekers would be knowledgeable on Sankara, the Gita, and the Upanishads -- but in my experience talking to them this doesn't seem to be the case. From what I gather from their guru-speak, it's more sitting in the Bhagwan's guru bliss. I've had a devotee counter that he does teach Vedanta and he just returned from a special Bhagavan teaching on the Yoga Sutras of Patanjali in Kollur. True, there are special retreats occasionally that are not Q&A. You pay for these retreats, even if you're a dedicated devotee and living a life of celibacy, and there's still a special Dana at the end for Bhagavan and you're told more than once to put your name on the Dana envelope. Evidently it's Bhagavan's special insight that unless you give a significant amount, you won't absorb the teachings. Nice.

But even here, the Yoga Sutras of Patanjali are *not* a Vedanta text (although they're good and the Yoga Sutras are a good book to read). I asked the young man: *How come you don't know this?* I know this and I'm primarily in the Buddhist camp. They often teach the Yoga Sutras of Patanjali at the myriad yoga teacher training camps. There's a clue even in the name: The **Yoga** Sutras… These type of Westerners risk becoming caricatures -- ignorant of India and not spiritually well-read or experienced and then falling into an Ashram with near-clones who ponce on that what they're doing and experiencing is equivalent to the original disciples of the Buddha or Christ. God Bless 'Em, I guess.

If you want Vedanta teachings, I can recommend the Dayananda Ashram. Dayananda stresses the importance of a good guide for Vedanta and Dayananda warns if a Vedanta teacher won't detail their own study and their teachers -- to run away as fast as possible. Dayananda Ashram actually teaches Vedanta too and doesn't charge. Apparently Dayananda Ashram hasn't found it a problem to give away real Vedanta teachings at no cost and for students to still learn it.

Why the mystery over Bhagavan's background, what? -- was he a pharmacist in his civilian life as one devotee theory goes? Carpet salesman? Chai Walla like Modi? If Bhagavan's command over Vedanta is so rich and profound, why doesn't he share how he accumulated such knowledge and who were his teachers? That way his students could try to replicate it. If he's a Buddha or a living Ramana Maharishi, why wouldn't his life story be of great interest and inspirational to his devotees?

The Sangha are young, mostly backpacker types, even the inner circle, and I don't think they know what they are doing. I don't hold it against them. They may be just a bit sheepish, doting on the Bhagwan and going on about his guru bliss (to be honest, I never felt it--my nipples never

tingled!), rearranging shoes and straightening them on the path before Bhagwan walked into satsang, and telling us the Guru is *not* to be approached or talked to outside of satsang (despite it being a very small Ashram), and parading around during meditation time with a zen stick. They seem extremely thin-skinned and there's a deeply repugnant culture of informing on other people there.

Speak your mind, ask hard questions, not be a sheep -- get kicked out. You have to be careful with even talking to an Ashram friend as you very well may be ratted out. So much for their Path including integrity. I knew a young woman who was sick after an intensive and asked to stay an extra day or two. It went all the way up to the Bhagavan and she was told she still had to leave. So much for their Path including compassion. Interestingly this young woman was debating going back for another stay at the Bhagavan Ashram. She had many friends who were Bhagavan devotees and thought maybe she should give the Ashram another chance. But we went for a walk and I shared I had many of the same doubts she had. It wasn't just her. This is one reason why I write these reviews. It's easy to let peer pressure and group-think influence you.

I owe Bhagavan devotees many thanks for help immunizing me (more) against guru bullshit. In a way, I think they aren't total idiots for doing what they do. Maybe instead it's genius: they don't need people like me who will balk at bullshit, call them out, and make fun of them, in their cult. I don't like rats. If I heard of a devotee ratting out another one -- I'd be tempted to take care of business. I don't know what sage said it, but, *Snitches get stitches*.

You may be able to tell even if I wanted to, I would not be a good fit at the Wayanad Bhagavan Arunachala Jungle Ashram.

I would start imitating the Bhagavan or making up funny nicknames for the Inner Circle. I wouldn't want people like me in my cult, either. I'm flattered they spent hours arguing with me about it. If there was a Survivor-type program and I had to spend six months at their Ashram without being kicked out, and the stipulation was I had to maintain my integrity and be somewhat myself instead of a devotee drone -- I'd laugh and refuse because that would be impossible. I'd be kicked out within a month. Probably the Over/Under is a week. My good personal friends might all take the Under though.

With their Celibacy requirement, quickly they know whether a person is a sheep or not. If a person can be convinced to give up their sex life after one ten day Intensive Retreat -- well, they're hardly likely to be independent, questioning, skeptical people. What kind of people are those that sign? I dunno, all kinds, I expect, but in my Wayanad ashram dorm was a repeat Ashram visitor who was a Sangha member. He did a lot of loud whispering to himself for hours and sometimes it would escalate and get intense. I don't think he was quite sane. He's a pure vessel though because he's not fucking anyone (Bhagavan logic). Sure.

Some people want to do an exotic practice that is off the maps and the Wayanad Bhagwan Jungle Ashram is literally off Google Maps, with no website, and the conditions at the Ashram while not too bad, it was a crowded dormitory, with mattresses on the floor, one toilet, and had mold problems. Some people believe that the harder they struggle, the more valuable the teachings must be. Still, it's sad to me. These people are stuck out in the Wayanad jungle waiting for years. Instead they could be taking Dayananda's two or three year intense residential Advaita Vedanta course. Instead of playing at Liberation and being on their own Purity kick, they could actually be getting the real thing.

So. Evidently I'm not ever going back there, as I'm not allowed, I'm not *Pure* -- but that's okay. I'm wary of Gurus generally. You cannot imagine how much disdain, contempt, and venom is in my italicized *Pure* in my last sentence! The dial's at eleven.

I've wrote quite a bit here on what is a small Ashram but it's like my take-down of Daniel Ingram in my Wolf's Guide to Dharma Books and Practice -- it's about more than a specific wonky guru or Ashram and their delusional following. I'm not sure who is more deluded, the author Daniel Ingram (who thinks he's an Arahant and believes in fairies) or some of the more passionate pretend-monk followers of the Bhagavan. You may not run into Daniel Ingram or the Wayanad Bhagavan Arunachala Ashram but you'll find the spiritual marketplace is full of frauds, grifters, crazies, and predators.

Don't be afraid to be yourself. Be a person of integrity. Question not only Authority but everything. One of Zen's three pillars is Great Doubt. Keep your eyes open and don't ignore red flags. Do your due diligence. Remember Buyer Beware.

Ask yourself if the path has a heart.

Don't trust any guru or teaching that claims a monopoly on Truth or has secret teachings. Be open to new teachings. Get out and visit teachers and centers that may have new teachings for you. Have friends with other beliefs.

Don't get caught in the spiritual bypassing mousetrap thinking you're getting special teachings and that this makes you special. Don't look down on those caught in an obvious mousetrap while you yourself are caught in a more subtle deluxe version. You're still caught.

But if you're honest, open, reflective, and have a sense of humor you'll do okay. Keep the Precepts. Practice the Brahmaviharas. Don't cling to anything including points of view.

I've heard other things too about this Ashram that I won't go into. Some I was told in confidence. Others the person didn't want it linked back to them. As if they are afraid. I think as time goes on, more unfavorable stories will come out on the Wayanad Bhagavan Arunachala Ashram. Time will tell.

And for a start (and it ain't looking good for the Ashram…), a Google search provides a Quora take on their Ashram from someone who spent 18 months there:

https://www.quora.com/Have-you-visited-Arunachala-Ashram-in-Kerala

I'm not sure also which is more damning, the Anonymous May 29th 2019 post on Quora which takes down the Bhagavan (from what I can tell it's mostly accurate), or some of the more recent pro-Ashram posts that read like New Age Guru Babble-Speak. One pro-Ashram response praised the authenticity and warned *not for picnickers!* -- my, aren't we special! Caught in the guru mousetrap yet looking down on the spiritual tourists caught in the shopping mall dharma mousetrap.

May 29th 2019 post excerpt:

> Yes, I have not only visited, but lived near this ashram for one year and a half. I don't recommend at all to anyone to visit "Arunachalashram"/ "Arunachala Hridayam". It was a great disappointment and waste of time in my spiritual search. Having witnessed the backstage of the ashram and its guru, I came to realize the corruption behind the facade of purity that they show off. I would have a lot to say, but it would be impossible to write everything here in this forum, so I will give you just a few remarks about it.
>
> Sunilkumar Kadaikal is the real name of the so called "Bhagavan", the guru of this ashram. He is not an enlightened sage as his students believe him to be. Sunikumar is a fake guru who is creating a spiritual business and running a very dangerous and nasty cult around his authoritarian leadership inside his community in the south of Kerala (Korome/Karimbil, Wayanad).
>
> Despite claiming to represent a tradition of sannyasins and presenting himself as a renunciate, free of any ego and desire, he drives shamelessly a BMW X7, which costs more than 100.000 euros. Moreover, there are very strong indications that he is diverting all the money of the ashram for his personal use and that the car was paid with this money (from his "monks"). For a long time, the ashram has been raising money for new buildings which never happened, and while the students have to squeeze themselves in a small room to attend his satsangs (and some even have to watch from the outside), he comfortably enjoys the spaciousness of his luxurious car.
>
> Many of his students recently left the sect having witnessed in "Bhagavan" several unacceptable incongruences and abusive behavior, acknowledging the cult characteristics in his leadership and in the group. Kumar is a self-proclaimed Buddha and he is not coherent with such position. He misuses his power in many ways, but no one can question or confront him, as one of his methods is to threat with expulsion those who dares to do so.
>
> He has many prejudices against Hinduism and Bhakti, and disregard all other Vedanta schools as distorted versions of the Original Vedanta, of which he claims to be the only loyal representant on Earth. Although not accepting formally any kind of devotion, Kumar is like an idol in the highest pedestal for his students, to whom he became the supreme authority. This has proved to be very dangerous, because it is too much power in the hands of someone who is not selfless, dharmic, nor compassionate.

Although posing like a Shankara of this age, he doesn't have the qualifications of a master and he is not even transmitting the knowledge like a Vedanta teacher. Actually, Kumar is very distant from being a reference of the Original Vedanta, as he created a self-styled approach which was tailor-made to serve his own interests. One of the many deviations from the Vedas in his approach is his monastic system. He is creating a community of brahmacharis (monks) which is very commercial, as they cannot have any access to his teachings unless they pay each time for his 15 days retreats. Besides that, in each retreat they have also to give a good amount of money as dakshina, a donation for the teachings.

There is a dogma created by Kumar that if a student doesn't give enough dakshina he will not assimilate and retain the teachings. That's part of the bizarre belief system he has invented. If that were true, Buddha, Jesus, Shankara, Sri Ramakrishna, Sri Ramana Maharshi and other sages would have charged for their teachings, but that never happened, and it was never an impediment for their disciples to grasp their spiritual message. This theory is completely absurd and cannot be endorsed by any Vedic scripture. That was a very nasty strategy to extract more money from a transmission that, traditionally, was always given for free.

This is probably the only case, not only in the Vedantic tradition, but in any spiritual tradition, wherein monks cannot receive teachings without paying, having to sustain a secular life in parallel in order to work and make money to afford the the costs of an unconventional "monastic lifestyle". Monks without monastery, who have to pay and donate dakshina, and still spend a lot of money travelling all over India to recruit more people to his group. As his students are mostly westerners who are completely unaware of the Vedic system, they easily conform with his distorted approach.

The Wayanad Arunachala Bhagavan Ashram do have a good Sangha that often show up at Bodhi zendo, or Tiru, or Rishikesh. Personally, I like many of them. Not all are alike and I try to see them as people, not as gushy deluded vulnerable Westerners on their special Indian Guru trip. Enough time has passed now that several devotees I have had verbal repartee with, left the Ashram themselves or been banned. I doubt most devotees I argue with about the Ashram will be sangha members long-term. Most will quit, and those that stick with it are True Believers. So what's the point of arguing besides planting a few small seeds that hopefully might wake them up?

I try not to be a jerk to leavers and say "See I was right, I told you so!" -- instead they're to be congratulated. The Wayanad Arunachala Ashram was right for them for a time in their life, and now they're ready to move on, a bit older and wiser.

Optimally, I should see their value as people and friends in both situations. If they're devotees and don't bring up Bhagavan Guru Bliss to me, I won't bring up red flags, celibacy, playing being a pseudo monk, Bhagavan's mysterious background, lack of real systematic teaching, and epistemological concerns, and the Manson girls. I'm thinking of warning devotees beforehand now that I'm probably one of the worst people for them to wax on about Bhagavan to. I feel like they're an oblivious pleasure cruise love boat captain sailing under the blissful blue skies --

while I'm a zen-trained, dharma combat-ready U-Boat captain with a salvo of torpedoes, ready to roflstomp. *Scratch one flattop!*

I've seen Bhagavan devotees and it's inevitable they'll bring up the Ashram and Bhagavan. At a center meal table or Vegan cafe, someone will ask them where they have been in India, and then their beady eyes will light up and they'll say they're staying in Wayanad. Inevitably again, the person will ask what they are doing in Wayanad. Then they can say they stay at an Ashram. Spiritually minded people will then ask about the Ashram. So although at centers like Bodhizendo, it's been enough of an issue that they're told to please not proselytize and recruit – if someone asks questions they're allowed to talk about their experience. They've got it down smooth. It happens to me too and with new Bhagavan people I'm meeting, when they say they're living at Wayanad, I'll short circuit their spiel and either change the subject and ask about the rainy weather at Wayanad or mutual friends there. Or I'll say "Oh the BMW Buddha Bhagavan cult?" and see them deflate. They can't really argue but if they do, I"ll just bring out more and more Bhagavan ashram bullshit in a galloping gish sort of way. Bhagavan really does have a BMW. His devotees believe he's a living Buddha. And of course people in a cult never believe it's a cult. However, people that have left Wayanad Bhagavan Arunachala Hrudayam Ashram mostly either think it's a cult, or ponder the question super seriously, or disturbingly, appear *afraid* to opine on the matter. In a Quora post (included at the end of this section below), written by someone calling themselves *a Bhagavan Student*, there is this creepy threat:

> If you say something bad against a sage it is the worst karma ever. So terrible to do it. That's what Bhagavan says. It's a well-known rule and people who are doing this will pay badly. These liars online will pay. They are dangerous to the world and great enemies of the Dharma.

One of the signs of a cult is that *former followers are at best-considered negative or worse evil and under bad influences*. That's a Bingo on the cult checklist.

(See the Rick Ross Cult checklist on his website or in my Wolf's Guide to Dharma Books & Practice, Guru FAQ).

In Ross's *Ten warning signs of a potentially unsafe group/leader*, I can check off nine out of ten signs Ross gives. Some apply more than others. Some are a strong check off, others are sorta a meh. Number four, *Unreasonable fear about the outside world, such as impending catastrophe, evil conspiracies and persecutions*, I'm not familiar enough with the inner workings to be able to opine here. I don't think it's a good fit here as it is for say some Christian apocalyptic cults like David Koresh's.

The only one that clearly doesn't apply is number seven:

> 7 There are records, books, news articles, or television programs that document the abuses of the group/leader.

Maybe because it's so small and secretive, without even a Google maps designation for their ashram. Nobody's heard of it so one's guard may be down. It's easy to be seduced by peer pressure and group-think. One may think that if you don't see anything special or feel the guru's bliss – it must be you.

This is why I've written this to warn people that if they just don't feel it with Bhagavan, his ashram, and his devotees – trust your bullshit radar. It's not just you. You don't have to give them a second chance. I'm not against anyone exploring anything really – check out a Scientology orientation, an Osho retreat, or a Gurdjief dance if you want. I've had relatives attend time-share condominium high pressure sales pitches in order to get a free stuff. Actually, you don't have to give dodgy grifty gurus even a first chance.

I've considered taking out this section so as not to make things awkward. But it's my own point-of-view and my own experience. And like I said earlier, there's not much critical of the Wayanad Arunachala Ashram out there. People are free to make their own decisions and decide their own path. I just think it can be useful for people to receive another point-of-view. I also like to poke fun at overly-inflated ultra spiritual scenes and an Ashram run by youngish backpackers, in a *Lord of the Flies* management style, who have trouble stringing together coherent sentences of their Ashram experience, who practically drool over an overweight Vedanta teacher they believe is the highest sage in the world – a living Buddha, yet a Vedanta teacher that rarely teaches Vedanta, kicks people out of the ashram over trivialities from snitch reports, and now rides around in a $100,000 car -- makes it easy.

See my Q&A in my Wolf Guide to Dharma Books and Practice, "Do I need a guru?" (Short answer is **NO**).

Truth be told, I enjoy seeing these Wayanad Ashram devotees, they're often beautiful people, friendly, and I sometimes envision them as being Pure and Holy (which amuses me) especially when they are wearing a traditional Indian dress. Good for them! You go, Girl! Their path is their path and they are serious on it.

I'll close with a long post (edited for length) that was written in rebuttal on Quora defending the Ashram. Like the best (or worst) of raving MAGA posts – it's hard to tell if its real or a parody. Let it speak for itself:

I believe what Bhagavan says about Ramana, he knows everything. He has psychic powers and can see. He is beyond God so he is never wrong. Who would imagine that he could lie or invent such things just to manage the ashram's money and take it to himself? Only his ex-students. They say he might have used our money for his own purposes because we have been collecting money for many years for a new Sangha hall and it's still not built yet and when Bhagavan got a BMW instead of a new Sangha hall people have said that he took money, but there is no connection between these things at all. He only uses the car, which is not his, when he leaves the ashram to other places. Everything he does is always for the whole of the group because that's what a Buddha does.

These gossips that are spread by people who don't see who he is. I don't listen to them. Bhagavan says they are confused and have too many entities in them, which are influencing them. The locals I met in Tiruvannamalai that knew him when he was living there are all lying or don't know what they are talking about. And the locals in Waynad are stupid for not believing he is God embodied and beyond. They don't know anything about Vedanta anyway. They are just simple villagers and cannot understand these higher truths. They think he is just a man. He is always classy every time I see him for satsung. I see Him 2 hours each day everyday when there is an intensive going on. The intensives are very pure and the best part is satsung when you can finally see Him. He used to have a dog Uttu who was a very high yogi and who is now fully liberated. Bhagavan has liberated more animals than Ramana ever did he says.

If you say something bad against a sage it is the worst karma ever. So terrible to do it. That's what Bhagavan says. It's a well-known rule and people who are doing this will pay badly. These liars online will pay. They are dangerous to the world and great enemies of the Dharma. They lie and say terrible things rather than to accept the Truth about Bhagavan. They compare Bhagavan to Ramana Maharshi. Do not ever compare him to Ramana Maharshi because He is HIGHER than Ramana Maharshi. He even said once in satsang that Ramana was actually only in "safe yoga", an elevated state of consciousness, but not nirvana. You can ask the people who have known him the longest about this. He will not tell this in satsang to just everybody. He only hints it sometimes for those who are fortunate to understand. But the tells the closet disciples the Truth about Himself. That's why they are so dedicated. They know the Truth. He is the Highest being alive right now. Maybe even of all time. He allows people to talk about how he is the reincarnation of Adi Shankara who is bringing back the only true path. That's what many people think there and if he allows that talk, I think it must be the truth.

Ramana was probably not beyond God like Bhagavan because he still had empathy for people, and Bhagavan doesn't have. Empathy is a human thing. Although a lack of empathy and amazing intelligence is a sign of sociopathy, it is also a Vedic sign of being higher than God, in spiritual beings. When fake seekers compare Bhagavan to cult-leaders that is what they don't understand. Bhagavan says that the lack of feeling or emotion in his presence is another sign that of being the MOST HIGH. He is higher than God and Ramana Maharshi. There will be consequences for those who ever think anything bad of a true sage as he is who is Beyond God.

Any person who left our ashram was always badly influenced by devas or evil forces. Bhagavan does not care about deva games. He does not care about human psychology or even much for humans which are very low. He wasn't born a human. He's not human, he's much higher than a human. And that's why he doesn't like humans. Many people were kicked out by Bhagavan because they are not worthy of The Path. They are not sincere or they hear stories about his past and believe it, they are fools. Only He is teaching us the Truth. He can never do anything wrong because he is the living Buddha.

Many people from all over the world come to listen to him. They are found by special recruiters who are meant to share the word of the Dharma, it's their duty to do so to be able to give people a chance of salvation in this lifetime. Niv and Nick are some of the best recruiters and they're doing a great job. Most of the people they bring are Western or Indians from non-Brahmin castes. There are even a few Indians who come who are special professors. They have donated the ashram land and a lot of money, so they have a lot of merit and so are able to retain the teachings more than others who don’t give or are stingy with their Dakshina. Every person must write their name on their dakshina so Bhagavan knows who is being greedy and won’t be able to retain the teachings well. When the professors come everybody has to go. They fall asleep and snore during satsang sometimes while the Buddha is answering questions. But it doesn't matter because the very fact of being in his presence is a great blessing for them and just hearing Him speak will help them in future lives.

Bhagavan teaches Vedanta in exactly the right way that only He can teach. We all can feel it in the Satsang Hall. I had many direct experiences where "I" disappeared. That's only possible because his Holy Body acts like a black hole, which sucks our vasanas. There are no words and it's beyond all the superimpositions. Sometimes he doesn't fully understand my questions but I don't say anything on the chair because I know it was probably better for the Whole for me or my question not to be understood. He's a lot smarter than me because I still have psychology.

Bhagavan does not twist ancient teachings, they are not common Brahmin knowledge. Only a sage can speak like this and know these things. He took a Vedanta course when he was a jnani in Thiru but that is not where he got

his deep understanding of the ultimate path. I am progressing spiritually not because of my own sincerity and merit but because of Him. He is so smart, it's incredible to watch him, everything is perfectly calculated in his answers and he can speak about anything. He reads the questions first before answering. You can ask him anything except about your psychology or feelings. He only threatens to kick people out of the only path to Dharma when they deserve it. Fear can be a great teaching tool for a Buddha. That's why the world is so full of fear, only because it helps humanity. If Ramana used fear and punishments like kicking them off the path of the Dharma he would have enlightened more people.

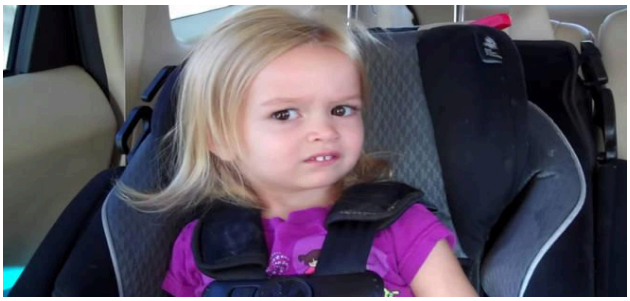
Everybody at the ashram is special and we got here by our merits to be able to sit with or serve Bhagavan. We got merit from previous lives and have the right Samskaras to be able to hear him. Bhagavan is our only chance at salvation in realizing the ultimate Truth. There's no other way for me to know myself without many many more lives to meet another Buddha again. I can't go anywhere else now because I do, I'd lose my only chance to get enlightenment and will suffer greatly if I turn away from Him. Any other Vedanta of today is wrong and only His way can help me. I wonder sometimes how long it would have taken me to find true liberation if I didn't come to Arunachala ashram. Now everything is much more clear for me.

People should take this opportunity otherwise they might be lost for many many bad lives and that would be terrible because they may not get another chance for thousands of years or longer. Bhagavan already said that it is so. And people who turn their back to this path or Him will go to hell. And they will have a bad life as soon as they go because The Vedas will curse them for going against them and Him. The Vedas have already cursed many who have left Him. Bhagavan knows the destiny of beings, he says he knows everything. We should listen to him. So one should come to our ashram and then they don't have to suffer in their next lives either. They can be finally liberated at death and experience that fullness when they are dead. Not now because he says it's not possible to be like him because it is so rare. Ramana was rare too but not as rare as Bhagavan. I'm saying the Truth, it may sound harsh, but that's the way it works. And it's better to know the harsh truth.

Bhagavan is waiting to transmit the Upanishads once the Rishis are satisfied with us. This is how it works in true Vedanta. The external Rishis impart the Teachings transmissions to the sage. The sage is not a walking Upanishad himself already until the students make him ready. He needs people and Rishis around him first. We need more sincere people to join us before he is able to be activated and transmit to the world the words of the rishis of other realms. It is our Great work. We are not good enough still. It's been many years I hear. Around 10 years at least people are waiting for the transformative teachings that will enlighten us. It was supposed to happen when the recruiters brought in more people but they brought the wrong people so He couldn't teach. I have learned so much about True Vedanta. I knew very little before. I knew a good amount of Tantra but most of those teachers

were bad teachers he says. I am lucky to have found Him even without previous Vedanta knowledge. I was chosen because of my past lives. I don't know much about the Upanishads nor Shankara but we don't need to read them because Bhagavan is speaking the words of the rishis. He doesn't need to teach the scriptures, that's why he doesn't do it. Maybe one day he will teach the Upanishads, that's what we are all expecting, it is for this that we need the right people in the group, the genuine seekers with the right samskaras. We need a big brain collectively to be able to understand the teachings he will channel.

But at his request right now it is important that we make positive spiritual reviews for our ashram. That's why I am writing about Arunachala Hridayam and making a stop to all these wrong stories about Him, the only Buddha of this age and our special Ashram. We can't have people spreading wrong thinking about our ashram. These internet posts with bad thinking may misinform people and ruin their only chance for liberation. And we need more people here too in order to be liberated. Any online damage made up of lies could interfere with the plan of the rishis to expand in Waynad and later into to other places to help enlighten people with the true and eternal path of liberation brought forth by the only living Master in all the Universe right now.



Appendix B: Christopher Titmuss's Ten Points to Remember If You Go to a Monastery or Centre in the East

Ten Points to Remember

If you go to a Monastery or Centre in the East.

Christopher Titmuss

Find out as much information as possible about the place and teachings before departure.

Take a sleeping bag. It can be cold at night.

Few Buddhist monasteries are vegetarian/vegan but will usually support a non-meat, non-fish diet.

Do not expect monasteries to be super silent. Festivals, weddings and traffic from the outside and building work etc from the inside the walls will impact on silence. If you cannot handle sound, then go to a Western centre.

Do not put yourself under a lot of pressure to go deep. A quietly meditative/mindful day in all postures will enable an organic experience of depth to develop.

Do not decide the value of a monastery or teachings within 10 days of staying there. You early response may not be the lasting one.

Remember practice includes letting go, equanimity, tolerance, patience and seeing through 'I' and 'my.'

Remember to be respectful and polite to the monks and nuns. You are the guest. The monastics host you even though they have not met you before.

Yes, Buddhism is patriarchal. Science is male dominated, too, with less than 20% in leadership roles in science.

Remember to offer a donation (dana) to the monastery. Place the money in an envelope with sum written on cover of envelope and offer to the Abbot with the name of the monastery and enclose with a few words of THANK YOU.